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Results from Qualitative Testing of the Annual Social and Economic Supplement of the Current Population Survey: Round 2 Cognitive Interviews to Prepare for Web-based Administration

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Call Order 011: Cognitive Interviews for ASEC Health Insurance, Medical Out of Pocket Expenses, Moving, Earned Income, Income Sources, and Poverty

Round 2 Briefing Report

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Any views expressed on the methodological issues are those of the authors and not necessarily those of the U.S. Census Bureau, RTI International, or Research Support Services. The report has been reviewed for disclosure avoidance and approved under DRB number: CBDRB-FY26-CBSM004-04.

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1. Executive Summary

The Current Population Survey (CPS) is an important source of data on U.S. employment and unemployment. Collected once a year within the CPS is the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC). ASEC collects data on income sources and amounts, participation in various economic support programs, health insurance, medical expenditures, child care, and moving. ASEC data support the creation of the Supplemental Poverty Measure and thus, are critically important to a broad array of data users.

In an effort to decrease costs while maintaining data quality, the Census Bureau set a goal to develop an internet self-administered (web) version of ASEC. A web version of this questionnaire presents many challenges, particularly with regards to respondent burden and data quality. To support the development of revised and new questions for web-administration of the ASEC instrument, RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS), previously conducted 60 one-on-one cognitive interviews, separately testing the health insurance and income sections of the instrument. This report details a second round of cognitive testing with similar methodology to further refine and revise the questions. The cognitive interviews focused on participants' interpretation of the questions and response options, and the accuracy of their response. The testing aimed to identify possible issues that may hinder a respondent's ability to select an answer, and gather feedback that can be used to revise the questions prior to fielding.

There were several cross-cutting findings and associated recommendations that came from this research, which are summarized below:

Health Insurance Module

- As a result of prior exploratory and cognitive testing, questions where participants had trouble interpreting items or response options as intended were modified to include clarifications and examples. Although these generally worked well, for some participants the parenthetical examples or qualifications proved somewhat confusing. This was the case, for instance, in a question asking about type of insurance coverage where a response option read, "Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plan)."
- Another issue was found with a term that performed well for most participants but was not understood by one: "uninsured." This was a finding in the question "Were you uninsured for part of 2024?" Although this appeared not to be a common problem, the data the question elicits are very important and it is crucial to have everyone understand and answer this item as intended.
- The response choice "Private health insurance not through a job" presented some difficulties. Some participants reporting coverage from "the Marketplace" or from "Obamacare" did not think this response applied to them. A participant without a job thought this option could not apply to them because it mentioned a job, which they did not have.

- **Medical out of pocket expenses:** An important issue remains in the Medical Out of Pocket Expenses section with possible double reporting of certain expenses between the question about coverage costs and other out of pocket costs. The transition sentence into this topic is necessary, but it could be simplified. In its current form it may be contributing to the double counting.

Migration Module

- **Reference dates:** The version of the item tested in this round did not include a reference date, and some participants were unsure about the reference period the question was asking about. Although most participants were able to interpret and answer the question without the inclusion of a reference date, a couple of participants either had trouble with recall or expressed they would have found the inclusion of a reference period date helpful.
- **Reasons for move:** For the 'reasons for move' migration questions, findings suggest that the list of response choices should be reviewed to identify any possible reductions and clarifications, as participants often found the list dauntingly long and some had difficulty selecting the option that best fit their situation. In addition, for those items that include the "No other reason" response choice, consider more prominently displaying this option through emphasis or spacing the response option to make it stand out.

Income Module

- **Proxy reporting:** Almost half of the participants in Round 2 indicated that they did not know the answer to a question at some point during the 'income sources' section of the interview when considering others in their household. This finding was also seen in Round 1. To address this, the response option "Someone in the household got [INCOME SOURCE], but I'm not sure what type" was added to items in this section. In Round 2 of testing, this response option was rarely used when participants were uncertain about income sources of others in their household, so it did not aid in their response process.
- **Double reporting instruction:** Round 1 of interviewing found that double reporting was a common problem, which was not an issue found in Round 2. To address the issue of double reporting found in Round 1, several items in the 'income sources' section included the instruction "Do not include anything you already reported." This instruction does appear to be helpful on some items (e.g., when an income source is likely to have been reported in a previous question) and appears to have addressed earlier issues with double reporting. However, this instruction is repeated on all items and, overall, participants found this instruction to be confusing and repetitive, especially when they were asked about an income source they had not been previously asked about in a prior question (e.g., unemployment). A few participants also interpreted this instruction to refer to reporting on taxes, which introduced additional confusion for them.

2. Introduction

This report details the results of 60 cognitive interviews that were conducted during the second round of cognitive testing for the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC). The instrument and tests were divided into two sections, broadly categorized as “health insurance” and “income”, with 30 interviews for each topic. The health insurance instrument included questions about health insurance coverage, medical out of pocket expenses, and moving (migration). The income instrument included questions about earned income, income sources and amounts, poverty (program participation), housing, child care, and child support. This section also included questions on moving (migration) when time allowed. Interviews were conducted by RTI International (RTI) and Research Support Services (RSS).

Cognitive testing consists of one-on-one in-person interviews to assess a questionnaire in terms of general comprehension, clarity and completeness of question and response wording, effectiveness of skip logic, and availability of help information. Census Bureau provided two separate and distinct cognitive protocols: one for health insurance and one for income. All protocols included the full set of questions tested in each interview, concurrent and retrospective probes for most questions, designation of the motivation for testing the question, and the desired output to be reported for each. Interviews were designed to take no more than 60 minutes.

The Census Bureau developed PowerPoint slide decks for each questionnaire that included jump-to navigation features to facilitate virtual interviewing. All interviews were conducted remotely and were recorded by interviewers. Following each interview, participants were provided with a \$40 Visa digital gift card as a token of appreciation for completing the interview.

Participants were recruited and selected based on pre-established targets/quotas approved by the Census Bureau. All efforts were made to reach these targets while providing an even distribution among demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, and household composition, among other criteria.

The RTI and RSS team used a systematic approach to analyze the cognitive interview data and address the research questions. Once the data were organized and analyzed, the teams wrote up their findings in a standardized format, including question-level responses from participants, key findings grouped by ‘report back’ questions provided by the Census Bureau, a summary of any overarching findings (where applicable), and recommendations for questions where issues were identified. These details provided the basis of this report.

3. Cognitive Methodology

This section provides details about the cognitive methodology, protocols, and procedures that were used during the ASEC health insurance and income cognitive interviews.

3.1 Methodology

The cognitive testing consisted of (virtual) one-on-one in-person interviews to assess the questionnaire in terms of general comprehension, clarity of question and response wording, effectiveness of skip logic, and visual aids. The goal was to gain an understanding of how well the questions work when administered to a sample of the survey's target population. The interviews followed a protocol with pre-scripted probes, administered either concurrently (i.e., directly after the question was answered) or retroactively (after a section of questions were completed), depending on the module. Cognitive interviewers also used spontaneous probes to gain a better understanding of participant feedback, when needed. Cognitive interviewing was used to:

- Learn about the respondents' thought processes while answering the questions;
- Measure the response process, including comprehension, retrieval, judgment, and response;
- Observe nonverbal, human reactions;
- Test navigation of the instrument;
- Assess the potential for measurement error in survey items;
- Examine potentially big or complex issues; and
- Gauge opinions on the survey as a whole.

3.2 Protocol

Census Bureau developed two separate and distinct protocols that focused on each of the two topic areas being explored in this study: one for health insurance (**Appendix D**) and one for income (**Appendix E**). Additionally, questions on migration were included as part of both protocols. RTI/RSS provided input and reviewed each protocol. Both protocols included the full set of questions included in each interview, along with probes on a subset of questions. Interviewers were instructed and trained to collect spontaneous feedback as needed.

Census Bureau developed a series of PowerPoint slide decks for each section of the health insurance and income instruments to facilitate virtual interviewing. Slide decks included with jump-to navigation programmed on question response options that allowed the interviewer to skip to the next appropriate slide in route to that response option. During the interview, interviewers shared their screen of the slide deck and asked participants to respond to the

questions shown on screen. Interviewers then 'selected' responses for the participant and navigated the slide deck instrument forward during the interview.

3.3 Interviews

All interviews were conducted remotely from June 11, 2025, through September 15, 2025, using Microsoft Teams within Census Bureau's secure Virtual Desktop Interface (VDI) environment or a Census Bureau issued laptop. Participants were assigned to either the health insurance protocol or the income protocol, depending on characteristics reported during screening. Questions on migration were included in both protocols. With permission from participants, interviewers audio recorded all sessions using handheld devices. Interviews were also recorded using Snagit software, which records both audio and video. Recordings were saved to the designated deliverable folder in the Census Bureau file share location. At the end of the interview, interviewers offered participants a \$40 Visa digital gift card code via email as a thank you for their time. Following each interview, interviewers or notetakers completed the appropriate case summary template for the topic area (i.e., health insurance or income).

Although the two protocols and respondent-facing instruments differed, each interview was conducted in the following sequence to standardize implementation. The interviewer:

- Explained the purpose of the study.
- Confirmed the participant had reviewed and signed the online consent form to participate in the study and be audio/video recorded (**Appendix C**).
- Started audio recording using an external audio recorder and Snagit software.
- Reconfirmed verbal consent to participate and be recorded once recording has started.
- Shared the respondent-facing instrument and asked participants to answer ASEC questions shown on screen.
- Administered probes to ASEC questions.
- Concluded the interview and sent the participant the incentive.
- Saved the recording within the Census Bureau's secure network environment in the designated file share folder.
- Completed the interview summary and saved it in the designated file share folder no more than 5 business days following each interview.

Before conducting cognitive interviews, all RTI/RSS interviewers were trained by Census Bureau on protocols for each topic area (i.e., health insurance or income) and other key procedures, including Title 13 requirements. Because each topic area used different protocols, two interviewer training sessions were held: one that focused on the health insurance protocol and one that focused on the income protocol. Due to the length and complexity of the interviews, all interviewers also completed a recorded practice interview before beginning interviews with participants. This practice interview was reviewed by RTI's

lead researcher, and feedback was provided to interviewers directly to prepare them for the main interviews.

3.4 Analysis

The RTI and RSS team used a systematic process to analyze the cognitive interview data and address the research questions. The case summaries were combined in Excel to provide a thorough data set for analysis, with participants presented in each row and interview probes presented in each column. Both teams analyzed data and wrote up their findings in a standardized format, including responses from participants, key findings, a summary of general findings (where applicable), and recommendations for questions that presented issues.

4. Participant Recruitment

This section provides an overview of participant recruitment strategies used to screen and select participants for the second round of ASEC income and health insurance cognitive interviews. This section includes 1) an overview of recruitment strategies across both the income and health insurance tasks and 2) targets and participant characteristics. The RTI/RSS team recruited participants from June through September 2025. The income recruitment began by leveraging the participant recruitment for the Current Population Survey (CPS) usability testing conducted from June through August 2024. First, the RTI/RSS team identified 151 prospective participants who were selected based on their eligibility for the CPS usability testing but were left uncontacted for participation. The team emailed each, inviting them to complete the ASEC online screener to determine their eligibility for ASEC cognitive interviews based on their demographics and current employment status.

Following this outreach, the RTI/RSS team identified numerous metropolitan areas across all four Census regions for recruitment: Philadelphia, Pennsylvania; Houston, Texas; Toledo, Ohio; Albuquerque, New Mexico; Detroit, Michigan; Charleston, West Virginia; Cleveland, Ohio; New Orleans, Louisiana; Phoenix, Arizona; Cincinnati, Ohio; Grand Rapids, Michigan; Kansas City, Missouri; Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania; Portland, Maine; Tucson, Arizona; Baltimore, Maryland; Boston, Massachusetts; Chicago, Illinois; Florida Keys, Florida; Las Vegas, Nevada; New Haven, Connecticut; San Diego, California; St. Louis, Missouri; Indianapolis, Indiana; Jacksonville, Florida; Providence, Rhode Island; Santa Fe, New Mexico; Milwaukee, Wisconsin; Omaha, Nebraska; Scranton, Pennsylvania; and Worcester, Massachusetts. The RTI/RSS team then posted online recruitment advertisements in these selected metropolitan areas, releasing advertisements on a rolling basis to maintain a steady stream of prospective participants for screening and scheduling. The team also conducted word-of-mouth outreach with the staff's personal networks specifically screening for individuals with the rarer primary characteristics that were underrepresented after approximately 8 weeks of data collection. The additional effort helped improve our recruitment outcomes with those who live alone or with unrelated individuals and those who are self-employed.

The Census Bureau programmed a web-based eligibility screening in Qualtrics. The RTI/RSS team also established a toll-free telephone line dedicated to recruitment purposes. The web link for the screening instrument and the toll-free phone number were presented in the online advertisements (see **Appendix A**).

During the data collection period, the RTI/RSS team provided the Census Bureau with a weekly recruitment and interviewing progress update report, reflecting results to date. The weekly report tallied the interview participants with respect to recruitment goals and needed

sub-characteristics. The results of ASEC cognitive interview recruitment presented in **Sections 4.3** and **4.4** of this report reflect the final recruitment outcomes.

4.1 Implementation of Recruitment Advertising

For the main online recruitment strategy, the RTI/RSS team used Craigslist as the primary venue for recruitment advertising. Craigslist is one of the best-known online bulletin boards and provides the most comprehensive coverage of metropolitan areas in the United States. To leverage Craigslist's broad reach, RTI/RSS did not use targeted advertisements that focused on specific characteristics and used a customized general advertisement instead (see **Appendix B** for recruitment materials and advertisement text).

The first round of monthly paid advertising started on May 22, 2025. The team posted general Craigslist advertisements in the metropolitan areas of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania; Houston, Texas; Toledo, Ohio; and Albuquerque, New Mexico. Several dozen potential participants completed the recruitment screener within 24 hours. Others continued to complete the screener at a consistent rate for approximately 1 week afterward. The RTI/RSS team recorded screening responses for more than 250 prospective participants from the first round of advertising.

The RTI/RSS team also launched an email outreach campaign to contact the previously screened but not contacted individuals on June 3, 2025.

On June 4, 2025, the RTI/RSS team then posted the general recruitment advertisement on Craigslist under the "jobs/et cetera" sections for five metropolitan areas across all four Census regions: Detroit, Michigan; Charleston, West Virginia; Cleveland, Ohio; New Orleans, Louisiana; and Phoenix, Arizona. Recruitment continued into September 2025. In July, the RTI/RSS staff reached out their personal networks to solicit participation from those who may fit our recruitment criteria and asked their personal contacts to refer the participant recruitment screener by word-of-mouth to others who might be eligible in their broader social circles.

The third round of paid advertising was posted on June 11, 2025. The team posted general advertisements for Cincinnati, Ohio; Grand Rapids, Michigan; Kansas City, Missouri; Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania; Portland, Maine; and Tucson, Arizona.

The team posted the fourth round of general advertisements for Baltimore, Maryland; Boston, Massachusetts; Chicago, Illinois; Florida Keys, Florida; Las Vegas, Nevada; New Haven, Connecticut; San Diego, California; and St. Louis, Missouri on June 18, 2025. All Craigslist ads were removed on June 27, 2025, to coincide with loss in access to the Qualtrics screener.

Once Qualtrics access was restored in August 2025, the team posted two additional rounds of general advertisements. The fifth round of paid advertising for Indianapolis, Indiana;

Jacksonville, Florida; Providence, Rhode Island; and Sante Fe, New Mexico was posted on August 6. The sixth and final round of general advertising was posted for Milwaukee, Wisconsin; Omaha, Nebraska; Scranton, Pennsylvania; and Worcester, Massachusetts on August 20, 2025.

4.1.1 Participant Selection Strategy

To facilitate efficient screening review and participant selection across subprojects, the team created a main intake tracker sheet to import the screening responses from Qualtrics. Interested participants were reviewed to ensure they met the main eligibility criteria (e.g., Age 18+) and one or more of the recruitment criteria (outlined in the Exhibits).

Participant screening responses were reviewed to determine whether they fit within one or more of the quotas that were established. Next, the team reviewed all prospective participants on the intake sheet, focusing on contact information self-reports and the IP addresses in the paradata. RTI removed duplicate entries from the same individuals, any entries identified as past participants, ineligible entries from foreign IP addresses, and any potentially fraudulent cases that were identified during recruitment (e.g., IP addresses did not match city/state the respondent reported in screener).

The RTI/RSS team determined protocol assignment (e.g., Health Insurance or Income) and participant selection priority. Within the main intake spreadsheet, the ASEC Health Insurance recruitment tracker and ASEC Income recruitment tracker were separated to account for different criteria and separate recruitment efforts. The lead recruiter reviewed the participants to ensure key quotas were fulfilled and selected participants for the RTI/RSS recruiters to contact.

During data collection, RTI/RSS team processed and reviewed the screening data at least once a week to select eligible participants for an interview. After a batch of screening data was reviewed, about 1 week would elapse before new assignments would be made to allow recruiters sufficient time to contact their existing assignments. Team members contacted participants and scheduled interviews, sending a confirmation email with all the information needed to take part in the remote interview. Because access to Qualtrics was lost in June 2025, the RTI team front-loaded recruitment efforts as a way to build an ample screener sample to draw from later in the interviewing period. To retain participants who screened into the study early in the data collection period but would not be invited to participate in an interview until later in the data collection time frame, RTI/RSS sent email communication in June 2025 letting them know that they could expect to hear from a recruiter in July or August.

4.1.2 ASEC Cognitive Interview Recruitment Outcomes

The RTI team completed 30 cognitive interviews for the Income module, and the RSS team completed 30 cognitive interviews for the Health Insurance module. Questions on migration were included in both protocols and resulted in 36 participants.

In total, RTI selected and contacted an additional 68 eligible participants for the Income module; 49 participants did not respond to the invitation, 3 participants refused during recruitment, 8 did not show up for their scheduled interview, and 2 decided to withdraw their participation after they were scheduled for an interview. Another 6 cases were determined to be potentially fraudulent responses based on the recruiters' communication with the individuals.

RSS also selected and contacted an additional 30 eligible participants for the Health Insurance module; 18 participants did not respond to the invitation, 1 participant refused during recruitment, 3 did not show up for their scheduled interview, and 2 withdrew their participation after they were scheduled for an interview. Another 6 cases were determined to be potentially fraudulent responses based on the recruiters' communication with the individuals.

4.2 Health Insurance Participants

Exhibit 4-1 details the distribution of the completed ASEC cognitive interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of health insurance. It includes the required recruitment targets of participants who are older or younger than 65, who are the policy holder on their own insurance, who have access to health care, who have experienced a life event, as well as those whose employment affects their insurance status. Various household composition targets are also included.

Exhibit 4-2 further presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the health insurance cognitive interview participants.

All criteria were met during interviewing.

Exhibit 4-1. Primary Participant Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Primary Criteria		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Age: Under 65	19	18
Age: 65+	11	9
Policy holder: No	5	At least 5
Access to care: No	6	At least 5

Primary Criteria		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Life event: At least one	23	At least 12
Spell of unemployment	18	At least 5
Nonstandard work	19	At least 5
Medicaid	11	At least 5
Lives with at least one other person (Primary criteria)	26	At least 24
Lives with unrelated individuals	11	At least 10
Lives with immediate family	16	At least 9
Lives with extended family	6	At least 5
Lives with children	8	At least 7

Exhibit 4-2. Secondary Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Sex	-	-
Male	15	At least 12
Race/Ethnicity	-	-
Non-white non-Hispanic	12	At least 5
Hispanic	5	At least 5
Geography	-	-
Northeast	5	At least 5
Midwest	4	At least 5
West	10	At least 5
South	11	At least 5
Education	-	-
Less than college degree	13	At least 10
College graduate	11	At least 5
Post-graduate	6	At least 5
Age	-	-
18–35	4	At least 5
36–50	10	At least 5
51–64	7	At least 5
65+	11	At least 9
Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone	11	At least 6

4.3 Income Participants

Exhibit 4-3 details the distribution of the completed ASEC cognitive interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of income. It includes the required recruitment targets of participants who received income from retirement or pensions, those who received income from unemployment benefits or workers compensation, those who are self-employed, participants with a second job or side hustle, and those who participate in a social assistance program.

Exhibit 4-4 further presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the participants of the income cognitive interviews.

All criteria were met during interviewing.

Exhibit 4-3. Primary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews

Primary Criteria		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Retirement/pensions	13	At least 10
Unemployment/workers comp	5	At least 5
Self-employment	8	At least 5
Second job/side hustle	7	At least 3
Program participation	12	At least 5
Household Composition		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Lives with at least one other person (Primary criteria)	26	At least 24
Lives with unrelated individuals	10	At least 10
Lives with immediate family	19	At least 14
Lives with children 13 or younger (Primary criteria)	7	At least 7

Exhibit 4-4. Secondary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews

Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Sex	-	-
Male	12	At least 12
Race/Ethnicity	-	-
Non-white non-Hispanic	5	At least 5
Hispanic	5	At least 5
Geography	-	-
Northeast	10	At least 5
Midwest	8	At least 5
West	5	At least 5
South	7	At least 5
Education	-	-
Less than college degree	14	At least 10
College graduate	6	At least 5
Post-graduate	10	At least 5
Age	-	-
18–35	10	At least 5
36–50	5	At least 5
51–64	5	At least 5
65+	13	At least 12
Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone	13	At least 6

5. Question by Question Results – Health Insurance

This section presents results and recommendations, where appropriate, for ASEC Health Insurance questions. Findings in this section are presented by topic, with findings from the cognitive interviews listed first followed by recommendations. Each question is formatted with the following elements:

- **Question text and response options** that were shown to the participants during cognitive interviewing. Each question is followed by the total number and the counts for each response option.
- **Summary** findings, where applicable (e.g., questions that included significant or overarching findings or recommendations).
- **Findings** grouped by and detailing the answers to key research questions provided by Census Bureau (i.e., from the report back templates).
- **Recommendations** for question changes, when appropriate.

The goal of cognitive interviewing is to collect qualitative feedback from participants about their response process when providing an answer to each question. We have included a report of the responses to each question (i.e., the quantitative data) to provide context for the findings. This response data comes from the response recorded in the notes during the interview. Participants are not required to provide an answer, and thus the total sample who saw the question (“n”) may differ from the total number of responses in some cases.

5.1 Health Insurance Questions

Question 1 (n=30)

Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.

- 1 Yes (29)
- 2 No (1)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- Of the 30 participants, 29 answered without any issues. One, however, answered No to having health insurance in 2024. This participant later explained in probing that they answered “No” because the question mentions Medicare and healthcare.gov, and they did not have those types of health insurance; instead, they had insurance through a job. They appeared to have missed the mention of “through a job” in the question. [P4453]

Recommendations:

To avoid the rare confusion as occurred with the participant who first answered “No,” the instruction “Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.” could be removed. In Round 1, this question did not have such clarification, and no issues arose that suggested additional instructions needed to be added (only those having other types of insurance did not consider public coverage).

Question 2 (n=30)

Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

- 1 Insurance through a job (yours or another family member’s) (7)
- 2 Private health insurance not through a job (2)
- 3 Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans) (11)
- 4 Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid) (8)
- 5 Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) (0)
- 6 TRICARE or other military health care (0)
- 7 Indian Health Service (0)
- 8 Something else (2)
- 9 Not sure (0)
- 10 No health insurance (0)

Findings:

Do the new or revised response options “Insurance through a job,” “Private health insurance not through a job,” and “Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)” make sense?

- Overall, the revised response option “Insurance through a job” generally worked well.
- However, three participants who selected “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Something else” should have selected other options but did not think those other options applied to them. They were still confused with the “Private health insurance not through a job” answer option.
- One participant who had initially reported having “Private health insurance not through a job,” selected “Something else.” They explained that they were looking for “Healthcare.gov” or “Obamacare” in the list of answer options. Although they selected “Something else,” the interview was conducted using the “Private health insurance not through a job” questions. When asked what they understood by private health insurance not through a job, this participant explained:
 - “So, when I’m seeing it listed like that as ‘private health insurance not through a job,’ it could be the same types of policies or even through the same companies, but it’s the ... like that ... that to me leads more to the full price payment. If that makes sense. Like I’m paying, like it’s insurance, but I just really, really want that insurance, so I’m paying full price.” [P3199]

- A second participant answered they had insurance through the “Marketplace.” Because they didn’t find that in the list of answer options, they selected “Something else.” In screening, this participant indicated they had Medicaid coverage, but because they mentioned the Marketplace, the interviewer switched to the “Private health insurance not through a job” protocol. This participant later confirmed they had private health insurance they had gotten through the state marketplace; however, they considered [State] health insurance plan “another category.” [P5285]
- A third participant selected “private health insurance” but said they were not sure about their answer. They said they had also considered selecting “Not sure” and “Something else,” and explained:
 - “Because I thought that, I had already kind of quickly looked at the other options, and that was the only one that I thought may have applied to me. I really used the process of elimination really quickly. I knew the other ones did not apply to me. So, I knew that I had health insurance, so I figured that it was like through, that it was through a private institution or something like that.” [P3127]
- Another participant had an unusual situation where their job pays for their health insurance premium, but the participant obtained it through the marketplace. In screening, they indicated having “Private health insurance not through a job”; however, during the interview, they answered, “Insurance through a job” and explained:
 - “Ah, just maybe, stop, maybe just slow down just a little bit more and maybe cuz my own, my situation’s a little bit unique with you know it’s through the marketplace it’s kind of individual but it’s kind of paid through the job ‘cuz kind of slowing down and, two things can be true, but which one is more true than another.” [P5054]
- Most (n=16) Medicare and Medicaid recipients understood clearly the difference between “insurance through a job” and “private health insurance not through a job,” although three participants thought of the “not through a job option” as only Obamacare [P3210; P4083] or insurance obtained from healthcare.gov. [P3885] Others interpreted these two options as intended (i.e., where premiums are privately paid by the insured person versus one where the employer pays all or part of a premium). However, one of these participants was unsure how “private health insurance not through a job” is obtained, and explained:
 - “...maybe like a private doctor did it or something like... you got it, kind of a unique way through the business.” [P3246]
- One participant did not see the difference between the two options.
 - “I don’t have a job, and I didn’t get private health insurance through the job, so I don’t have a job, so these don’t apply to me.” The interviewer had the participant look carefully at the two options again for differences between the two options. “Insurance through a job or private health insurance not through a job, I understand if you have a job ... and they offer you health insurance, you have the option to get it through your job or if I had a spouse, so those didn’t apply to me.” [P3805]

Was the information in parentheses helpful to participants?

- All participants were asked whether the information in parentheses regarding the “insurance through a job” option was helpful to them, and all but 2 found it

useful. These 2 [P3667, P4153] said they had not paid attention to what was between parentheses because it did not apply to them. After rereading it, one found it helpful, while the other was confused and didn't know what it meant:

- "Uh, I paid attention to it, I was trying to find out to understand. I know I had my insurance through a job. I don't know, I didn't put any context on 'yours or another family member's.' I don't know what that means. It was confusing at it." [P3667]
- Of the 11 Medicare recipients, 3 [P3324, P3698, P4083] felt that specifying in parentheses different types of Medicare plans was unnecessary, as seeing "Medicare" was all they needed to know that was the option for them to select. One participant [P3210] found it unhelpful because the mention of "any Advantage or supplemental plans" confused them as they did not know what those were. However, the participants who have a Medicare Advantage plan liked that it was mentioned in parentheses and found it helpful.
- The 8 Medicaid participants generally thought it was useful because it helped distinguish that different plans fall under Medicare.
- Among the 9 non-Medicare, non-Medicaid participants, 7 thought the information in parentheses for the Medicare option was helpful.

Recommendations:

Consider dropping the information in parentheses for Medicare. This information appeared unnecessary and, on occasion, was confusing. Consider additional testing in 2026.

For the option "Private health insurance not through a job," we recommend considering a reference to the Marketplace to address the rare situation where someone does not feel the Marketplace falls under that response choice.

Question 2a (n=7)

How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)? Select all that apply.

- 1 Current job (yours or another family member's) (6)
- 2 Former job (yours or another family member's) (1)
- 3 Union or professional association (0)
- 4 Student insurance through university (0)
- 5 No response (0)

Findings:

What do participants who select "Student Insurance" think about the wording "through university"? Do they think it includes colleges that are not universities?

- This question was administered only to those reporting coverage through a job and none of them reported having "student insurance through university." Therefore, we were unable to test how that response category performed.
- One of the participants [P3693] who received insurance through a family member's job asked whether "former job" also included retirement. In their case, their spouse had retired but continued to receive benefits from that company.

They did, however, correctly select the “through a job” option despite their hesitation.

Recommendations:

Although not likely to be a frequent situation, there are retirees who receive their own or a family member’s health benefits from a pre-retirement job. Consider rewording the “former job” category to include the idea of the benefits occurring after retirement. Although our participant in this situation found the correct response, their hesitation suggests that others may not.

Question 2b (n=3)

How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job? Select all that apply.

- 1 State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov) (3)
- 2 Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member (0)
- 3 Broker (0)
- 4 Student insurance through university (0)

Findings:

How did participants understand the response options, especially “marketplace” and “purchased directly”?

- The two participants [P3127, P3335] who reported having private health insurance not through a job selected “State or Federal Marketplace” for this question without any problem. Another participant who had answered “Something else” at Q2 was skipped over this question but was later shown it during probing (the interviewer used the “Private health insurance not through a job” protocol). This participant who had looked for “Healthcare.gov” or “Obamacare” in the list of answer options for Q2, explained during probing, when asked about Q2b:
 - “It would be the first one, the ‘State or federal marketplace’ because that’s another common way of identifying the healthcare.gov, it’s just the healthcare marketplace, so the state or marketplace would have fit in there.” [PROBE: Okay, but you still do not think about that when you read private health insurance?] “No, when I read private health, just private health insurance by itself, it doesn’t lead me to ‘marketplace.’” [P3199]
- Although Q2 might not have worked as intended for participants who answered, “something else,” the options in Q2b redirected them to the correct place. All four participants understood “Marketplace” as a way to get health insurance, but their definitions varied. One participant thought of it as a general place “where you could go to shop and buy things and purchase things,” either online or in person. [P3127] Another participant saw it as an online spot with different insurance options. [P3335] The third participant connected it directly to Healthcare.gov and described it as being different from “Private” health insurance. [P3199] Another participant described it as a state-run selection of health insurance plans where costs depend on income. [P5285]

- When asked if “Purchased directly from an insurance company” was different from “Marketplace,” three participants clearly saw the difference. The first participant saw Marketplace as something provided through taxpayer or government support, while purchasing directly meant paying for insurance yourself. [P3127] Another participant explained that purchasing directly was used when specific plans were not available on the Marketplace. The third participant said Marketplace involves using Healthcare.gov to see what subsidies you qualify for, while purchasing directly means contacting an insurance company on your own and paying without government help. [P3199] This probe was not asked to the fourth participant. [P5285]
- None of the other participants reported having “student insurance through university.” Therefore, we were unable to test how that response category performed.

Are any other response options needed?

- No need for additional options emerged.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 2c (n=0)

How did you get your health insurance in 2024? Select all that apply.

- 1 Current job (yours or another family member’s)
- 2 Former job (yours or another family member’s)
- 3 Union or professional association
- 4 State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- 5 Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- 6 Broker
- 7 Student insurance through university
- 8 Some other way
- 9 Not sure

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 2d (n=0)

What kind of health insurance did you have?

- 1 Church
- 2 Charity care
- 3 HealthShare

4 Other [write in]

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 2e (n=0)

Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 2f (n=0)

What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- 1 Medical doctor's office
- 2 Clinic or hospital clinic
- 3 Hospital emergency room
- 4 Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- 5 Some other place
- 6 No one place

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 4c (n=11)

Whose name was this insurance in?

- 1 My name (8)

- 2 Adult 2 (3)
- 3 Adult child (18 or older) (0)
- 4 Someone outside the household (0)
- 5 No response (0)

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the Medicare or Medicaid recipients.

Understanding of question with 'policyholder' excluded.

- Of the 11 participants who answered this question, 10 understood it as asking whose name the insurance policy is under, whether it was in their own name, a spouse's name, or another family member's.
- One participant found the question confusing because their insurance card was in their own name, even though the coverage was provided through their spouse's employer. They clarified that each had a separate policy.
 - "Whose name was this insurance in? So, insurance through the job is on my name, the card is on my name. I just got ... it's confusing because it's not through my work, it's through the work of my spouse." [P3693]

For some participants, this was the first of several questions that showed the type of insurance under the question, rather than as a fill in the question. How do participants like/understand that?

- Participants were asked if they noticed the type of insurance listed below the question and how they felt about it. Three participants said they saw the insurance type but didn't react; they treated it as just an identifier.
 - "It's kind of just a continuing identifier; I guess at this point." [P3199]
 - "I did see that." [Do you have any reaction to that?] "Not really. I mean, I know my insurance is through my employer." [P4153]
 - "Insurance through the job ... again it is the retiree aspect of it, because it could be through the job.... No, it was clear, through the job." [P3693]
- Two participants felt it confirmed their earlier answer and helped avoid mistakes.
 - "I think that is just clarifying the answer I placed to the previous question to make sure. You know, I made the right choice, because I don't have to go back to be corrected." [So, you think it's helpful?] "Yea ma'am." [P3335]
 - "It's because that was my initial answer and so I feel like once I made, once you entered that answer that I initially said that the program or the algorithm possibly automatically incorporated that subtitle in all of the questions after that, because that's the question, that that's the answer that I gave so that's the subtext of the answers that we're looking for." [P3127]
- Two participants thought repeating the insurance type was fine but unnecessary. One suggested it could be included in the main question instead.
 - "So, for me, I just feel like it's excess actually putting it on there. But again, it's still something that's showing you that, okay, this is what you actually choose. And we're asking, this question that we're actually asking you is based on the previous answer that you actually gave, so for me it's fair for

me, but again I feel like I think that can still be added to the main question to see if it makes sense.” [P3665]

- “Yeah, you are right. It does show up, and while it may seem redundant, it makes sense.” [P3153]
- One participant said they didn’t really notice the repeated insurance type under the question.
- One participant was not asked the probe related to the health insurance type fill.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 4d (n=0)

Did an employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 4e (n=0)

Did an employer or union pay all or part of the cost of the insurance?

- 1 All
- 2 Part

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 4f (n=0)

Did you receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to pay for the insurance?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 5 (n=30)

How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

- 1 All year (28)
- 2 Part of the year (2)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

- All but one of the Medicare recipients had Medicare all year in 2024. The participant who answered “Part of the year” indicated they were uncovered until they started receiving Medicare coverage “in May or June.”
- One participant [P4458] who answered “all year,” thought the intent of the question was to know how long ago they had started getting Medicare and questioned why it said “in 2024”:
 - “...I think the question is a little confusing when they ask you, how long did you have it in 2024? I will just ask you, how long have you had this insurance, period? 6 years or 10 years, it doesn’t matter. How long have you had this type of health insurance? Why did they put the ‘in 2024’? It’s assuming that maybe you got it. I don’t know, you know, this is for a sentence or whatever it’s for, but I would just ask how long have you had this type of health insurance that you currently have?”
- Medicaid recipients interpreted the question as asking about all of 2024, without issues. However, later in the interview at Q20, a participant [P3490] who had answered “All year” in this question asked why there was no question about themselves being uninsured at any time in 2024. The interviewer reminded them that they had answered “All year” in Q5, to which the participant said they had actually been uninsured for about 4 months in 2024. Therefore, they had answered Q5 in error.
- All “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients had the same type of health insurance all year in 2024.

For some participants, this was the first of several questions that showed the type of insurance under the question, rather than as a fill in the question. How do participants like/understand that?

- Participants were probed on whether it was helpful to have their type of insurance listed immediately after the question. In interpreting this probe, several Medicare participants focused again on the text between parentheses listing Medicare programs and indicated those details were confusing, as they had indicated in Q2.

- All but three of the eight Medicaid recipients had no reaction to the type of insurance being listed after the question. Two felt it was useful:
 - “I think it’s helpful still.... If it wasn’t there ... when I see just ‘health insurance’, I don’t know, my brain thinks ‘private.’” [P3515]
 - I would keep it the same way it is in the question. Yeah, I would keep that the same way because it gives a description of what exactly it is.” [P4044]
- The third participant [P3246] appeared confused by the question listing the specific type of health insurance. They did not say anything while answering the question but during probing they asked if it was listed because they have state Medicaid and not just Medicaid. They wondered if there was a difference between the two.
 - Of the 11 participants who had “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job,” only two were probed about their type of insurance being listed after the question. One participant did not have any reaction, and the other acknowledged it could be helpful to other people answering these questions.
 - “Honestly, I hadn’t paid much attention to it coming up again. I think it’s not really necessary to have it coming up again and.... You know, once I knew the type of insurance I chose, but for some people, it might be helpful for them to keep coming up and trying to remind them of what your option was.” [P3667]

Recommendations:

No recommendations for changes. Listing the type of insurance right after the question did not confuse anyone and it may have been helpful for those who had more than one type of insurance coverage.

Question 6 (n=30)

Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision.

- 1 Yes (9)
- 2 No (21)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- Three Medicare recipients [P4290, P4592, P3101] answered Yes, but only one of these participants [P3101] actually had additional coverage (Medicaid). Another one of these participants thought the question was possibly repetitive and was asking for further details, so they answered that they had Medicare Advantage. Another interpreted the exclusions mentioned in the question as whether they did have dental, drug, and vision coverage (rather than not to include such plans) and said Yes because their Advantage plan has such coverages. A participant who had initially volunteered in Q2 that they had both Medicare and Medicaid

coverage assumed this question asked for any coverage other than what they had already mentioned and therefore said No [P3805].

- Among the eight Medicaid recipients, two [P3101, P3490] said Yes, one of them reporting they had Medicare concurrently. The other participant had changes in coverage throughout the year depending on their job situation: when working and having access to insurance through their job, they took that coverage, but when out of work, they would revert to Medicaid. Thus, their two types of coverage were not concurrent. All others who said No were consistent in reporting only Medicaid coverage in 2024.
- Of the 11 “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients, four [P3153, P3667, P3693, P4153] reported having another type of health insurance in 2024. Two reported this correctly, with one accurately reporting having Medicare in addition to their insurance through a job. A second participant initially answered “No” to the question about additional insurance; however, they recalled previously mentioning their Veterans Affairs (VA) insurance and corrected their response to “Yes.” Because the participant had referenced VA insurance earlier (Q2) but appeared confused when asked again, the interviewer probed further to determine if it was confusing to be asked about it again. The participant explained that the wording could be clearer if framed as “supplementary” or “secondary insurance.” They confirmed that they consider VA coverage their secondary insurance, which is why they answered “Yes.”
 - “If you are going to make it sound like it’s a secondary, I would put, ‘Do you have a supplementary or secondary health insurance?’ To ask, ‘Do you have another type?’ in my case, I thought you were talking about the VA one again.” [P3153]
- The other two reporting having additional health insurance in 2024 were false positives. One of them [P4153] first answered “Yes” to having another type of health insurance but clarified that they were referring to dental coverage. They explained that they see health insurance as a broad category that includes medical, vision, and dental plans, which is why they included all of these in their response. When rereading the instructions (do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision), they realized they had misinterpreted the question. Even though the participant confirmed only having insurance through a job, which included vision and dental, they still chose to answer “Yes” because they viewed dental insurance as another form of health insurance. The other false positive [P3667] was a participant who initially answered “Yes” because they were thinking about their family’s Medicaid coverage in 2024. During probing, they realized it was asking only about their own insurance and changed their answer to “No.” When asked why they thought about their family while answering this question, the participant suggested that other survey questions may have prompted them to focus on their family coverage; however, it wasn’t clear what questions they were talking about.

Recommendations:

The participants did not select by themselves the answer to Q2 and instead answered verbally. When they did so, they often told the interviewer more than one type of coverage, but Q2 was not a multiple response question. Thus, only one type of coverage was recorded. When asked Q6, some thought the question was repetitive or that they had

already given this answer. Because this is not going to happen in production with self-administration, we do not recommend changes.

Question 7 (n=8)

What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

- 1 Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's) (3)
- 2 Private health insurance not through a job (0)
- 3 Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans) (2)
- 4 Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid) (1)
- 5 Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) (1)
- 6 TRICARE or other military health care (0)
- 7 Indian Health Service (0)
- 8 Something else (1)
- 9 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- One Medicare recipient correctly reported on their secondary coverage (insurance through their job). One Medicaid recipient consistently chose insurance through a job as they had explained in Q6. One participant with coverage through their job accurately reported additionally having Medicare.
- Those who answered in error in Q6 continued down this path and again answered in error. One Medicare recipient selected Medicare again and specified it was Advantage, while one Medicaid recipient thought that the question was asking about any other health insurance and chose "something else" to report on their dental and vision plan. Another participant with VA coverage in Q2 reported it here again.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 8 (n=3)

How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

- 1 Current job (yours or another family member) (1)
- 2 Former job (yours or another family member) (0)
- 3 Union or professional association (1)
- 4 Student insurance through university (0)
- 5 No Response (1)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question. The question was identical to Q2a.

Recommendations:

The recommendations for Q2a apply here as well. No changes recommended.

Question 9 (n=0)

How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- 1 State or Federal Marketplace
- 2 Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- 3 Broker
- 4 Student insurance through university

Findings:

None of the participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 11 (n=3)

Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- 1 Yes (3)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- One of the Medicare participants answered this question and said Yes. They did not start receiving Medicare coverage until May or June of 2024.
- One Medicaid recipient that answered "Yes" appeared to misinterpret the term "uninsured." Although we did not probe on the term, the participant volunteered their confusion:
 - "Uninsured? What is that? [What do you think it means?] "Out of work ... Unemployed at the time."
- This was not answered by "Private health insurance not through a job" and "Insurance through a job" recipients.

Recommendations:

Given some evidence of the term “uninsured” possibly being problematic, we recommend rewording as “Were you without health insurance at any point in 2024?”

Question 15job (n=10)

Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

- 1 Yes (6)
- 2 No (4)

Findings:

Were the participants thinking of their insurance through a job that they just reported about or any insurance through any job?

- This question was only asked to 10 of the 11 “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients. The type of insurance referenced by “this” type of insurance in the question appeared below the question.
- Among the seven participants who reported having insurance through a job, three interpreted the question broadly, thinking about insurance through any job rather than the specific policy they had been discussing. One participant [P3667] explicitly said “through a job in general.” Another participant [P3153] said they were thinking “just insurance in general,” referring to their spouse’s job insurance.
- The third participant, who had answered “No” to this question, explained that they were thinking about “insurance in general,” but described it in terms of their own coverage, noting that their spouse was a homemaker and didn’t have the same benefits.
 - “Was actually thinking about it in general. Basically, it’s been stated that through insurance from my job. So, definitely, I’m actually thinking about insurance through my job. And the question is, if anyone else in my house would have that same type of insurance. So, basically, my wife is a homemaker. She doesn’t actually kind of have that kind of job that actually offers all those things that my job do offer, so definitely.” [P3665]
- Two participants explained that they were thinking about their own or their spouse’s specific insurance policy. The first participant [P3693] said they were thinking specifically about their spouse’s retirement program insurance, which covers both of them, noting that they have separate policy numbers. The second participant [P5054] said they were initially thinking about their own insurance policy through their job because they misread the question. They later corrected their response thinking about the type of insurance in general.
- Three of the four participants with private insurance not through a job answered “Yes” to this question and explained that they thought about the type of health insurance broadly, not necessarily within the same policy.
 - “So, I was thinking about my spouse because we’re both on the same policy, but also at the same time thinking about the [18-25 year old] because, like I

- said, he has the same type of policy through the marketplace, he just has his own separate policy.” [P3199]
- “Yes, my daughter has her own insurance through another [State] health marketplace plan.” [P5285]
 - “No, I was thinking specifically about the marketplace that the state and federal marketplace that we were talking about because again, it’s the same exact plan that he has.... He has his own separate policy, and I have mine.” [P3127]
 - The fourth participant answered “No” and explained that they didn’t know much about the health insurance of other household members. [P3335]
 - Another participant [P4453] said the wording felt repetitive or contradictory compared to earlier questions. They were unable to specify which questions they meant. The last participant [P4153] did not answer this question because they lived alone.

Recommendations:

To address the fact that some participants were more narrowly thinking only of their specific policy instead of the type of insurance, the question could be reworded as *Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024 (even if they were covered under a different policy)?*

Question 16*job (n=7)*

Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

- 1 Adult 2 (6)
- 2 Adult child (18 or older) (1)
- 3 Child 1 (under 18) (0)
- 4 Child 2 (under 18) (0)
- 5 Child 3 (under 18) (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- This was not asked of any of the Medicare or Medicaid recipients. None of the “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients who answered this question had any difficulty understanding how they would record their answers.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 17*job (n=7)*

How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

People in Household	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	(6)	(0)
Adult child (18 or older)	(1)	(0)
Child 1 (under 18)	(0)	(0)
Child 2 (under 18)	(0)	(0)
Child 3 (under 18)	(0)	(0)

Findings:

- This was not answered by any of the Medicare or Medicaid recipients. None of the “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients who answered this question had any difficulty understanding how they would record their answers.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 18job (n=6)

Whose name was [Person in Q17_job]’s insurance in?

- 1 My name (0)
- 2 Adult 2 (5)
- 3 Adult Child (18 or older) (1)
- 4 Someone outside the household (0)
- 5 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- This was not answered by any of the Medicare or Medicaid recipients. None of the “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients who answered this question expressed any difficulty understanding it.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 19job1 (n=4)

Did [^Person in Q18_job]’s employer or union help pay for [^Person in Q17_job]’s insurance?

- 1 Yes (3)

- 2 No (1)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question. This was not answered by any of the Medicare or Medicaid recipients.

- Of the 11 “Private health insurance not through a job” and “Insurance through a job” recipients, four were asked this question; three of them answered “Yes,” and one answered “No.” These positives and negatives reflected different levels of certainty. One participant who answered “Yes” explained:
 - “About 50 percent sure that they pay for part of the insurance, which is probably why it was way cheaper than the other one.” [P3153]

Did participants experience any confusion from seeing the same name inserted from different previous questions?

- The participant who answered “No” found the question confusing at first, although they answered correctly. They noted that it felt “tricky” because they interpreted it as asking whether Adult 2’s employer or union helped pay for Adult 2’s insurance. They clarified that in their case, Adult 2 (their mother) was covered under “somebody outside the household” (their father’s) policy, so the insurance was not connected to her own employer or union, and therefore, the answer would be “No” [P5054]. Their confusion was related to having the same name from different questions.

Recommendations:

No change recommended. In production, the automated fills would eliminate any confusion regarding who the question is about and whose insurance it refers to.

Question 19job2 (n=3)

Did [^Person in Q18_job]’s employer or union pay all or part of the cost of [^Person in Q17_job]’s insurance?

- 1 All (1)
- 2 Part (2)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

Did participants experience confusion because of the two different names inserted from different questions?

No probes were administered for this question. No confusion was noticed due to the insertion of names from different questions.

- Of the three participants who answered this question, only one showed confusion. This participant [P4453] did not interpret the question as referring to the cost of

having insurance, that is, the cost of premiums. They interpreted the question as asking about deductibles. They said that for the first claim in a year, they have to pay the deductible themselves, but after that, the insurance covers the rest of the costs.

Recommendations:

To reduce the chances of misinterpretation, the question could be phrased as: Did [^Person in Q18_job]'s employer or union pay all or part of the cost of [^Person in Q17_job] insurance coverage?

Question 15m (n=14)

Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

- 1 Yes (6)
- 2 No (8)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

Were participants thinking about the specific policy, or more generally about any government-sponsored insurance?

This question was only asked of Medicare/Medicaid' recipients.

- Eight of the Medicare recipients were asked this question and none of them thought the question was about their specific policy. Two of them were among those who answered Yes, and in both cases, they were referring to a household member also having their own Medicare coverage.
- Among the six Medicaid participants who lived with others and were asked this question [P3246, P3490, P3514, P3515, P3705, P4044], only one was thinking about their own specific Medicaid policy [P3490]. However, another participant who lives with their child clarified that the probe did not necessarily apply to them:
 - "Like, that's just how it is with our state. If you're on State Medicaid, your children are included under it with you." [P4044]
- A participant reported some difficulty answering this question because they moved and changed households multiple times in 2024, which made the answer to the question be Yes sometimes in the year and No at some other times. They answered Yes after giving it some consideration. [P3515]

Recommendations:

No change recommended. However, if Q15job is changed as recommended, the same change should be made here.

Question 16m (n=9)

Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

- 1 Adult 2 (4)
- 2 Adult child (18 or older) (1)
- 3 Child 1 (under 18) (2)
- 4 Child 2 (under 18) (1)
- 5 No response (1)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question. This question was only asked of Medicaid and Medicare recipients.

- The two Medicare recipients easily chose Adult 2 as the other person with the same type of coverage. Among the four Medicaid participants, this was also easy to answer except for the same person who reported difficulty selecting Yes or No in Q15m because of changing household frequently in 2024. In Q16m, the participant was simply unable to give an answer.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Question 17m (n=9)

How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

People in Household	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	(3)	(1)
Adult child (18 or older)	(1)	(0)
Child 1 (under 18)	(2)	(0)
Child 2 (under 18)	(1)	(0)
No response (1)	-	-

Findings:**Did participants have any difficulty understanding how to record their answers and did they report for each person mentioned in Q16m?**

This question was only asked of Medicaid and Medicare recipients.

- The two Medicare recipients easily answered All of 2024 for Adult 2 and had no difficulty with the response column headings.
- All covered all persons reported in Q16m.

- For the Medicaid participants, the issues found were the same as for Q15m and Q16m: the participant who changed households often in 2024 was unable to answer. The participant in whose state children are covered under their parents' Medicaid plan found the question unnecessary and repetitive: if the parent had coverage all year, then by necessity, so did the child.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Question 15 tricare (n=0)

Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024? VA/TRICARE or other military health care.

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 16_ tricare (n=0)

Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024? VA/TRICARE or other military health care

- 1 Adult 2
- 2 Adult child (18 or older)
- 3 Child 1 (under 18)
- 4 Child 2 (under 18)
- 5 Child 3 (under 18)
- 6 Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 17_ tricare (n=0)

How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024? VA/TRICARE or other military health care?

People in Household

All of 2024

Part of 2024

Adult 2

Adult child (18 or older)

Child 1 (under 18)

Child 2 (under 18)

No response

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 15 nontypical (n=0)

Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

1 Yes

2 No

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 16_nontypical (n=0)

Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

1 Adult 2

2 Adult child (18 or older)

3 Child 1 (under 18)

4 Child 2 (under 18)

5 Child 3 (under 18)

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 17 nontypical (n=0)

How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

People in Household	All of 2024	Part of 2024
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Adult 2

Adult child (18 or older)

Child 1 (under 18)

Child 2 (under 18)

No response

Findings:

This was not answered by any of the participants.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 18 (n=24)

Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- 1 Yes (15)
- 2 No (8)
- 3 No response (1)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- Of the eight Medicare recipients answering this question, seven said Yes. One of these seven was confused by the phrase “any other type” and thought the question had been asked and answered earlier already. Among the Medicaid recipients, two had some issues responding Yes or No as they remembered household members’ circumstances, and one other could not answer because of their changing households in 2024.
- Of the 10 “private health insurance not through a job” and “insurance through a job” recipients who answered this question, 5 answered “Yes,” and 5 answered “No.” One participant [P3335] initially answered “No,” explaining that they were only thinking about themselves when responding. After rereading part of the

question, they reconsidered and said they could have answered “Yes,” since other household members might have different insurance, though they did not know the details of that coverage.

- Two participants [P5054, P3153] were confused about how to answer when multiple types of insurance had already been mentioned. In each case, the participant hesitated because they felt they had already said “Yes” earlier and worried about repeating themselves or creating a “loop.” They were unsure whether the question was asking them to confirm the same coverage again or to identify an additional, third type of insurance. One participant concluded there were no additional household members with other coverage other than the person already mentioned, while the other explained that their household had two types of insurance, one through their spouse’s job and another through the VA. This participant ultimately responded “Yes,” thinking about their VA coverage.
- Another participant [P3667] initially answered “No,” but during probing, they confirmed they had made a mistake. They responded “Yes” to Q6 (Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024?) because they were considering their family members’ Medicaid coverage. When they saw this question, they thought they had already reported what type of insurance they had. During probing, they changed their answer to Q6 to “No,” and their answer to this question to “Yes.”
- The remaining participants who answered this question did not appear to have any issues.

Recommendations:

Participants did not select for themselves the answer on an online survey and instead answered verbally. In the actual online survey, the question could be prefaced by recapping what is known so far about other household members’ coverage before asking Q18, as in: “So far we have (PERSON) with (PERSON’S INSURANCE TYPE) coverage.” (REPEAT FOR EVERY PERSON IN HH).

Question 19 (n=24)

Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- 1 Adult 2
- 2 Adult child (18 or older)
- 3 Child 1 (under 18)
- 4 Child 2 (under 18)
- 5 Child 3 (under 18)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question.

- Of the 24 participants, 15 selected one or more household members covered by some other type of health insurance. None of them had any issues answering.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 20 Adult (n=2)

Was [Person] uninsured at any point in 2024?

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (2)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

Only one of the Medicare and one of the Medicaid recipients were asked this question and answered “No” without any issues. This question was not answered by any “private health insurance not through a job” or “insurance through a job” recipients.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 22 (n=16)

What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- 1 Insurance through a job (yours or another family member’s) (6)
- 2 Private health insurance not through a job (1)
- 3 Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans) (3)
- 4 Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid) (3)
- 5 Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) (1)
- 6 TRICARE or other military health care (0)
- 7 Indian Health Service (0)
- 8 Other (2)
- 9 No response (0)

Findings:

- One of the Medicare recipients was unsure of the option they should select for their household member. They chose Other and in probing indicated it was “through the Marketplace,” then reread the list and said they were not sure if private health insurance was the correct answer in their case. The only Medicaid recipient probed on whether they knew the coverage for all family members said they were 100% sure and could answer.
- Of the six “private health insurance not through a job” or “insurance through a job” recipients who answered this question, one said that other household members had health insurance, but they didn’t know the details of their coverage.

- Another participant identified Medicaid as the coverage for one household member and noted that their mother-in-law had both Medicaid and Medicare. They pointed out that the question format did not allow them to select multiple options. They said they would try to pick both options if they could, but if not, they wouldn't know how to answer.
- A third participant said their parents' insurance was private coverage through a spouse's job. Because that didn't fit the choices, they said they would pick "Other" and explain.
 - "Thinking about it, would my mother's or my father's insurance, that'd be private insurance, but is not given through my job, it is through his job. I would say that'd be question 2, or I would click 'other' and give a description.... Private insurance, private health insurance not through, mmm, no, I would click 'other' then.... I mean, and give a description." [P5054]
- This confusion with whose job the person was covered under appeared again in the case of a participant who had Medicare and also had insurance through his job. In this question, they were responding about their child. The participant answered "private health insurance not through a job" because they were thinking the first category referred only to their own job or someone else's in the household. Their child was covered under their mother's job, and the participant no longer considered the mother a "family member."
 - [PROBE: Okay. Does it, when it says another family member, does that throw you off?] "Yeah, it might a little." [PROBE: What do you think could be done so it's clear that it could be somebody else's insurance through a job?] "Well, I would think insurance through a job, not a family member or.... See that, I would take insurance through a job, not living in the household or something." [P4592]

Recommendations:

Since the question asks in plural about other coverage(s), it should allow multiple answers.

Additionally, in the option "insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)," it appears the parenthetical explanation was still unclear to a couple of participants and may need reconsideration. We recommend changing this response category to:

"insurance through a job (yours or another person's)"

Question 25hea (n=16)

How long did [Person] have this insurance in 2024?

- 1 All year (15)
- 2 Part of the year (1)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

No probes were administered for this question. No issues were found for any participants answering this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 33 (n=22)

Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- 1 Yes (8)
- 2 No (14)
- 3 No response (0)

Findings:

Did participants find the placement of the 2024 reference period awkward?

- Participants were probed on question clarity and asked if they would reword the question at all. Across types of insurance, virtually all participants found the question clear and did not feel it needed rewording. One participant wanted it to clarify that it referred to full-time employees since usually part-time employees do not get access to health insurance.
- Only one participant wished the question could be reworded and referred to the placement of the reference period specifically:
 - “The wording is a little weird. I mean, I understand it.” [PROBE: Okay, would you make any changes to it? Would you reword it differently?] “I would put 2024 in the front. In 2024, did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees?” [P3515]

Question Interpretation:

- Medicare and Medicaid recipients did not experience any visible difficulties responding. However, it appears that some were thinking of whether they personally were eligible for/offered health insurance at work, rather than *any* of the employees. Three Medicare recipients [P3324, P3686, P3805] had this interpretation, and three Medicaid recipients as well, as the quotes illustrate:
 - “If you have a job that offers health insurance in 2024.” [P3101]
 - “Did I ever have a job that would offer me insurance while my employment.” [P3246]
 - “It’s asking me if I had a company that I was working for that had an insurance package ready for us.” [P3514]
- Among the three recipients of “private health insurance not through a job” and “insurance through a job” that answered this question, one misinterpreted it, thinking it was asking if they personally owned a company and provided insurance to their employees. They thought the wording sounded more like it applied to business owners or corporations, rather than individual workers.
 - “Did you have a job that offered health insurance to (any of its employees). Well, is asking me if I own a company.... You are asking me if I have a company, and do I offer, employees—You gotta mean corporate, or LLC or something like that.” [P4453]

Recommendations:

Reword the question adding a clarification: Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024 (even if you personally were not eligible)?

Question 34 (n=8)

Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Findings:

- None of the Medicare recipients had difficulties answering this question, and all four who answered the question said "Yes." Three Medicaid recipients also answered the question without issues and interpreted the question as intended. None of the "private health insurance not through a job" or "insurance through a job" recipients had difficulties answering this question.

Recommendations:

See Q35 case P3153. Based on that situation, it may be advisable here to rephrase as *Was it possible for you to get health insurance through your job in 2024?*

Question 35 (n=6)

Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- 1 On someone else's plan (0)
- 2 Covered by another plan, not through a job (3)
- 3 Traded health insurance for higher pay (0)
- 4 Too expensive (1)
- 5 Don't need health insurance (0)
- 6 Have a pre-existing condition (0)
- 7 Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered (0)
- 8 Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year (0)
- 9 Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan (0)
- 10 Other/specify (1)
- 11 No response (1)

Findings:

Did the word "get" work for participants?

- None of the participants exhibited any difficulties or issues with the word "get" in this question. Their responses revealed they interpreted "get" in the sense of taking up the offer of insurance through a job. They explained why they decided

not to take the insurance they were eligible for and were able to select from among the categories offered.

- Of the three Medicare recipients answering this question, one had to select Other and specify that they have insurance through a job. In Q2, they had selected Medicare but also mentioned being covered through their job.
- The other two correctly chose “Covered by another plan, not through a job,” thinking of their Medicare coverage. The two Medicaid recipients who were asked this question were able to respond without noticeable difficulties and had no issues with how the question is worded.
- The one “insurance through a job” recipient who answered “Yes” to Q33 found this question confusing and at first thought it was asking about jobs in general rather than their own. They explained that their household did have insurance, but it came through their spouse’s job, not the participant’s. When asked about their own job, they said the insurance offered through it was too expensive, so they chose not to take it. Then they were able to answer this question: being covered under someone else’s plan, not needing additional coverage, and the insurance offered through their job being too expensive. They also noted that they didn’t initially see the “select all that apply” instruction, which also confused them.
 - “Well, we did on someone else’s plan. This is bad.... I can’t understand this question. If it was, I had answered no before, but I answered yes. So, this seems kind of redundant, unnecessary.” [PROBE: Do you understand this question to be asking about your job or a job in general?] “I understand it to be why we didn’t get it under a job in general. Obviously, we did, we got it through my husband’s because he was working.” [P3153]

Recommendations:

Consistent with the recommendation for Q34, we recommend considering changing “through a job” to “through your job” in Q35.

5.2 MOOP Questions

MOOP_PREM (N=30)

The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024.

In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

Include comprehensive plans and supplemental plans such as vision and dental insurance. Do not include any Medicare deductions from Social Security and/or Social Security Disability.

- 1 \$0–\$199 (14)
- 2 \$200–\$499 (5)
- 3 \$500–\$999 (4)
- 4 \$1,000–\$2,999 (3)

- 5 \$3,000 or more (4)
- 6 No response (0)

Findings:

Did the participant see the note about “paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs”?

- Twenty-nine of the 30 participants confirmed that they saw the sentence before the question about “paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs.” The one participant who did not read it, a Medicare recipient, said:
 - “And other healthcare costs, okay. No, I just assumed we were talking just about the plan, you know, copays and all other stuff.” [P4083]

Did it help them understand that there would be separate questions about insurance coverage and other costs?

- Twenty-three of the 29 participants who saw the sentence said it was helpful for different reasons. They explained that it clarified which costs to include, framed or transitioned the question, made the instructions easier to understand, and guided them to think about household members, time periods, or specific expenses.
 - “Yeah, it gives it, it gives you a ... a tracking, I guess, it lets you know what you’re moving into now, let you know that you’re moving into now, let you know that you’ve kind of changed. I guess a good way to say you’ve changed gears from the first set of questions, you’re kind of moving into something a little different.” [P3199]
 - “Oh yes, it’s good, it frames it and allowed me to focus on exact, approximately guessing total for what health insurance coverage was. So, I think this previous sentence is helpful.” [P5285]
 - “This question is asking for all the health care costs, insurance coverage, and everything relating to health care your family paid over the year that was mentioned.” [P3667]
 - “Yeah, because you’re going to think about what you actually paid for, like your monthly insurance premium, and then if you had any costs, other costs other than the insurance that you normally would pay every month.” [P4592]
- Although the last participant [P4592] mentioned “monthly insurance premium” in their answer, they explained that they understood they had to report the yearly cost.
- Two participants noted that while the introductory sentence was helpful, it should be clearer about the period of coverage to be reported. One noted during probing that the question should specify whether it refers to monthly or yearly costs, since they initially answered with monthly figures before realizing the specified timeframe was yearly [P3693]. Another explained:
 - “I think it should definitely specify, you know. I thought it was for monthly instead of, you know, for the whole year. So yeah, it needs to be a little bit more specific.” [P4153]
- Two participants noted the instruction was confusing. One participant [P3324], a Medicare recipient, said that the sentence was helpful, but the instructions about “Medicare deductions from Social Security” confused them. Another participant

[P3885] said, “Well, it made it more... in hindsight, it makes it more confusing,” but they did not provide any explanation.

- Three participants [P4458, P3705, P5326] felt the introductory sentence was not helpful. Two explained that it seemed redundant, noting that the second sentence simply repeated the first; although they found it repetitive, they did not consider it confusing.
- Another participant expressed confusion about the phrase “other health care costs,” interpreting it to include “everything” (out-of-pocket payments, copays, and any additional expenses).
 - “Well, to me, that’s where the confusion lies, other health care costs. That’s everything. That’s your out-of-pocket. That’s your copay. That’s, you know.... So yeah, that would put it into the over \$3,000 answer.... And then if you’re asking me how much of that was just for out-of-pocket stuff, like the next question is, yeah, then I would definitely change that answer.” [P3153]
- One last participant [P4290] expressed uncertainty about what should be counted as health insurance coverage costs, particularly regarding supplemental plans. They explained that while dental and vision plans should be included, direct payments to providers, such as dentists, should not. This participant said that their answer included, “Copays, and supplemental dental policy, and the things that Medicare did not cover.”

How did they interpret “paid for health insurance coverage?”

- Across all 30 responses, most (n=16) participants understood “health insurance coverage” as the premium they pay to maintain their insurance, but many (n=10) also included services, copays, or supplemental policies. Some thought about household or employer contributions, and a few were unsure how to explain what it meant. A couple of participants even suggested changing the wording to make it clearer.
- Sixteen participants interpreted “health insurance coverage” primarily as the monthly premium or policy cost they pay to maintain their insurance. For these participants, coverage was understood as the “bottom-line” amount deducted each month or year to keep their plan active. They described it as “what you pay on a month-to-month basis” or “the premium for the policy.”
 - “Initially, I was thinking about ... how much you’re paying for everything that’s not medication, but coverage just means how much for you to be covered. So, I had to let the question resonate, and I realized they were asking about how much does it cost for you to be covered by the insurance, which is what you pay on a month-to-month basis.” [P3127]
 - “Health insurance coverage, so it’s ... to me, that’s what you’re paying monthly or what you would be expected to pay monthly just to maintain the policy.” [P3199]
 - “I think they do the price paid for the insurance monthly, that goes to the insurance side monthly.” [P3667]
 - “Health insurance coverage to me is the actual product itself. What does the Medicare Advantage cost me? What does the plan cost me? Before I even get any benefits, before I even get anything out of the package at all, what’s my bottom line going to be? What’s my cost going to be?” [P3885]
- Ten participants conflated coverage with the services or benefits included under their plan. These participants listed doctor visits, hospital stays, prescriptions,

dental care, and vision care as part of what coverage meant to them. Some explained that coverage was what reduced their out-of-pocket costs, such as lowering a \$250 visit to a \$20 copay. Others thought about supplemental policies like dental or acupuncture alongside premiums. When probed, however, three admitted they had only reported premiums in their answers.

- “Mmm, health insurance coverage, anything that kind of falls into like maybe you need acupuncture, maybe you need it anything else like that, anything kind of underlying within those healthcare coverage costs you paying for your main policy and then you need an extra dental policy. Let’s say there was something else you need it, be able to add into the policy that make it better for that person.” [P5054]
 - “Health insurance coverage means just that. The insurance pays their end of it. Where, my office visit is only \$20 for a copay versus paying \$250 for the entire visit. So, that’s what the health insurance part to me is.” [P3153]
 - “I think it means dental, vision, doctors, hospital, all that stuff.... Copays at the doctor’s office, specialists’ costs, prescription drug costs ... all outside of the insurance premium.” [So, when you think of the phrase health insurance coverage, it makes you think about all those things.] “Yes.” [P3686]
 - “Everything that it covers. Well, you know, doctor’s visits, hospitalization, ambulance, whatever coverage you got. How much you pay for all the coverage.” [P4458]
- Three participants showed confusion about what “health insurance coverage” meant. The first participant [P3335] kept switching between ideas, sometimes thinking it meant their personal plan or premiums, and other times the total insurance costs for the whole household but never gave a clear answer. Similarly, a second participant [P3665] described employer contributions versus their own payments, but their explanation of what coverage meant was not clear. The third participant [P4044] gave an unclear answer, saying coverage meant “who your doctors get paid by.”
- One participant was unsure if supplemental plans like dental and vision should be counted as part of coverage or excluded as direct service payments.
 - “Well, the thing includes comprehensive plans, supplemental plans. OK this is a little tricky because they’re talking about supplemental plans, vision and dental supplemental plans, but I don’t think they’re talking about direct payments to the dentist.... When I look, when I think of health insurance coverage, I think of dental and vision too, but I think here as I read the second question, I think here maybe they’re just talking about where you are going to see your personal physician, or you are having surgery. They’re not talking about dental or vision, unless, except how much you pay for dental and vision plan.” [P4290]
- Finally, two participants suggested revising the wording of the question to make it clearer.
 - “Yeah. I mean, it should say premium coverage maybe or amount of your coverage.” [P4083]
 - “I think you should revise it. Say ‘how do you pay for it?’” [P4453]

Did they understand the question and instructions? If applicable, are they answering for themselves or for the combined household?

- Eighteen participants said they considered the combined household when answering this question. Four participants confirmed that they had thought about the whole household but were unable to include everyone in their answer. One of the four participants said she did not know how much was deducted from their daughter's paycheck. Two participants didn't answer about their roommates because they didn't have the information. The fourth participant explained:
 - "I was thinking about the household I had in 2024." [PROBE: Okay. Can you tell me a little bit about that?] "Well, I was like in and out of sober living. So, um, I really didn't have like a permanent residence." [P3515]
- One participant [P3324] included everyone in the household but themselves. They initially estimated about \$50 per person per month. When probed further, they clarified that this did not include their own \$175 Medicare premium. After reading the instructions, which said not to include "Medicare deductions from Social Security," they asked what that meant and wondered if the question was telling them to leave out Medicare altogether. Even after rereading the instructions several times, this participant concluded that the question applied only to the other household members, not to themselves.
- This probe was not asked of six participants because they lived alone. One was skipped due to time constraints.

Would it have been easier for them to report this by person instead of for the household?

- Six participants said answering separately for each household member would make things easier, especially when household members had different types of insurance.
 - "Yeah, there should be two questions. It really should be like that for the other ones, too. Because, you know, not everybody has a permanent home to live in."
 - "Yeah, it would be for myself and then a separate one for household. And then it needs to clarify if you're still talking about the same household in 2025 or in 2024. I had a different living.... Yeah. My household was different in 2024 or in 2025." [P3515]
- Three participants said it would depend on household structure.
 - "So, I mean, yeah. With multiple people, especially if it's on.... If it's households with different types of plans it seems like it would be very helpful to answer for each person individually. Now if it's a household where everyone's on the same plan or the same type of plan, then I could see it would be okay to do it just grouped together as one." [P3199]
 - "You know, it makes sense to answer it the way that it is. Now, if you found a rare occasion when you have a household which is like an Airbnb and people are just set up in different families and different households in one household in a one-room, then maybe." [P3514]
- Six participants preferred answering for the household as a whole, saying it was simpler, more inclusive, or worked better for them.

- "I think it would be more inclusive and easier to answer as a whole because most households have kids, there's more, most households have a package deal, a spouse, you know dependents, so they're more inclusive. We have a house that's three adults, so, everybody's kind of exclusive. So, I think the average household would be more as a unit so, it would be easier for them to answer as a household." [P3127]
- "I don't think so. You know, I mean, it's all coming out of the same two paychecks or one paycheck, depending on how the family is set up. In most cases, obviously, if you have a kid on Medicaid, you're not even going to think twice about it, because Kids are covered 100% under Medicaid, right?" [P3153]
- "No, the household is good." [P3324]
- Lastly, one participant strongly rejected answering by person. Through the interview, they did not provide information about other household members because, as they explained, they felt it was not the government's business to know.
 - "Nope. Absolutely not. Because again, not everybody's business." [P4044]
- This probe was not asked to eight participants due to time constraints, and to six participants because they lived alone.

If they had the option to report this at a frequency other than year, would they have chosen something else?

- Most participants (n=22) said they were thinking about the entire year of 2024 while answering this question.
 - "I was thinking about the entire year because in the first and the second both say costs in 2024, so that to me just being you know for the entire year." [P3199]
 - "Yeah, I was thinking about 2024 when I came up with that amount." [P3665]
 - "Yes. I did. And I did because all the other questions have always been consistent in saying for the entire, for all of 2024, so it's got me thinking in that mode." [P3885]
- Five participants [P3698, P4083, P3705, P4153, P3693] said they thought in terms of monthly payments, not the whole year. Two participants [P4153, P3693] suggested adding "monthly" or "yearly" to clarify what is being asked.
 - "I think it should definitely specify, you know. I thought it was for monthly instead of, you know, for the whole year. So yeah, it needs to be a little bit more specific." [P4153]
- One participant [P3210] said that she did not think about 2024 but her whole lifetime because she has never had to pay for health insurance.
- One Medicaid participant gave an unclear answer that didn't fit into "year" or "month."
 - "Half of the year, I was being charged for my disability check, I would say 7 or 8 months, then after that it was no deductions from my disability check. I didn't include it, though." [P3101]
- Participants were split on whether a different time frame would make answering this question easier. Eight participants said shorter periods, such as weekly,

monthly, or 6 months, would be easier, mainly because they are easier to remember and calculate.

- Nine participants preferred the yearly format, saying it was clearer, more standard, and better captured changes in costs over time. Two participants said it would be the same whether asked by year or another period. Two participants didn't directly answer but suggested the question should specify "monthly" or "yearly" to avoid confusion.
- One participant said it depended on household stability (job changes). For them, yearly was fine because they had no premiums, but they noted the question may not fit all households.
- The remaining seven participants did not answer or were skipped.

If they have employer-sponsored insurance, does the value provided include or exclude any contribution from their employer?

- This probe was only meant for participants who had their own insurance through a job or lived in a household where someone else had this type of coverage. All seven participants who were asked this question said they did not include employer contributions, focusing only on what they personally pay.
- This probe was skipped, not asked, or was not applicable to 23 participants.

How did they reach the amount they included?

- Participants arrived at their answers in different ways. Eight calculated yearly costs by multiplying monthly or weekly deductions, and in these cases, several knew the exact deduction amounts, while others relied on rough estimates or averages. Four participants also considered weekly deductions, but they reported the monthly cost rather than the yearly cost.
 - "I just answered by, you know, roughly calculated the price I paid through the insurance monthly." [P3667]
 - "Because I pay, I get deducted out of my paycheck for the private insurance. It's like, once it's 100 something, I mean.... Yeah, it's automatically taken out of my check, so I don't really think about it, so I'm just trying to do quick math. But I figured it's like one hundred and something a month times 12. So, it's in between that. It's over \$1,000, but it's definitely less than \$29,999." [P4592]
- One participant focused only on what they paid for health insurance coverage in 2024, but they were confused by the phrase "other health care costs" and expressed uncertainty about whether other health care costs should also be included.
 - "Now I'm not so sure that they're not asking about the other things as well. But I thought it was strictly just what did you pay for coverage. Include comprehensive plans and supplemental plans such as vision and dental insurance. Do not include any Medicare deductions. So, are they asking me what I paid for the coverage and then what I paid for other health care costs to combine it? Is that what they're asking, or are they asking me which is what I paid for the coverage? ... Now I'm a little confused because of the way the question is worded. So, I might reword that slightly and just say the next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage period." [P3885]

- Four participants included both premiums and other medical expenses, such as copays, prescriptions, or dental costs.
 - "I was thinking in terms of, I have a supplemental dental plan that I pay twice a year and various copays. That's what I was thinking about." [P4290]
 - "Monthly Medicare costs alone is more than \$3,000, so.... Copays at the doctor's office, specialists' costs, prescription drug costs ... all outside of the insurance premium." [P3686]
 - "\$150 a month for the insurance for the two of us; comes right out of his paycheck. Plus, I was also thinking copays, and my husband had surgery on his neck last year. That's where that 1,500 on the next screen comes from, so yeah, between the cost of the insurance, the copay for the surgery, plus any out-of-pocket copays for medications for the two of us. It would probably be just about let's see a hair north of \$3,000." [P3153]
 - "That's the only guess from all the doctors for the physicals, check-ups, the cleanings, and fillings. I just went for the easy guess. I know it ain't more than that, though." [P3444]
- Ten participants reported zero costs, one was a private insurance recipient, and eight were Medicare/Medicaid recipients. Some did not provide details about what was covered or how they thought about their answer, simply answering "zero" because they do not pay anything. However, some specifically mentioned their premium, while others mentioned specific medical costs, such as doctor visits and prescriptions.
 - "No one here pays anything for their insurance, 0 to \$199. I get extra help from Medicare, which pays for my.... I don't know exactly what it's paid for the prescription of the Medicare.... I've been getting for years. It's called extra help, which is about \$150 for Medicaid. But I don't qualify for Medicaid because they say I make too much money. But I qualify for extra help for Medicaid. So, I pay zero. (Adult 2) pays zero. (Adult 3) pays zero. We all pay zero." [P4458]
 - "Anything...any charge, like doctor's visits, prescriptions, or anything related to your health.... Currently, I didn't pay anything." [P3101]
 - "Because I didn't have.... I didn't have health care costs in 2024." [P3246]
 - "Because I get my health insurance through the state, so I don't pay a premium. And I don't have any supplemental insurance like dental revision." [P3515]
- One participant [P3514] based their answer on the cost of one member of their household; a [65+] household member bought a dental plan for about \$100 to get bridge work, but the plan didn't cover the care. Because that was the only expense they remembered, they treated it as the household's total health insurance cost.
- Another participant [P3665] guessed their costs were between \$500 and \$999 but wasn't clear about what that covered. At first, they mentioned vision, dental, and other insurance plans. Later, they explained they were thinking about money they paid out of their own pocket, like payroll deductions through ADP or personal payments. They didn't say if the amount was for premiums, medical bills, or both.
- Finally, one participant [P3324] said they thought about the \$50 each household member paid each month, but they left out their own \$175 Medicare premium. They were confused by the instructions, which said not to include "Medicare

deductions from Social Security.” After rereading the question several times, they wondered whether it meant they should leave out Medicare altogether.

Recommendations:

Although participants were positive about the introduction and felt it was useful, it was not clear that they realized the introduction applied to more than the first question in MOOP. In addition, the phrase “other healthcare costs” made some participants think of ALL costs of health care coverage, services, and products, and some thought that they should report on all these in this first question. Consider modifying the introduction and first question to read:

The next two questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024.

First, in 2024, how much did your household pay to have health insurance coverage?

Given that participants had mixed views about the best reference period for this question, we recommend adding clarification that the question asks about the annual cost in <LAST CALENDAR YEAR>. Should the decision be made to ask about monthly cost, this should be equally stressed to avoid confusion.

MOOP_NONPREM (n=30)

In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

Include: Costs for doctor and dentist visits, diagnostic tests, prescription medicine, glasses and contacts, medical equipment and supplies, vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, first aid supplies, and other similar expenses.

Do not include the amount your household paid for health insurance coverage.

If you don’t know the exact amount, please estimate.

#[numbers].00 for the year

- 1 \$0 (4)
- 2 More than \$0 (26)
- 3 Don’t know (0)
- 4 No response (0)

Findings:

Did the participants have any trouble with this question?

- Overall, several participants had trouble with this question (n=12). Some included insurance premiums or deductibles instead of just out-of-pocket costs,

while others only counted one or two big expenses they could remember. Some focused on their own costs instead of the whole household, and a couple treated it as the same as the previous question. Participants who said they had little or no spending often skipped the instructions and didn't include over-the-counter items such as vitamins or first-aid supplies. One participant commented that the question would be clearer if the list of items to include were presented as bullet points rather than a single long sentence.

- Eighteen participants understood the question as intended, focusing on over-the-counter products they had bought, such as vitamins, allergy medicine, cold medicine, and first-aid supplies. Some also included copays, surgery costs, medical equipment, and any "out-of-pocket" medical expenses. They often described adding these items into their rough totals without precise calculations, saying they "just guessed" or multiplied small monthly amounts.
 - "Glasses and medicine, and vitamins, cold medicine, first aid supplies, yeah. So, you know, the other stuff I paid out of pocket for." [P4153]
 - "None of us did any, had any glasses or contacts renewed last year, so that is out. No new medical equipment for mother-in-law. Had vitamins, allergy cold medicine, first aid supplies, other similar expenses. So very helpful on here is if you do not know the exact amount, please estimate, because I do not know the exact amount, but I would estimate it to probably be for the entire year probably \$2,000 out of pocket." [P3199]
 - "So, all I was doing from there was really just looking at the \$500 we had to pay ourselves for my husband's neck surgery, and then out-of-pocket medical care, which for us would be the visit to the eyeglasses, which was about \$250 for me. And then non-prescription medical expenses, I have some medications that I have an inhaler, a rescue inhaler, some months are better than others, so I may have to go buy an extra inhaler for myself. So, I counted those, but I didn't consider it a prescription medical expense because it is something I pay full price for. I don't use my insurance for it. So that kind of thing. That's where I came up with about the \$1,500." [P3153]
- Six participants did not mention over-the-counter products in the list of out-of-pocket medical care expenses they reported; some admitted they had not considered over-the-counter products at first and only realized after rereading the list of things to include or being prompted that these costs should be included.
 - "Ok. I didn't consider that, so maybe the amount would be a little bit higher." [P3698]
 - "Well.... I didn't think about things like first-aid supplies, I didn't think about things like allergy and cold medication, I wasn't even thinking that. So, yeah, the more choices you can give there, I think it's more, it's more is gonna stimulate people to think about their expenses." [P3885]
 - "One thing I included is, I don't pay for regular doctor visits. I don't pay for dental visits up to \$2,500. I don't pay for diagnostic tests. I pay very little for prescription medication, maybe \$3 to \$9 every three or four months. I don't pay for glasses. I don't pay for any of those things. So, I'm just thinking, would I have to pay when I see a specialist, maybe? \$20 two or three times a year, and the little bit that I copay that I pay for my medications is probably about \$100." [P4458]
 - "I remember, I think I got some.... I got charged for going to the hospital for.... I told them I was having like stomach problems. I just got out of work,

and they gave me some stomach ... something for stomach, something to flush my system, and send me home. Then they sent me a bill like ... like a \$47 bill that I didn't even pay." When asked if they included any over-the-counter medication, they responded "Because that's not prescribed medication from whatever your health insurance is." [P3246]

- Two participants based their estimates on premiums or deductibles rather than strictly out-of-pocket medical costs. One participant [P3693] explained that both spouses had reached their deductible amounts, so they estimated \$12,000 by adding \$4,000 for each spouse, plus another \$4,000. They then added \$4,000 in dental care, bringing the total to \$16,000. The other participant [P4453] multiplied a \$500 monthly insurance payment to reach an annual total. This participant explained their answer by saying they treated this question as essentially the same as the first, only it applied to annual expenses rather than monthly ones.
- One participant [P3805] was not able to provide an answer. They said: "Oh my God. I have absolutely no clue." They described using their Medicare Advantage card to pay for vitamins, supplies, and first aid items, but admitted they did not know how to account for prescription costs. They added that they could use their card for nonmedical uses, such as paying the electric bill or cellphone bill, noting that the plan deposits money monthly that can be spent on a range of items.
- Three participants [P3335, P3705, P3101] reported zero out-of-pocket medical expenses for 2024. One of them explained that they don't have copays, and they simply don't buy over-the-counter items. The other two participants (both Medicaid recipients) explained their answers by saying insurance covers all their medical costs, leaving them with no out-of-pocket spending. However, both of these participants were not considering over-the-counter products. When asked if Medicaid also covered over-the-counter products, one participant clarified that it did not. Another participant said they paid nothing in 2024, so they did not look closely at the instructions. When asked again, they were surprised that the question included items such as first-aid supplies, vitamins, and allergy medicine. They explained that they had never thought of everyday pharmacy items as medical expenses, which is why they did not include them.
- One participant explained their answer by roughly adding up copays and prescription refills, estimating \$100 based on how often their spouse visited the doctor. Their calculation focused only on copays and prescription refills and did not include any out-of-pocket items such as vitamins or first-aid supplies. [P3127]

Did the "include" list make things easier or harder?

- Of the 30 participants, 3 did not read the list of items to include when answering the question, but they did read it during probing.
- Most participants said the list of items to include was helpful; however, as mentioned before, some did not include items mentioned in the list. Twenty-three participants described it as useful, necessary, or clarifying. Some participants said they would not have included certain items if they hadn't read the list, while others who reviewed the question during probing realized they had left out many things and noted that, after reading it, their answers would change.
 - "Yes. I'm a person that has to have definition, because if something is general and broad I don't get it as much as if it's included the way you had it. Which

- it included ... you broke it down what you were talking about specifically. That for me.... I found that a lot more, easier to understand." [P3210]
- "Well, I think so because I didn't think about things like first aid supplies, I didn't think about things like allergy and cold medication, I wasn't even thinking that. So, yeah, the more choices you can give there, I think it's more, it's more is gonna stimulate people to think about their expenses." [P3885]
 - "Yeah, I think it did. I don't think I would have included over-the-counter stuff, or like glasses, contacts, vitamins." [P3490]
 - "Yes, yes, and you know what, I didn't even really include medical equipment. I did not include any boots or any type of wheelchair or knee-rolling machine that he had to use for transportation, and just to get around the house." [P3514]
- One participant [P3153] did not directly answer whether the list was helpful, but they critiqued it. They felt the instructions were confusing because many of the items listed are covered by insurance, making "out-of-pocket" unclear. They understood prescriptions as a clearer example but noted that medical equipment and supplies vary by insurance coverage. They suggested the list was too broad and should be broken into separate questions: Over-the-counter items such as vitamins, allergy medicine, cold medicine, and first -id supplies. Medical and dental care, such as doctor visits, prescription medications, eye doctor visits, and dentist visits. And medical equipment, such as CPAP machine supplies (masks, tubes, holders), and diabetic patches and monitoring devices.
 - One participant [P4453] said it helped, but the question could be improved: "Yes and no, because people don't know how to calculate, you know?" They added that they would prefer to answer by month and have the "system" make the calculation.
 - One participant who did not read the list of items to include because they reported zero out-of-pocket spending in 2024, did not answer this probe. Instead, when prompted, they expressed surprise that the list covered everyday pharmacy items such as first-aid supplies, vitamins, allergy and cold medicines, and medical equipment.
 - "To include first aid supplies, and other expenses like vitamins, allergy and cold medicines, and equipment and supplies.... I mean, it's kind of surprising.... I never heard that kind of questions before." [P3101]
 - The remaining four participants did not answer the question or were skipped.
 - The participants were also asked whether there were still things they weren't sure they should include.
 - Three participants provided examples of expenses they were unsure about including. One talked about everyday items and over-the-counter products, another mentioned transportation to medical visits, and the third brought up massage therapy.
 - "Well, you know, like compression socks, back support braces, knee braces. These are things that I didn't really put in my costs at that time, right there. Any kind of pain reliever that's over the counter, Voltaren and stuff like that. That's stuff I didn't include either." When asked why they didn't include them, this participant said, "I guess maybe because when I think about Voltaren and a pain rub or a deodorant type of thing, I don't really put that with my health

insurance cost so much as it should be there.” However, as they were thinking about it, they changed their mind: “Okay. Healthcare it’s probably healthcare as well. A deodorant, toothpaste, any kind of facial wash or body wash should probably be included in healthcare ... toothpaste, fingernail clippers, toenail clippers, even out of fingernail polish. These are all the controversial types of help I would know.” [P3514]

- “Yeah, like transportation to these visits. Yeah, the transportation cost.” [P3515]
- “Yeah, for instance a visit to a massage therapist. That is a legitimate medical need for me. And it’s something that I pay for out of pocket, but it’s not listed in the paragraph here.” [P5326]
- Two participants did not answer the probe. The first one [P3693] only said it was hard to remember everything after so long. The second one [P4453] explained that, to calculate their yearly costs, they had to use a calculator and multiply the amounts.

Did they have questions about what to include and for whom?

- The findings under the previous probe mention items that participants wondered about including or not.
- Over half of the participants (n=17) confirmed that they had included everyone in the household when answering this question.
- One participant explained that they only included themselves in their answer, since their child is covered by the mother’s insurance through her job, even though she does not live with them.
 - “Just myself, pretty much. I mean, I’ll like, I’ll always have like, I’ll check the medicine cabinet, and I’ll always have certain things that like cold medicine instead of, maybe getting NyQuil when it’s like real low, stuff like that. And like I said, like band-aids, and then I’m trying to think of rubbing alcohol or something. And it’s just certain stuff that you need for like little every day or every once in a while, mishaps that you have, you’re going to cut yourself.” [P4592]
- Six participants did not include everyone in their household. Four said they did not have information about their roommates. Another participant explained that they did not have information about the people they lived with in 2024; they lived in different places during that year and now live in a recovery home. The fifth participant included one roommate but excluded another younger person, describing them as “more like a neighbor” who doesn’t participate as a household member.
- This probe was skipped for six participants because they lived alone.

Recommendations:

We recommend moving the exclusion of health insurance premiums to a more prominent place, as follows:

In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses? Do not include the amount your household paid for health insurance coverage.

An issue with this question that needs to be resolved is that some participants double-counted expenses, reporting them in both the first and second MOOP questions. This issue may be reduced or solved by prefacing the question with:

For this question, please do not report any expense you already counted in your answer to the previous question.

6. Question by Question Results – Migration

This section outlines findings from the migration module. We first present findings for the 1-year and 5-year migration questions, followed by findings from associated 'reason for moving' items.

Globally, we recommend filling the reference date (1 or 5 years ago today, as relevant) on questions to orient respondents to past time periods without negatively impacting others' response process. In MIGPLC1, for example, a participant asked the interviewer to remind them what month it is right now to help them figure out the start of the reference period so they could think back to last year at this time. This request for clarification indicates that the respondent was seeking to benchmark their response within the reference period. This finding and subsequent recommendations are discussed in more detail in this section (see MIGSTAT1).

MIGSTAT1 (n=36)

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- 1 Yes (28)
- 2 No (8)

Findings:

How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous?

- Generally, this question was not challenging or confusing to participants. However, of the 36 participants who received this question and were probed, 9 said they would prefer the question to include the exact date fill from "1 year ago today." The lack of a reference date was the primary source of confusion for respondents. When asked if it would be helpful to include the reference date in the question, 9 participants said it did not matter or did not express a clear preference, and 22 preferred to leave the question as tested (i.e., version presented above). (Totals do not add up to 36 as some answers were coded in two categories).

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- Of the nine participants who would prefer to have the date filled, seven had a general preference for inclusion because it would be more specific, or because the specificity might help others, but did not express difficulty answering with the original wording. However, two participants indicated that having a date would help them with recall, and in one case, change their answer.
- On participant [P3515], who had a history of homelessness, stated a specific date would have aided their memory of where they were residing at the time. When probed if they knew exactly where they were living last year, they stated: "Um,

no. I actually don't. No. I might have been either homeless or staying with someone, or I wouldn't say, yeah, I wouldn't know. I wouldn't know for sure. I don't know." On further probing as to whether having a date helps them think back, the participant confirmed: "Yeah, it makes me think back. It's easier to recall."

- Another participant [P3667], who had last moved in March 2024 but was interviewed in July 2025, answered "No" to MIGSTAT1. Probing revealed this answer to be incorrect. When probed as to whether they would prefer the date being listed in the question, they said it would have been "easy," and "My attention was on the beginning of the last year." They said that having the date "would make a very big difference." This participant should have answered "Yes" to MIGSTAT1, but they answered "No" because they were thinking about early 2024 instead of exactly 1 year ago.
- Another participant [P3246], who preferred to keep the wording as is, thought it would be harder to remember the specific date: "Some people might not be able to remember exactly from a year from now, that's just more simpler [sic]."
- Notably, one participant [P3665], who reported living at their current residence 1 year ago, stated they didn't prefer whether the question wording included the date or not but thought that changing the wording to a specific date would change the meaning of the question: "Maybe I actually went for a business trip, and I was not actually home that particular month." This participant may have misunderstood what was meant by the phrase "living at," and interpreted it to mean "staying at," such as where they were sleeping when they were traveling. Because this issue only arose upon probing and no similar confusion arose during Round 1 of testing, we consider this to be rare.

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

During Round 1 there was some confusion about the date that was filled on screen, but this was because the date was static and did not align with the actual reference date at the time of the interview.

In this round of cognitive testing, the question did not include a reference date. Most participants were able to interpret and answer the question without the inclusion of a reference date; however, some participants' experience suggests that including a specific reference date could reduce measurement error.

Presenting the reference date below the question may aid the recall of respondents who may have moved at or around the time of the reference date, or who are transient (e.g., Date 1 year ago: February 3, 2025). Although this specific presentation was not tested in the current round of cognitive interviews, similar formats that display fills below questions were tested in the Health Insurance module and performed well. Based on those findings, we expect this format to function well and should address the few issues we found with recall and comprehension (due to lack of reference period) observed in this round. We also recommend including this item in a future round of cognitive testing to assess performance.

MIGUS1 (n=11)

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- 1 Yes (11)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

How many respondents found the description clear/not clear?

- Seven of the 11 participants who were asked this question found the question/description clear, while 4 found it unclear. The 4 participants who found the wording of the question unclear were either confused by the inclusion of Washington, D.C. as a state or the grammar of “50 United States” or both:
 - P4458 shared: “It’s a little confusing. Were you living in the 50 United States? Because there aren’t 50 United States, there’s only one United States.... I’m sure most people don’t get worried about the grammar.... There aren’t 50 United States....”
 - P3444 said: “Yeah, the Washington, D.C., threw me off....It should say, ‘Were you living in any of the 50 states?’” [PROBE: What about that Washington, D.C. part? Was that confusing to you or not?] “Yeah, the whole question was.”

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

Although the wording is unlikely to result in inaccurate responses, improving clarity to avoid cognitive burden is recommended. Due to the confusion about the phrase “District of Columbia” that arose during Round 1 of testing, we recommend a merged approach between the original phrasing and the new phrasing:

Were you/they living in the United States (within the 50 states or Washington, D.C.) 1 year ago today?

At a minimum, we recommend removing reference to “50 United States,” as that wording was also confusing to a participant in the 5-year version of this question (MIGUS5).

MIGST1 (n=11)

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Findings:

- Eight of the 11 participants who were asked this question answered without difficulty, while 3 had some difficulty answering it.
 - One participant [P3114] asked to see MIGSTAT1 again, thinking it had already asked about state.
 - Another [P5273], who reported living with multiple unrelated individuals as part of a sober living house, said the question was not clearly defined. Upon

further probing, however, this participant stated that he did know what states his housemates had moved from in the last year.

- One participant [P3515] who lives with three roommates was not able to answer this or many other questions about those roommates.

Recommendations:

Due to the difficulty in proxy reporting for some people with unrelated household members, we recommend adding a “don’t know” response option to the dropdown list for the version of this question that asks about where others lived.

MIGCTY1 (n=11)

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Findings:

Number of skips + information on why?

- None of the 11 people who were asked this question skipped it.

Comments related to question phrasing + dropdown structure:

- Two participants [P4044, P4958] thought the word “county” read “country.” Both participants first answered, “United States,” and the interviewer had to point out the word “county” to obtain their correct answer.

Distribution of “Don’t Know” and “Other,” as well as any noticeable patterns related to these responses:

- Two participants didn’t know about unrelated household members.
- One participant who lives in a sober living home [P5273] said they didn’t know and weren’t sure who the question was asking about.
 - “That I would have to ask. Also, not clearly defined who they’re speaking about, but I guess, it says down there.... I could just put ‘don’t know.’”
- One participant [P3515] said they think most people know what county they live in, but they didn’t know this information about their roommates.

Recommendations:

Although “county” was initially misread as “country” by two participants, it is unlikely to present a challenge to response when the instrument is programmed with the state fill from MIGST_1. Round 1 testing did not identify any similar challenge.

Proxy reporting was also a challenge on this question, but because “don’t know” is already a response option, there are no resulting recommendations.

MIGPLC1 (n=11)

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Findings:**Number of skips + information on why:**

- None of the 11 people who were asked this question skipped it.

Comments related to question phrasing + dropdown structure:

- None

Distribution of “Don’t Know” and “Other,” as well as any noticeable patterns related to these responses:

- The two participants [P3515, P5273] who live with unrelated housemates were unable to answer this question about the other household members, but P5273 said he could ask them.
 - P3515 also asked the interviewer what month it is right now to jog their memory about whether they had moved from a different city in their county. [Okay. Did you move from city to city in 2024?] “Yeah, I did.... But it’s like all you know because Phoenix is comprised of you know, a whole bunch of other smaller cities, that’s just one big city that you know, considered Phoenix. There’s like a lot of different suburbs.”
 - P5273, who had had trouble understanding who MIGST1 and MIGCTY1 were asking about, noted at this point that as the survey went along, they understood that it was asking about housemates who had moved in within the last year.

Recommendations:

Proxy reporting was also a challenge on this question, but because “don’t know” is already a response option, there are no resulting recommendations.

As noted earlier, we recommend including the date fill below the item on questions with a reference date (i.e., “1 year ago today”).

MIGTOGETH1you (n=20)

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

Findings:**How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous versus how many did not find that to be the case?**

- Of the 20 participants who were probed, 6 had difficulty with this question, but only 1 had a challenge that was not directly related to the names not being filled on the PowerPoint slide. Names will be included when the survey is fielded, so this finding is limited to the testing environment.

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- P4044 thought that asking for names would be too personal. "That's too personal.... Again, I understand it being for the Census, but they don't need to know everybody's first name.... They could have said how many of your family members, or how ... what was your household size one year ago? But asking for their names is asking too much."

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

Because of privacy concerns about listing household members' names, P4044 recommended, "remember how it was stated, like child under 18, child over 18, like you could have put that same answer section versus the name" as an alternative to listing names.

In Round 1 of cognitive testing, at the rostering screen reluctant participants were told by interviewers they did not need to type full names of household members. Although rostering questions were not present in the PowerPoint version in Round 2 and were not specifically tested, unless otherwise required, Census may consider updating earlier rostering screens to include explicit written instruction that participants can use pseudonyms or phrases such as "Oldest Child" to refer to household members. This may improve respondent compliance with the request and reduce any breakoffs related to privacy concerns.

MIGTOGETH1 (n=25)

Did anyone (else) living at your current residence move in within the last year?

- 1 Yes (3)
- 2 No (22)

Findings:

How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous versus how many did not find that to be the case?

- No participants directly reported finding this question challenging or ambiguous; however, one participant gave an unclear answer.

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- P3114 answered "No," only one person. It was unclear what she meant by this. This individual, who answered "No" to MIGSTAT1, currently lives in a five-person household with both related and unrelated individuals and does have a young

child, so it is possible she was only answering about herself and not counting her child.

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report-writers)

No changes recommended.

MIGTOGETH5you (n=18)

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

Findings:

How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous versus how many did not find that to be the case?

- Eighteen participants were asked this question. Of the 14 participants who were probed, one found this question challenging.

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- P3244, who lived with different household members 5 years ago, 1 year ago, and on the date interviewed, said “it’s kind of a trick question” because the names of the household members did not appear on the screen. The interviewer confirmed with the participant who lived in the participant’s household in what periods of time. Although we cannot be certain whether this participant would have struggled with comprehension of this series of questions if the household roster name fills had been programmed, there is no indication that she did not know who lived with her at what time frames.

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

No recommendations at this time; most participants clearly understood the question.

MIGTOGETH5 (n=20)

Did anyone (else) living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- 1 Yes (2)
- 2 No (18)

How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous versus how many did not find that to be the case?

- One participant (P4453) thought the question’s clarity could be improved. The other 19 who were asked the question did not find it challenging, confusing, or ambiguous.

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- P4453 specified that they would prefer to see the year (2020) in the question stem for clarity.
- Note that P3665 answered “No,” and has a child under 5, whose birth they did not consider as “moving in.” When probed about their answer, the participant stated, “I wouldn’t consider him moving in. He’s part of us. He’s part of the family. So, he’s not actually moving in.”

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report-writers)

Because the universe for migration questions includes individuals age 1 year or older, SMEs should consider whether children born within the 5-year reference period time frame count as “moving in,” and include instructions to include or exclude them from this question, such as:

Answer “Yes” if a child age 1 year or older who lives in the household was born within the 5 years.

MIGSTAT5 (n=26)

Were you living at your current residence 5 years ago today?

- 1 Yes (19)
- 2 No (5)

Findings:

How many respondents found this question challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous?

- Generally, this question was not challenging or confusing to participants. Of the 21 participants who received this question and were probed, 12 either preferred the wording as is or had no preference. Nine participants thought it would be helpful if the question included the date fill from “5 years ago today”; 5 of these participants thought it would be personally helpful and 4 thought it would be helpful to others if the date was listed.

What did the respondents who found this question to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous actually find to be challenging, confusing, or potentially ambiguous (and why they found that to be the case)?

- P4152 stated that especially since it was August (during the cognitive testing), it would be helpful to have the exact date as the current year is almost over.
- P5215 did not prefer having the date in this question, stating it is “pretty clean-cut” but did prefer having the date on MIGSTAT1.

Recommendations: (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

Similar to MIGSTAT1, we recommend the following wording and fill, to improve respondent recall and reduce measurement error:

Were you living at your current residence 5 years ago today, on [MONTH DAY, YEAR]?

MIGUS5 (n=8)

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., five years ago today?

- 1 Yes (8)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

How many respondents found the description clear/not clear?

- One of the eight participants who were asked this question found the description unclear. P5054 was confused and read the question more than once, repeating “in the 50 United States.” This was the same wording issue addressed by P3444 in MIGUS1.

Recommendations (Any suggestions for improvement that ensued, either directly from respondents or interpretationally via report writers)

- One participant [P5054] suggested “in one of the 50 states” or “one of the states within the 50 states in the US.”

Our recommendation to reduce burden, as a merged approach between Round 1 and Round 2 of cognitive testing, similar to our recommendation in MIGUS1:

Were you/they living in the United States (within the 50 states or Washington, D.C.) five years ago today?

MIGST5 (n=8)

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Findings:

- 8 participants answered this question and no challenges, confusion, or ambiguity were reported.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

MIGCTY5 (n=8)

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Findings:

Number of skips + information on why:

- None of the eight participants who were asked this question skipped it.

Comments related to question phrasing + dropdown structure:

- None

Distribution of “Don’t Know” and “Other,” as well as any noticeable patterns related to these responses:

- One participant [P5054], was not 100% sure of their county’s name, but they did provide one.

Recommendations

No changes recommended.

MIGPLC5 (n=8)

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Findings:

Number of skips + information on why:

- None of the eight participants who were asked this question skipped it.

Comments related to question phrasing + dropdown structure:

- None

Distribution of “Don’t Know” and “Other,” as well as any noticeable patterns related to these responses:

- None

Recommendations

No changes recommended.

MIG1RFM1 (n=11)

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family (1)
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship (1)

- For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work (0)
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training (0)
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship (4)
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing (1)
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle (0)
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety (0)
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional (0)
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health (1)
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster (0)
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment (0)
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify (2) (save money; for rehab)
- Did not select an answer (1)

Findings:

Categories that posed difficulty and related reasons; how often?

- None of the participants who answered this question expressed or exhibited difficulty with any of the categories.

Categories that got flagged as uncomfortable or sensitive; how often?

- Although none of the specific categories were flagged by any participants as particularly uncomfortable or sensitive, two participants [P3114 and P3515] did say they felt the question in general was sensitive.

Examples that were named as unclear and related reasons; how often?

- No participants named any examples as unclear.

Examples that were named to be missing that would have been helpful; how often?

- One participant [P4044] did not have an issue with any of the specific examples, but expressed that they did not find the inclusion of examples helpful or necessary,
 - "Oh my gosh, okay, we could alleviate all that little tiny, for example, crap, because honestly, if you're filling out this form, you know what family, non-family work, like you know what the main bullets are, you don't need all the extra little tiny crap." [PROBE: Okay, so you don't think that it will help understand what the option is?] "Not at all, because it literally just made my head hurt trying to read it." [P4044]

Categories that participants were torn between and why; how often?/How did participants determine their selection if torn between categories:

- One participant [P5273] whose current residence was a sober living home was unable to decide between "Housing hardship," "Better-suited housing," and "Other, specify":
 - "I can't tell if the answer here would be 'housing hardship' or 'better-suited housing,' just because I mean, if I'm just being blunt, no one ends up living here because everything's going great, so would that be housing hardship or better-suited housing because this is a place for accountability and cheap rent for two years so that you can get back on your feet?... I'm not sure which one would fit better."
- Another participant [P3246] considered "Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle," "Better-suited climate or natural environment" before ultimately choosing "Better-suited neighborhood."
 - "Um, because this is not [county name], this is like you know, like the good parts of somewhere. Yeah, this is like the good parts of um, [county name]. Well, it's not even [county name], it's a whole other county. But it's just, you know, a better environment out here. It's like no high crime." [P3246]
- This person had reported read all of the options but did not seem to have considered "Crime or safety." They said they did not initially read the examples, and that they would have changed their answer.

What reason(s) for moving were given among participants who selected "Other"?

- Two participants selected "Other" for this item. One [P3515] said they would write in "For rehab" and the other said they would write "to save money"[P2490]. Note these were write-in responses provided in the "Other, specify" response option and not suggestions for language changes in the question.

Why didn't participants who selected "Other" feel that their reason for moving was adequately covered by any existing adjacent categories?

- The participant who wrote in "to save money" was asked by the observer why they did not consider "Better-suited housing" as a potential category and instead selected "Other," to which the participant replied, "I guess I had a problem with the category name." [P2490] The observer also asked the participant for any category names that they felt would better capture the idea, and the participant offered "Economics" and "Economic or financial."

- The other participant [P3515], who selected “Other, specify” and wrote in “For rehab,” decided at probing that they should have selected “Better-suited housing” instead. They were also probed about whether they considered the “Health” category while answering the question since it includes “*exited rehabilitation*” in the list of examples. The participant explained that the example “exited rehabilitation” did not make them think about their situation (i.e., a person leaving drug/alcohol rehabilitation/residential treatment) exactly, though it perhaps should have.
 - “Oh okay. You know what I’m thinking, rehabilitation like for, I don’t know why I didn’t think that like.... Yeah, I probably would have, yeah. With rehabilitation, I’m thinking about people who are physically disabled or assisted living, with assisted living I associated with rehabilitation. Yeah, I didn’t catch that.” [P3515]

How often were participants not thinking of their most recent move, if at all?

- Two participants [P3246 and P4458] said they were mistakenly thinking about a previous move, and not about the move to their current residence. One participant [P3246] who selected “family” said they were thinking about how they had moved out of the home owned by their grandfather but not thinking about the reason they moved to their current residence specifically.
- The other participant [P4458] explained that they had answered thinking about a big move 7 years ago and not a more recent move 10 months ago.
 - “Well, since your current residence, to me, the apartment building that I’m in, the townhouse, and the one across the street is like the same residence because it’s the same neighborhood. We just moved across the street from one building to another, a different landlord. But it’s like the same residence, really, because it’s the same neighborhood; we’ve been here. It’s just a few feet away.” [P4458]

Any suggestions for rephrasing the question to make the intended move clearer?

- None of the participants had any suggestions on how the intention of the question could have been clearer.

Recommendations:

See recommendation at MIG1RFM5 below.

MIG2RFM1 (n=10)

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason (3)
- Family (0)
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship (0)
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work (0)

- For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training (0)
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship (2)
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing (3)
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle (1)
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety (0)
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional (0)
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health (0)
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster (0)
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment (1)
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
 - Other, specify (0)

Findings:

Any reasons participants found this question difficult; how often?

- One participant [P4290] expressed some difficulty with the question. This participant [P4290] was confused and thought it was the same question as the previous question (MIG1RFM1) and did not see the difference until they reread it during probing.

Any suggestion on how to rephrase the question to make it clearer; how often?

- Participants did not offer any suggestions beyond making the text easier to read.

Categories that participants were torn between and why; how often?/How did participants determine their selection if torn between categories?

- None of the participants offered specific categories they had trouble choosing between while answering this item. However, one participant [P3515] expressed that they had some difficulty choosing between the categories generally but was ultimately able to do so:

- “Yeah, a little bit because I have the mixture of a few of them, you know. Those kind of, yeah, I just picked the most, the most, the primary reasons.” [P3515]

What reason(s) for moving were given among participants who selected “Other”?

- None of the 10 participants who answered this item selected “Other.”

Why didn’t participants who selected “Other” feel that their reason for moving was adequately covered by any existing adjacent categories?

- None of the 10 participants who answered this item selected ‘Other’.

How often were participants not thinking of their most recent move, if at all?

- One participant [P3246] said at probing that they had been thinking of a previous move when they answered the question and should change their answer from “Better-suited climate or natural environment” to “Better-suited housing.”

Any suggestions for rephrasing the question to make the intended move clearer?

- None of the participants made suggestions for how to rephrase the question.

On missing “No other reason”:

- One participant [P4458] did not see the option to select “No other reason” and instead selected the same answer they had in the previous question (MIG1RFM1). At probing, this participant was asked why they did not select it, and said, “Well, no, I didn’t see that.” [P4458]

On being asked for an additional reason for the move:

- One participant had a strong negative reaction to being asked for a second reason for their most recent move,
 - “Yeah, that was a pointless question to me. If you ask me, it’s pointless, I answered it the first time. No, I don’t wanna go into what the second reason was. Like, the one reason was bad enough. What do I want to go into another reason for? So, the question’s pointless.” [Do you think there will be people who might have more than one reason for moving?] “I’m sure they do, but they don’t want to go into it. Like you asked me what the main concern was in the first question, like just let me focus on the main concern, because by opening up this next question, you’re opening a whole can of worms for me to go into my second, my third, my fourth, my fifth, my sixth. I mean, I could go on and on about the reasons to move, but the main reason was the important one.” [P4044]

Recommendations:

See recommendation for MIG2RFM5 below.

MIG1RFM5 (n=7)

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family (1)
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship (0)
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work (1)
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training (2)
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship (0)
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing (2)
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle (1)
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety (0)
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional (0)
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health (0)
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster (0)
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment (0)
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify (0)

Findings:

Categories that posed difficulty and related reasons; how often?

- None of the participants had difficulty with any of the categories.

Categories that got flagged as uncomfortable or sensitive; how often?

- Again, none of the participants flagged any categories as uncomfortable or sensitive, but one [P4896] said the question was sensitive overall. They did not elaborate on why they found it sensitive.

Examples that were named as unclear and related reasons; how often?

- None of the participants said that any of the examples were unclear when answering this item.

Examples that were named to be missing that would have been helpful; how often?

- One participant [P3153] said one example not included that might be needed was a move because of damage from a fire:
 - "I would put snow and heavy rain under natural disasters, but fires.... Yeah, that's kind of a safety concern, but not a crime safety. I would put that probably under crime and safety, or you know, make a yeah, I would put it under crime and safety. I would put specifically fire, arson, or accidental, you know that kind of thing."

Categories that participants were torn between and why; how often?

- None of the participants spoke about being torn between categories while answering this item.

How did participants determine their selection if torn between categories?

- None of the participants discussed being torn between categories while answering this item.

What reason(s) for moving were given among participants who selected 'Other'?

- No participants selected "Other" for this item.

Why didn't participants who selected "Other" feel that their reason for moving was adequately covered by any existing adjacent categories?

- No participants selected "Other" for this item.

How often were participants not thinking of their most recent move, if at all?

- All participants said they were thinking of their most recent move when answering this item.

Any suggestions for rephrasing the question to make the intended move clearer?

- None of the participants made suggestions for how to rephrase the question.

Recommendations:

Based on one participant's recommendation, a move due to a fire could be added to examples. However, the best placement for it might be with "building issues," under "Housing hardship."

MIG2RFM5 (n=7)

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason (1)

- Family (0)
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship (0)
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work (1)
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training (0)
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship (0)
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing (2)
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle (1)
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety (1)
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional (0)
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health (1)
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster (0)
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment (0)
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify (0)

Findings:

Any reasons participants found this question difficult; how often?

- None of the participants expressed finding this item difficult or exhibited difficulties answering.

Any suggestion on how to rephrase the question to make it clearer; how often?

- No suggestions were offered by participants for this item.

Categories that participants were torn between and why; how often?

- No participants expressed being torn between items while answering this item.

How did participants determine their selection if torn between categories?

- No participants expressed being torn between items while answering this item.

What reason(s) for moving were given among participants who selected “Other”?

- No participants selected “Other” for this item.

Why didn’t participants who selected “Other” feel that their reason for moving was adequately covered by any existing adjacent categories?

- No participants selected “Other” for this item.

How often were participants not thinking of their most recent move, if at all?

- All participants said they were thinking of their most recent move when answering this item.

Any suggestions for rephrasing the question to make the intended move clearer?

- None of the participants made suggestions for how to rephrase the question.

On missing “No other reason”?

- One participant [P5054] selected “Work” for this item as well as for the previous item (MIG1RFM5). At probing, the interviewer asked if they had seen the option for “No other reason,” and the participant said they had not seen it and that they would have selected it if they had seen it.

Recommendations:

- As one participant here and another at MIG2RFM1 both missed the option to select “No other reason,” we recommend additional formatting to highlight this option and differentiate it from the rest of the categories and examples in these two items.
- Based on the confusion of one participant between “rehabilitation” (which they interpreted as physical rehabilitation due to disability or injury) and their own situation of exiting drug and alcohol rehabilitation, consider adding a mention of such programs as, for example, in “exiting rehabilitation or a drug or alcohol rehabilitation program” to clarify if respondents should consider both physical rehabilitation due to disability or injury, as well as drug and alcohol rehabilitation or residential treatment.

7. Question by Question Results – Income

This section presents results and recommendations, where appropriate, for ASEC Income questions. Findings in this section are presented by topic, with findings from the cognitive interviews listed first followed by recommendations. Each question is formatted with the following elements:

- **Question text and response options** that were shown to the participants during cognitive interviewing. Each question is followed by the total number and the counts for each response option.
- **Summary** findings, where applicable (e.g., questions that included significant or overarching findings or recommendations).
- **Findings** grouped by and detailing the answers to key research questions provided by Census Bureau (i.e., from the report back templates).
- **Recommendations** for question changes, when appropriate.

The goal of cognitive interviewing is to collect qualitative feedback from participants about their response process when providing an answer to each question. We have included a report of the responses to each question (i.e., the quantitative data) to provide context for the findings. This response data comes from the response recorded in the notes during the interview. Participants are not required to provide an answer, and thus the total sample who saw the question (“n”) may differ from the total number of responses in some cases.

7.1 Employment (I&O) Questions

Q29a (n=30)

Did [you/^(name)] do any work for pay or profit at any time during 2024, even for one day?

- 1 Yes (25)
- 2 No (5)

Findings:

There were no specific probes for this question.

- Two participants, who worked odd jobs/side gig work, were initially uncertain whether odd jobs should be considered as “for pay or profit.” Both participants ultimately selected “Yes.”
- One participant noted they are retired but they earn extra money doing surveys, mock jury trials, and gambling studies. This participant answered “Yes” after giving it some thought.
- One participant initially was uncertain as to whether he should answer “Yes” to this question. This participant explained:
 - “I don’t get a paycheck.... I work under the table as they used to call it. I don’t know what they call it these days, but I work for cash for different

places.” The participant was unsure if this should count as “work for pay or profit” but decided that he would say “Yes” to this question. (P3313)

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q29b (n=4)

Did you do any temporary, part-time, or seasonal work, even for one day during 2024?

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (4)

Findings:

Did respondents include any Military Reserves or National Guard work?

- No participants were in the Military Reserves or National Guard, so we could not determine whether participants considered this as work when responding to the question.
- None of the four participants who received this question answered “Yes.”

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q30 (n=5)

Did you spend any time trying to find a job or on a temporary layoff during 2024?

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (5)

Findings:

How did respondents interpret “on temporary layoff”; what does the term “on layoff” mean to them?

- All participants interpreted “temporary layoff” to mean the employer could bring you back at another time.
- However, when asked specifically what “On layoff” meant (n=5), three participants thought it meant the same as temporary layoff, while another two thought it meant that you were permanently cut from your position or that the company has “let you go.”

Recommendations:

No change recommended. The term “temporary layoff” seems to be well understood by participants compared with the term “on layoff.”

Q31 (n=0)

How many weeks in total were you looking for work or on temporary layoff in 2024?

_____ weeks

[] all 52 weeks in 2024

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q32 (n=5)

What was the main reason you did not work in 2024?

- 1 Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern (0)
- 2 Chronic health condition or disability (1*)
- 3 Retired (3)
- 4 Pregnancy or childbirth (0)
- 5 Taking care of children or others (0)
- 6 Going to school (0)
- 7 Unable to find work (0)
- 8 On temporary layoff (0)
- 9 Not interested in working (0)
- 10 Some other reason (0)
- 11 No response (1)

*Participant selected responses #2 and #3 but ultimately could not decide between the two responses.

Findings:

Did respondents find any of the response options confusing or have difficulty deciding on a response?

- Most participants did not have any confusion with this question or the response categories.
- However, one participant was unsure if they should select “retirement” or “chronic health condition” since her health condition is what led to her retirement. Ultimately, the participant could not decide between the two and did not select a response.

Are we missing any reasons? If “Some other reason” was chosen, what was the reason?

- No participants selected “Some other reason,” nor did they offer any additional reasons that we should include in the list.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q33 (n=26)

During 2024, how many weeks did you do any work, even for a few hours?

Include paid vacation and sick leave as work.

_____ weeks of work, including paid leave

[] all 52 weeks in 2024

Findings:

- Seven participants selected, “all 52 weeks in 2024,” while the others provided varying responses from “1 week” to “50 weeks”
- Some participants (n=4) found it difficult to answer the question as it required recall and some calculation/estimation.
 - One participant explained, “Let’s just, let’s just say, like maybe, I don’t know, a dozen, or fifteen weeks ... out of the year, probably not more than twenty.” This participant answered ‘somewhere between 15–20 weeks total,’ then ultimately arrived at 15 weeks. (P3313)
 - Another participant, who worked at a school, explained that it was difficult to calculate, “So I wouldn’t quite know how to.... How many weeks did you do any work? Well, the school year is 40 weeks.... But I couldn’t tell you how many of those weeks I worked.” Interviewer asked how they think they might answer this if completing interview on their own, “I would take a guess and say about 30 weeks.” (P3418)
- Two other participants had a similar experience in determining an estimate. These participants did not seem to be too burdened by this exercise and put a lot of thought into providing an accurate response.

Did respondents read the instruction to count paid vacation/sick leave as work? If not, did the additional text next to the response box help?

- The participants all read the instruction, but several (n=8) felt that it did not apply to them as they do not take vacations or get sick.
- Other participant(s) (n=4) mentioned that their job was part time and that they do not receive paid vacations.
- One self-employed/1099 employee felt the qualifying statement did not apply to them as they do not receive “paid vacations or sick leave” like those who work for an employer. However, they were still able to answer the question.

- Another participant wasn't sure how long she was on unemployment and whether this should be included or not.
 - She explained, "I think the part I am not totally clear on is the paid leave portion." This participant explained that if this had an instruction to NOT include unemployment, she would have answered differently. This participant answered "All 52 weeks," which included her unemployment. [P3172]

Did respondents follow the instruction to count any work at all during the week as a full week of work? For example, if they lost their job on a Monday, that's a week of work.

- Some participants (n=4) found it a little burdensome to calculate the response as they worked part-time in 2024. However, they ultimately provided a response as they counted weeks that they worked, even if only a few hours.
- Another participant excluded weeks where they did not work a full week as they would not consider working 1 or 2 days a week as a "week worked."
 - This participant explained, "For somebody working part-time, these questions are a little ... they're not necessarily straightforward for how you answer them and is going to be a little mentally challenging on the math on this." This participant said that at his last week in the first job, he got laid off midway through the week and didn't work that full week, but he tried to accurately estimate the number of weeks he worked there the best he could. The interviewer clarified that if you only worked 1–2 days in a week, would they consider this a whole week worked. The participant responded that they would not consider that a whole week. [P4958]
- Most participants followed the instructions and counted any work completed in a week as a full week of work.

Recommendations:

Overall, the question performed well but may benefit from additional testing and revision to determine what changes might be helpful for respondents who may not consider or count partial worked weeks (e.g., 1–2 days) when responding to the question.

For example, a version of the question that revises the label to "weeks of *any* work..." or just "weeks" could be tested to determine if this would address issues with respondents who wanted to report only "full" weeks of work.

We also recommend considering a more robust instruction on this item to count *any* weeks of work at all, even if less than a standard week or only a few hours were worked in that week. For example: *Count any weeks of work as a full week, even if only for a few hours during that week.*

A new question could also be considered prior to this item that states: *Did you work every week in 2025, even if only for a few hours certain weeks?* This item would also include an instruction about paid leave and expanded instructions

Q35. (n=0)

Did you lose any full weeks of work in 2024 because you lost a job or were on temporary layoff from a job?

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q36 (n=13)

Of the weeks you were not working, how many full weeks were you looking for a job or on temporary layoff?

_____ weeks

Findings:

How well did respondents remember the number of weeks? Did respondents have any trouble with the instruction to report full weeks only?

- Participants did not have any issues with this question. They explained how they came up with their response, based on the time they were not working and looking for a job or on temporary layoff.
- One participant, who is semi-retired, was not sure how to answer this question and explained that he is never looking for a job and spends time volunteering and occasionally doing "odd jobs." This participant ultimately decided to report "0."
- Another retired participant explained that she does not receive much Social Security and that she is always looking to pick up some kind of gig work each week. As a result, she answered "50" to this question.

Do respondents know the term "on temporary layoff" and that it is different from "laid off"?

- The participants did not seem to have any difficulty understanding the term "on temporary layoff," and while there was no probe on this, no participants raised a concern about the terminology.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q38 (n=6)

During the weeks you were not working, what was the main reason?

- 1 Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern (0)
- 2 Chronic health condition or disability (0)
- 3 Retired (4)
- 4 Pregnancy or childbirth (0)
- 5 Taking care of children or other persons (0)
- 6 Going to school (0)
- 7 Not interested in working (0)
- 8 Some other reason (2)
- 9 Did not answer (0)

Findings:

- Participants who received this question did not have any challenges providing a response.
- A few participants thought of several reasons but were ultimately able to decide on a “main” reason.

If “Some other reason,” what was the reason?

- Two participants selected “some other reason.” One participant explained they selected “Some other reason” because they just do not like to work; it was not clear if this respondent noticed the “Not interested in working” response.
- One retired participant was not sure what to select as he is retired but willingly only works part-time. He considered the “Retired” category but did not feel this described his situation.
 - He explained, “I would say ‘Some other reason’ because I am intentionally only working part-time because I am retired. So, I don’t know. I guess maybe that’s the main reason.” (P4766)]

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q39a (n=24)

In 2024, did you have more than one job or business?

If you do similar work across multiple clients or apps, count those as one job or business.

- 1 Yes (10)
- 2 No (14)

Findings:

What did respondents think of this question?

- One participant was not sure how to answer as they held one job and then was out of work for about 9 weeks before starting another job. Ultimately, this participant selected "Yes" after giving it some thought.
 - They explained, "Yes ... well, not at the same time. I had two jobs, but they weren't at the same time. I don't know what they mean by 'not at the same time or not.'" (P5339)
- Another participant accidentally answered "Yes" to this question, due to the wording of the question, but did not elaborate on the confusion other than saying they felt the question was awkward as written. The participant recommended we rewrite the question as "How many jobs or businesses did you have in 2024?"

Did they read the second instruction sentence and, if so, did they find it to be clear?

- Most participants read the instruction, but some (n=4) skipped over it as they knew it did not apply to them.
- Participants felt the second sentence was clear, referring to things like consulting work where you might have multiple clients or rideshare/delivery for places like DoorDash or Lyft.
- One participant found this question to be difficult to answer because she does odd jobs/gig work and explained that there is more than one app or place to work. Ultimately, she answered correctly by selecting "Yes" and understood this based on the clarifying sentence.

Recommendations:

Although one participant (P5339) was unsure if this question was asking about situations where multiple jobs are occurring at the same time or situations where they left one job and started another job, we do not recommend any changes. Question 39c specifically asks about working more than one job at the same time, which helped address this respondent's confusion (see Q39c findings).

Q39b (n=11)

How many jobs or businesses did you have in 2024? If you do similar work across multiple clients or apps, count those as one job or business.

- 1 Two (6)
- 2 Three or more (5)

Findings:

- One participant was not sure what was meant by "similar work across multiple clients."

- Another participant explained that it was unclear whether the question was referring to jobs performed “at the same time” or “separately.”

Did respondents have any trouble remembering the number of employers? How did they come to their response (thought process)?

- Most participants did not have any trouble remembering their number of employers.
- One participant, who was self-employed, responded “three or more.” She found it somewhat difficult to answer as she had to think back across the year and count how many jobs she had in 2024. She may have answered incorrectly, as responses to later questions indicated that she works for a single company, reviewing AI responses to tasks. It appears she may be counting all those individual tasks as separate “jobs,” although this was not probed on by the interviewer.

If respondents mentioned participating in gig/platform-based work (e.g., Uber, Lyft, Grubhub) or being self-employed, did they struggle with this question? Did the second instruction sentence influence how they answered the question?

- One participant who worked various odd jobs and selected “two” and explained:
 - “Now, I didn’t count, um, the little side jobs that I did on these, because they wasn’t really jobs, just like everybody else, once in a while, I would go and, somebody would need some help painting a room and I did it for cash and those types of things, but I didn’t, I didn’t count that, you know, so.” (P4958)
 - It was determined during probing, that this participant held two regular jobs at different times in 2024, in addition to the side jobs he performed. He counted the two jobs but did not count all the side jobs as a “third” job.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q39c (n=7)

Did you work at those jobs or businesses at the same time at any point during 2024?

- 1 Yes (4)
- 2 No (3)

Findings:

Did respondents understand the question? Did they have any trouble deciding how to respond?

- One participant who experienced some confusion in Q39a (P5339) mentioned that he liked the wording “at the same time” better than the previous question as it was easier to understand. The participant was confused by wording on Q39a because the question doesn’t specify if they should be consider jobs that occur “at the same time” or “separately.”

- Another participant (P4180) assumed this question was asking if she held both positions concurrently, at the same time. Therefore, she selected “Yes.” However, she questioned whether the wording meant “holding both jobs consecutively or concurrently” as the question appeared vague to her.

Did any respondents only work multiple jobs at the same time for part of the year; if so, how did they come to their response (thought process)?

- Two participants worked multiple jobs at the same time for part of the year.
- One participant explained that she worked the full-time and part-time job at the same time for part of the year. She was certain that she worked both jobs at some point in 2024 but couldn’t remember when she quit one of the jobs.
- Another participant said that this was just for part of 2024, explaining that she does one of the jobs all year long and the other one has been more project hiring where she is on and off for a few months at a time.
 - She explained, “These questions do not easily fit the schematic of my work profile very easily.... I’m trying to understand what you guys are trying to accomplish with these questions.” (P4766)
 - After the interviewer explained that we want people who don’t work typical 9-to-5 office jobs to be able to understand and be able to report on their jobs, the participant said that with part-time work it can be difficult to recall.
 - Ultimately, the participant was sure that she worked multiple jobs at the same time for part of 2024.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q39d (n=5)

Did you work at any of those jobs or businesses at the same time at any point during 2024?

- 1 No (2)
- 2 Yes, at most two at the same time (2)
- 3 Yes, three or more at the same time (1)

Findings:

Did respondents understand the question?

- Participants felt the question was clear.

Did any respondents struggle deciding between which “Yes” option to choose; if so, what was their thought process on how they came to their answer?

- Participants had no trouble deciding between responses.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q41 (n=25)

In the weeks that you worked, how many hours did you usually work per week?

_____ hours

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question.
- One participant who worked multiple jobs asked whether this should include hours across both jobs.
- A couple of participants who worked part-time or did gig work reported their hours often varied by week, and thus had more difficulty answering as they had to come up with an estimate or “average” number hours worked in a typical week. Participants explained that they did not find this process difficult; it just required some thought.
 - “I would say there was an average so I would just give a random number like 20 hours.” (P4220)
 - “Once again, I can work 3 days, which would be 18 hours or a day, which would be 6 hours.” (P3418)
- One participant who was self-employed found it difficult to estimate as she does not have a “usual” week. She was concerned that since this is requested by the government, she felt like it should be accurate. If completing the survey on her own, she might not answer at all rather than provide an inaccurate estimate.
 - “This is hard, because I am self-employed. My billable hours worked is so much different than my work on my website.... I don’t have a “usual” week. Because this is a government document, you feel like it needs to be accurate. It would make me nervous to guess. I might not answer this at all.” (P4454)

Recommendations:

Consistent with questions in the income section, we recommend including a statement:

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

Q43 (n=11)

Were there one or more weeks where you worked less than 35 hours?

Do not count time off with pay like holidays, vacation, or sick leave.

- 1 Yes (5)
- 2 No (7)

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question and no issues were found.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q44 (n=18)

How many weeks in 2024 did you work less than 35 hours?

_____ weeks

[] all the weeks worked

Findings:

- Six participants selected “all the weeks worked.”
- One participant initially interpreted this to be “more than 35 hours?” and had to change their response.

How well do respondents remember the number of weeks in which they worked less than 35 hours?

- Most participants had to estimate the number of weeks as it was difficult for them to remember.
- One participant, who works at a school, found it difficult, explaining:
 - “There are only 40 weeks in a school year ... 52 weeks in a year, so there’s 12 weeks I for sure worked less than 35 hours. And then based on how many other factors there were, I worked less than 35 hours.” The interviewer went back to Q33 where, for “How many weeks worked,” the participant answered 30, explaining, “Because there’s 40 weeks in a school year and I figured I worked all but 10 of those let’s say. The difference is the school year versus the calendar year.” (P3418)

How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process)?

- In general, participants did not find the question overly difficult. They had to determine an estimate, which took some thought, but felt confident in their response.
- Participants who worked part-time knew it would be all the weeks worked, and those who worked full-time had to think of the weeks they worked less without counting holidays, vacation, or sick leave, as that context was established with the previous question.

Did participants include weeks where they worked less than 35 hours because they were on paid vacation/sick leave?

- None of the participants counted weeks where they worked less than 35 hours because they were on paid vacation/sick leave.

Recommendations:

Consistent with questions in the income section, we recommend including a statement:

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

Q45 (n=18)

What was the **main reason** you worked less than 35 hours per week?

- 1 Could not find a full-time job (1)
- 2 Job was part-time (8)
- 3 Seasonal work (1)
- 4 Business was slow (3)
- 5 Weather conditions
- 6 Physically unable to work full time (2)
- 7 Going to school (1)
- 8 Caring for family or personal obligation (1)
- 9 Some other reason (1)

Findings:

- One participant explained that some people might not want to work 35 hours, or they may get government assistance. They suggested adding a response option to capture these situations. However, these participants may also fall under the “job was part-time” option.

Were any of the response options unclear or confusing?

- The participants all felt the response options were clear.

Did any respondents feel multiple options applied; if so, how did they decide on the “main” reason?

- Some participants (n=4) could have selected more than one response but understood this question to be asking about the “main” reason. Two participants had some trouble selecting a “main” reason.
 - One participant explained, “I guess I would have chosen ‘caring for family’ as kind of like paid vacation, or sick time.” The participant also selected “Business was slow” and thought about selecting “Weather conditions” because of working outside. The participant ultimately selected “business was slow” because work opportunities were sometimes not available with different clients. (P5353)

If “Some other reason” was selected, probe on what the reason was and why they did not feel any of the other response options were appropriate.

- One participant (P5339) indicated that their “boss [i.e., the school] dictated it” as the reason they worked less than 35 hours those weeks. This participant, who worked at a school, said holiday or vacation days were granted, but there were also school-approved (i.e., holiday school closures) or school-required days off, such as “snow days,” “election day,” and “parent-teacher conference” days. This participant explained that “weather conditions” would fit for snow days off from school, but they wouldn’t fit for parent-teacher conference days or other times the school was closed and they did not work. This participant was thinking about the weeks in which they worked less than 35 hours per week due to these school closures or school-required days off when responding.

Recommendations:

Consider revising the question to reference the number of weeks from Q44 that the respondent reported not working:

Thinking about the [FILL WEEKS] weeks that you worked less than 35 hours, what was the main reason?

"For those [FILL WEEKS] weeks that you worked less than 35 hours, what was the main reason?"

Consider revising response options to account for summer breaks (e.g., seasonal work/summer break) or other time periods where workplaces are closed to address the confusion experienced by the school employee.

Q45a (n= 2)

Why were you physically unable to work full time?

- 1 Injury (0)
- 2 Short-term illness (0)
- 3 Chronic health condition or disability (1)
- 4 Some other reason (1 -)

Findings:

- Only two participants received this question.

Did respondents understand the response options or find any of them confusing?

- One participant was unsure of which option to pick because their diagnosis was related to mental health, but they did not see that as an option listed and chose "some other reason."

Where do/would respondents include mental or emotional health?

- As described above, one participant did consider mental health but was unsure where to include it and selected "some other reason."

If "Some other reason" was selected, probe on why they didn't feel any of the other response options applied.

- The participant did not elaborate but did not feel "mental health" fell into any of these categories.

Recommendations:

Consider adding a response option for "Mental or Emotional Health."

Q47a (n=25)

What employer did you work for the longest in 2024?

Employer name: _____

Findings:

- Some (n=2) participants are self-employed and weren't sure how to respond in some cases.
- One participant explained that he doesn't work for an employer as they have a neighborhood web page where people can post if they need help with something and he answered a couple of ads to do yard work. He basically works for himself.
- Another participant entered "Nobody," explaining that he works for himself as a freelance worker.
 - Another participant answered "Self-employed," explaining, "I worked for, I guess myself, but a market firm." The participant wrote in "self-employed" as the response. (P5353)
- Another participant asked if self-employment is included in this question because they did not see it mentioned. (P4152)

If they worked for more than one employer in 2024, how did they determine which one was the longest? If they worked multiple jobs for the same amount of time, how did they determine which one to put?

- Most participants did not have any challenge determining the employer they worked for the longest as it was immediately clear to them how to respond. Participants who were self-employed or worked gig jobs found it more difficult as they needed to think through the jobs they performed in 2024.
- Participants mentioned things like, it was their permanent employer, it was considered their main job, they spent the most time at that employer, or it was the job comprising more than 50% of their time.

Recommendations:

Consider adding a selection box below the response box for "Self-employed/Freelance." Another consideration is to switch the placement of Q47e1 and Q47a so that participants can select "Self-employed" prior to answering Q47a.

Q47e1 (n=25)

Which best describes this employer or business?

- 1 Private for-profit company (4)
- 2 Non-profit organization including tax exempt and charitable organizations (0)
- 3 Government (1)
- 4 Self-employed (2)
- 5 Unpaid family business or farm (0)

Findings:

Did the responses overlap? Which ones overlapped and how did respondents choose the “best”?

- None of the participants felt the responses overlapped. They were able to select a response that best described their employer or business.

Did respondents know which employer the question was asking about?

- Participants explained that this was referencing the employer described in the previous question (i.e., the one they worked for the longest in 2024).
 - One participant explained, “Because the previous question had been about which one that I worked at the longest, I just assumed that was still the one they were talking about.” (P4958)

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q47e1a (n=2)

Which one of the following best describes this government job?

- 1 Federal - (Federal government civilian employee) (0)
- 2 Active Duty (U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps) (0)
- 3 State (including state colleges/universities) (1)
- 4 Local (county, city, township) (city or county school district) (1)

Findings:

- Only two participants received this question.

Did they need the extra information in the parentheses to find the right response?

- The participants felt the information was helpful.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q47e1b (n=8)

Was this business incorporated?

- 1 Yes (3)
- 2 No (5)

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question.

- One participant answered “No” as he did not know what the question was asking about.
- Another participant was not sure about the definition of incorporated, but selected “Yes” because she said it was a legitimate business.

Recommendations:

Consider adding a definition of “incorporated” with SMEs consulting on the most appropriate definition of the term.

Q47e1c (n=0)

Were you the owner of this business?

- 1 Yes (0)
- 2 No (0)

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q4788 (n=24)

Counting all locations where this business operated, what was the total number of employees in 2024?

- 1 1-9 (8)
- 2 10-49 (1)
- 3 50-99 (2)
- 4 100-499 (3)
- 5 500-999 (4)
- 6 1,000+ or more (4)
- 7 Don't know (2)

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question.
- Most participants had no difficulty answering this question.
- One participant, however, explained that he had no idea what the number was and said he would likely skip this question if answering this on a survey.
- Another participant answered “Don't know.”

Recommendations:

Most participants should be able to answer this question, so we would not recommend adding a “don’t know” response. Another option would be to not offer a “Don’t know” response initially, but if respondents try and skip the question, then “Don’t know” and “Refused” response options would appear. This is often done in other surveys as a soft prompt.

Q47b (n=25)

What kind of business or industry was this?

Include the main activity, product, or service provided at the location where employed.

(For example: elementary school, residential construction)

Kind of Business: _____

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question.
- Participants provided a variety of responses and had no concerns in answering this question. Some examples of how participants responded are provided below:
 - “Manufacturing” (P3907)
 - “Maintenance” (P3313)
 - “Elementary School” (P3311)
 - “Temp agency” (P3114)
 - “Department of Labor” (P3173)
 - “Yard work” (P3180)
 - “Education” (P3418)
 - “Land Inspection” (P3373)
 - “Photography sales” (P4152)
 - “Start-up” (P4220)
 - “Workforce and education development” (P4302)
 - “Retail sales” (P4958; P4865)
 - “Delivery service” (P5215)
 - “Telecommunications” (P5339;P5273)
 - “Market Research” (P4225)
 - “Data Analytics” (P4454)
- Responses included the actual name of the business or description of the business, even for gig work, such as “Yard work or Uber driver.”

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q47b1 (n=23)

What was the primary industry of this business?

- 1 Manufacturing (0)
- 2 Retail trade (5)
- 3 Wholesale trade (0)
- 4 Something else (18)

Findings:

- There were no specific probes for this question.
- Interestingly, 18 of the 23 participants selected “Something else.” Interviewers asked them to elaborate, and they explained that these were “odd jobs,” “distribution,” “warehousing,” and “service industry jobs.” A few participants said “retention center.”
- One participant said that the word “trade” was confusing. They felt we could just list “Manufacturing,” “Retail,” “Wholesale,” or something else.

Recommendations:

If analytically useful, consider adding an open-ended response for respondents to type in the industry if they select “Something else.” Another suggestion is to add other classifications that would fall into “Something else” so that more respondents can easily find their industry, even if these responses are then recoded into “something else” during analysis.

Q47c (n=25)

What kind of work were you doing at this job or business in 2024?

For example: 4th grade teacher, entry-level plumber

Main Occupation: _____

Findings:

What did people report when they did not have an official job title? Did they know how to answer?

- Participants provided a description of the job such as:
 - “Yard care” (P3180)
 - “Guest teacher” (PP3418)
 - “Contractor to help with business operations” (P4220)
 - Public relations (P3173)
 - Various occupations within one temp agency (P3114)

- "Warehouse manager" (P3291)
- "Receiving department" (P3907)
- "Special education classroom assistant" (P3311)
- "Photography" (P4152)
- "Employee engagement manager" (P4302)
- "Inbound customer service" (P4958)
- "Concierge like tasks" (P4613)
- "Data analysis" (P4454)
- One participant wasn't sure what to enter, explaining, "It varied. So do you want me to list multiple types of jobs, or do you want me to like stick with varied?" The participant entered, "Various occupations within that one temp agency." (P3114).

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

Q47d1 (n=25)

What were your most important activities or duties in 2024?

For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe sections and review building plans for work details.

Job Duties: _____

Findings:

How did respondents decide on the order of their duties—what activities were most important? Are the most important ones listed first?

- Participants were descriptive in responding to this question, providing a variety of duties that they perform. They generally provided two or three examples beginning with the most important activities that they perform.
- One participant was not sure what "duties" referred to and then read the examples and realized it was referring to "job" duties.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

7.2 Income Questions

7.2.1 Earned Income

EMP_INC_TYP (n=20)

Select the types of income that (^name/you) received while working at (^your/their) employer in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Salary or wages (n=17)
- 2 Tips (n=1)
- 3 Bonuses (n=2)
- 4 Overtime pay (n=6)
- 5 Commissions (n=2)
- 6 Piece rate or pay per item of work (n=5)

Findings:

Did respondents understand all of the response options?

- Some participants (n=3) said that they were not sure what “piece rate” meant at first, but some were able to figure out what it meant using context clues (i.e., “pay per item of work”). For example, one participant explained:
 - “The piece rate was a little unclear at first, but I figure, someone that works on that type of pay structure would know what it means..... Oh, no, that makes sense, if you do like silk-screening, you get paid per shirt.” (P5273)
- One participant said that “overtime pay” and “bonuses” could each mean different things to different people. This participant wanted to know how to define “overtime pay” and “bonuses,” as “bonuses” was vague.

Was anyone who regularly received tips confused by the question wording?

- One participant selected “tips,” and they said that the wording of this question made sense to them.

Other findings:

- One participant who is retired but does occasional yard work for neighbors said that both “piece rate or pay per item of work” and “salary or wages” could be applicable to their job because their neighbors pay a flat rate for one job. The participant ultimately chose “piece rate or pay per item of work.”
- Participants with multiple jobs differed in how many jobs they considered when answering this question:
 - Two participants who had multiple jobs in 2024 said that they were not sure if they should be answering for both jobs or only for the job that they had for the longest in 2024. One participant explained, “However, I did for a second wonder is this the single employer or the long-term employer or is this combining all jobs worked?” (P 3269) This participant answered thinking only about the job they had the longest in 2024 and the other participant answered about both jobs.

- As this was not a scripted probe, it is not clear how some participants with multiple jobs answered this question. However, there were three other respondents who explained during the think-aloud or probing discussion that they thought about all jobs in 2024.

Recommendations:

As some participants did not know what “piece rate” meant, consider rephrasing this response option.

Although participants with multiple jobs differed in whether they thought about their main job or all jobs in 2024, using “(^your/their) employer” instead of filling in the specific job appeared to be the primary source of confusion. However, this may have been a limitation of testing (i.e., “employer” is not filled in here, but this may be what is intended in production). We recommend using a fill for the employer name in production. This may be filled within the question, or as a stand-alone fill below the item (e.g., Employer: [FILL]).

Select the types of income that (^name/you) received while working at (^employer name) in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Salary or wages
- 2 Tips
- 3 Bonuses
- 4 Overtime pay
- 5 Commissions
- 6 Pay per item/unit of work

EMP_INC_AMT (n=17)

How much did (^name/you) earn from this employer before taxes and other deductions in 2024?

Include:

(^fill selected types from Q48a_source) in bulleted format

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

- 1 Numeric response (varied) (n=15)
- 2 Not sure (n=1)
- 3 Refused (n=1)

Findings:

For those who reported multiple sources in the preceding question, how did they think about combining these different sources on the fly? Was it difficult for them? Would it have been easier if any items were broken out separately?

- Eight participants reported multiple types of income on **EMP_INC_TYP**. There were four participants who reported multiple types of income on **EMP_INC_TYP** but were not asked this probe and it is unclear if they thought this was easy or difficult.
- Of the participants who were asked this probe, all but one had multiple jobs/employers in 2024. Some of these participants expressed difficulty with answering this question, but their difficulty was not in combining income sources or types. Instead, they struggled with deciding whether they should be reporting income from one or all jobs in 2024 (see “Other findings” below). However, these participants knew their monthly or gross income for each job and could calculate an estimated answer.
- Other participants (n=3) said this question was difficult to answer:
 - One participant, who received salary or wages, bonuses, overtime pay, and commissions, opened an ADP payroll app and found the answer. They noted that without the app, it would have been “impossible” to calculate this himself.
 - One participant preferred to report income separately for each source. This participant added her monthly income across all jobs and then multiplied by 12 to arrive at the answer.
 - One participant wanted to have the option of reporting income by year, week, or month, as a salary would be easier to report annually but other sources of income like bonuses or overtime pay would be easier to report by week or month.

If earnings are variable (e.g., different each month), is there an easier way for them to report info to allow an annual amount to be determined?

- Seven participants said that their earnings varied each paycheck.
- Of the four participants who were asked if they would prefer to report for a different time period, all said that it was easier to report their annual income than for another time frame because other time frames would be more time consuming to calculate. For example: “Some people know exactly how much they get paid each pay period, but if you’re in a variable situation, it’s not gonna be the same, so I would just keep it at the annual level.” (P4766)

Was the instruction to provide their best estimate helpful? What does “best estimate” mean to respondents?

- Most participants said that this instruction to provide their best estimate was helpful, explaining that it was encouraging to them that they did not have to provide a precise answer.
 - “Yes, because, you know, I was trying to do quick math in my head.” (P4302)
 - “Best estimate is letting people round it off.” (P4613)

- Two participants said they would have given an estimate even without the inclusion of the instruction.
 - "I would give my best estimate anyway because I wouldn't remember anyway, the exact figure unless I grabbed ahold of my tax, um my tax folder, that my CPA has prepared.... I'm used to government forms or questions like these where they want your best estimate. I just assume that's what they want." (P5339)
- Two participants said they would prefer that this instruction was placed immediately after the question stem, as it was displayed underneath the bullet points of income sources and therefore was easy to miss.
- The meaning of "best estimate" was not specifically probed.

Other findings:

- Some participants with multiple jobs in 2024 mentioned that this question was confusing because it said "this employer" and they were not sure which employer they were being asked about.
- One participant gave the answer for their annual salary, but during probing, realized that they retired in September 2024 and changed their answer to account for this.
- One participant gets paid hourly and said that it is difficult to calculate annual income for an hourly worker and that this question is designed for a salaried worker.

Recommendations:

Recommend further testing of this item to determine the extent that participants who have multiple types of income have difficulty reporting.

Similar to **EMP_INC_TYP**, although participants with multiple jobs differed in whether they thought about their main job or all jobs in 2024, using "(^your/their) employer" appeared to be the primary source of confusion and may have been a limitation of testing. We recommend using a fill for the employer name in production (e.g., Employer: [FILL]).

EMP_INC_RNG (n=2)

Select a range that indicates how much (^name/you) earned from this employer before taxes and other deductions in 2024.

Include:

(^fill selected types from Q48a_source) in bulleted format

- 1 \$0–14,999 (n=1)
- 2 \$15,000–\$29,999 (n=1)
- 3 \$30,000–\$44,999
- 4 \$45,000–\$59,999
- 5 \$60,000 or more

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than a specific value?

- One participant with multiple jobs said that they have no idea what their income is because it varies year to year.
- The other participant said that the ranges were easier for them to answer because they don't always have the exact numbers at their fingertips.

Did respondents feel these ranges are too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- One participant said that the last response option, "\$60,000 or more," was too small. The other participant was not asked this probe.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

BUS_INC_TYP (n=6)

Select the types of income that (^name/you) received from (^fill self-employment) in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Salary or wages (n=1)
- 2 Tips (n=1)
- 3 Bonuses
- 4 Overtime pay
- 5 Commissions (n=1)
- 6 Piece rate or pay per item of work (n=5)

Description of participants' employment:

- The six participants who received this question were all freelance workers or contractors:
 - One is retired but occasionally does odd jobs (e.g., yard work for neighbors)
 - One only works odd jobs under the table with very limited income
 - One is a contractor who does tasks such as project management, business development, and brand building
 - One works for DoorDash
 - One is a door-to-door salesman
 - One is a freelance worker for Outlier AI
- It should be noted that none of these participants own their own businesses. Because these participants are freelance workers or contractors, some of these questions did not make sense for their employment situations.

Did respondents understand all of the response options?

- Three participants were unsure what "piece rate" meant and whether this represented the type of income that they receive:

- One participant receives a flat rate for doing yard work. He was not sure whether this should be categorized as “Piece rate or pay per item of work” or “Salary or wages” and ended up choosing both.
- “I just get paid, usually that day, but sometimes if I’m going to be working for them for like a week, I might get paid at the end of that week. And I do sometimes get bonuses, sometimes they give me other stuff. Which is nice, cause they know I’m poor. Sometimes they give me, like, shoes or food, or whatever on top of pay.” (P3313) This participant ended up choosing “Piece rate or pay per item of work” because they did not consider bonuses to include items like shoes or food. This participant was also not sure what commissions meant.
- One participant is a contractor who receives income as a flat rate on a monthly basis. Although they were initially confused by “piece rate” (i.e., “I would say piece-rate, but I don’t really know what piece-rate means here.” (P4220).] This participant ultimately chose this response option.

Was anyone who regularly receives tips confused by the question wording?

- One participant received tips from DoorDash customers. They thought that the question was clear.

Recommendations:

Similar to EMP_INC_TYP, some participants did not know what “piece rate” meant. Consider rephrasing this response option or providing a brief definition.

Select the types of income that (^name/you) received while working at (^employer name) in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Salary or wages
- 2 Tips
- 3 Bonuses
- 4 Overtime pay
- 5 Commissions
- 6 Pay per item/unit of work

BUS_INC_DESC (n=8)

What best describes (^name’s/your) earnings from (^fill self-employment) in 2024? (n=8)

Include:

(^fill selected types from source) in bulleted format

- 1 Positive (earnings were greater than expenses) (n=7)
- 2 Broke even (earnings and expenses were equal)
- 3 Loss (earnings were less than expenses) (n=1)

Were the concepts of positive earnings or loss ones that respondents were familiar with? Were there other words they might use to describe earnings being greater than expenses or earnings being less than expenses?

- All participants except for one said that these phrases were clear and were terms that they are familiar with.
 - Only one participant was not as familiar with these terms; however, this participant chose their employment type as self-employed because they are a contractor, but they do not consider themselves self-employed.

Did respondents know this information at an annual level or would they have preferred to report a lower periodicity (monthly, quarterly)?

- All participants said that it was easy to report this information at an annual level.
- Three participants noted that while answering at an annual level was easy for them, it might be easier for others to report a lower periodicity. They, however, did not have a preference themselves.
- Three participants preferred to report at an annual level.
- One participant would prefer to report at a quarterly level: “Ideally, yes, it would be better quarterly. Because of the holidays, there are times when people are spending less throughout the year.” (P4152)

How did respondents think about variable earnings or expenses (e.g., different every month or quarter) when answering this question?

- No data to report. This was not specifically probed.

Other findings:

- Two participants were confused by the visual formatting of this question. One participant thought that they needed to choose one of the types of income in the bullet points in addition to selecting an answer for positive/even/loss. The other participant thought it was asking them for the same information as the previous question, before seeing the response options of positive/even/loss.
 - This finding might not be an issue in the field, if there is better visual differentiation between bullet points and choosable response options. Further, due to the limitations of testing, we were not able to fill the income types listed in the previous question. As this question will not list all income types in the field, this finding may not be relevant. However, we should monitor this in usability testing.

Recommendations:

As noted above, none of these participants owned their own businesses and were all contractors or freelance workers. Therefore, the way that this question is phrased (i.e., comparing earnings to expenses) wasn’t applicable to their employment situation. SMEs should ensure that the skip logic for this question is being asked of the correct population.

BUS_POS_AMT (n=7)

How much were (^name's/your) net earnings, before taxes, in 2024?

Net earnings are total earnings minus expenses for the year. If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

- 1 Numeric answer (varied) (n=6)
- 2 Not sure (n=1)

How did they determine their answer? Did they know this number off the top of their head or were they doing mental math based on earnings and expenses? Or did they use some other strategy? Did they include all income sources?

- One participant was not sure if he should include all his income when reporting this amount but ultimately decided to only include earnings from self-employment. This participant also said that he wanted more explanation of what was meant by "earnings."
 - "Doing this survey, from what I've seen so far, I would say from the work that I have done. But I have done some surveys where they ask what was your net earnings and they would say [ask me to include] my Social Security, what I'm making from my 401ks, what I made working. So, this question needs or should be changed a little bit.... I won a raffle that paid me [less than \$20,000]. Is that earnings?" (P3180)
- Three participants said that they estimated their answer.
 - One participant, who does not have steady income from one place, but rather does small jobs and side gigs whenever they can, estimated what they made each month then multiplied by 12: "I keep zero record of it. I never file taxes, so, I mean, I can't imagine I made more than \$100 a month, between \$50 and \$100 a month, so let's say, I might have made a thousand dollars last year .. twelve hundred dollars. That's all net, because I'm not taxed or anything. I always get paid in cash." (P3313)
- Three participants said that they were thinking about income sources and amounts that they reported on their 1099 forms or general taxes.
 - One of these participants mentioned that he did not include earnings from crypto accounts.

Would respondents have preferred to have reported this some other way? If earnings and/or expenses are variable (e.g., different each month or quarter), what is the easiest way for them to report information to allow an annual amount to be determined?

- Five participants said that they preferred to report earnings on an annual level.
- The participant who does not have steady income but does small jobs whenever they can said that they would prefer to answer for a shorter time frame as it was difficult to remember earnings for the whole year.

Was the instruction to provide their best estimate helpful? What did “best estimate” mean to respondents?

- Six participants said that they thought the instruction was helpful because it made them feel better about giving an estimate. These participants said they would have estimated anyway and would not have skipped the question if the instruction was not provided.
- One participant said that regardless of whether the instruction was there, they would pull up their tax form and answer the question precisely.

Recommendations:

As it was not clear to some participants whether this question is asking about total income or earnings from self-employment, consider clarifying this in the question stem (i.e., include the self-employment fill used in **BUS_POS_RNG**).

How much were (^name’s/your) net earnings from (^fill self-employment) before taxes in 2024?

Net earnings are total earnings minus expenses for the year. If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

BUS_POS_RNG (n=1)

Select a range that indicates how much (^name/you) earned from (^fill self-employment) before taxes in 2024.

Net earnings are total earnings minus expenses for the year.

- 1 \$0–14,999 (n=1)
- 2 \$15,000–\$29,999
- 3 \$30,000–\$44,999
- 4 \$45,000–\$59,999
- 5 \$60,000 or more

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than a specific value?

- One participant (the participant who does not have steady income) saw this question and seemed to answer this question more easily than the previous question.

Did respondents feel these ranges were too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- This participant thought the ranges were fine.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

BUS_NEG_AMT (n=1)

How much was (^name's/your) net loss before taxes in 2024?

Net loss is total earnings minus expenses for the year. If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

1 Not sure (n=1)

How did they determine their answer? Did they know this number off the top of their head or were they doing mental math based on earnings and expenses? Or did they use some other strategy?

- One participant (the participant who answered they were self-employed but said they were a contractor) saw this question and did not know how to answer it; however, the misreporting of their employment type likely contributed to this difficulty.
 - "It's like you literally told someone, that their life is a loss and I feel like that could be negative." (P4220)

Would respondents have preferred to have reported this some other way?

- No data to report

If earnings and/or expenses were variable (e.g., different each month or quarter), what was the easiest way for them to report information to allow an annual amount to be determined?

- No data to report

Was the instruction to provide their best estimate helpful? What did "best estimate" mean to respondents?

- No data to report

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

BUS_NEG_RNG (n=1)

Select a range that indicates how much (^name/you) lost from (^fill self-employment) before taxes in 2024.

Net loss is total earnings minus expenses for the year.

- 1 \$0–14,999
- 2 \$15,000–\$29,999
- 3 \$30,000–\$44,999
- 4 \$45,000–\$59,999
- 5 \$60,000 or more
- 6 Not sure (n=1)

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than a specific value?

- One participant (same as above) saw this question but did not know how to answer it: “Unless you take an accounting class, I don’t think the average person would know this amount.... This [question] assumes you track you[r] income that way.” (P4220)

Did respondents feel these ranges were too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- No data to report

Recommendations:

No changes recommended

7.2.2 Income Sources**General Findings**

Throughout the “Income Sources” section there were several overarching findings on “like” items, which are detailed below.

1. “Someone in the household got [INCOME SOURCE], but I’m not sure what type”

Following the findings from Round 1, this response option was added to questions in the “Income Sources” section, where some participants indicated uncertainty of the finances of others in their household.

- Almost half of participants in Round 2 (n=12) indicated that they did not know the answer to a question for others in their household at some point during this section of the interview.
 - Five of these participants live with unrelated individuals and did not know the answer to any of the questions for others in their household, or they had to guess. For example, when asked if it was easy or difficult to answer a question on behalf of others in their household, one participant explained:
 - “Oh, extremely difficult. I know nothing of their business. I don’t know if they have one cent to their name or if they have millions of dollars to their name. I know nothing, they tell me nothing, they’re not gonna tell me nothing.... They’re just other renters.” (P5339)
 - Seven of these participants live with family. For these participants, they could answer most questions for others in their household but came across at least one question where they did not know the answer for others. The questions

they did not know the answer to were mostly questions that required more of a specific knowledge of someone's finances (e.g., interest-earning accounts, annuities, dividends).

The "Someone in the household got [INCOME SOURCE], but I'm not sure what type" response option was rarely used when participants were uncertain about income sources of others in their household (see distributions for each question below). Choosing this response option would indicate that the respondent confidently knows that someone else in their household received income from this source, but that they just did not know the *type* of income received. However, for the participants described above, most were not confident or had no idea if others in their household received that income source at all. Therefore, this response option was not appropriate for them to indicate that they didn't know the answer for others in their household. We recommend rewording this response option on all questions as follows:

I am not sure if someone else in the household received [INCOME SOURCE], or I am not sure what type they received.

2. "Do not include anything you already reported" instruction

This instruction was added to all income source questions following the findings from Round 1, where some participants were reporting the same income source on multiple questions.

- Overall, participants found this instruction to be confusing and repetitive, especially when they were asked about an income source they had not been previously asked about in a prior question (e.g., unemployment).
- A few participants interpreted this instruction to refer to reporting on taxes, which was also confusing to them.
- In general, we recommend including this instruction only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question). We have listed this recommendation where applicable in each associated question below. However, we note that for some questions, this instruction is helpful and important to keep if respondents are likely to "double report." We have noted this where applicable in each section below.

Unemployment Compensation (Source)

UI_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of unemployment benefits that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 State or Federal unemployment compensation (n=5)
- 2 Supplemental Unemployment Benefits (SUB)
- 3 Union Unemployment or Strike Benefits

- 4 (^I/Someone in the household) got unemployment, but I’m not sure what type
- 5 None of the above (n=25)

How confident were respondents in responding for themselves? For others?

- Most participants (n=27) said that they were confident in their answer for themselves.
- About half of participants (n=17) were confident in their answer for others in their household.
- For those who were not confident in their answer for others in their household:
 - Participants who live with unrelated roommates were unaware of others’ finances and reported that they would have to ask. One participant explained: “Oh, extremely difficult. I know nothing of their business. I don't know if they have one cent to their name or if they have millions of dollars to their name. I know nothing, they tell me nothing, they’re not gonna tell me nothing.... They’re just other renters.” (P5339)
 - Three participants who lived with family members reported that another person in their household was unemployed for at least part of 2024 and had to think about whether the person received unemployment benefits but ultimately decided that the person did not qualify for unemployment.

Was the instruction to not include anything they have already reported helpful?

What did this mean to respondents?

- Ten participants said that the instructions were clear.
- Ten participants understood that they should not include income received from unemployment benefits if they had reported this income earlier in the survey. However, this was confusing to them, as they did not think people would report unemployment benefits as income. Examples:
 - “No because they don’t include anything already reported. And it’s referring to unemployment benefits. I don’t think there’s a question before this one about unemployment benefits.” (P3373)
 - “No, I don’t know where I would have reported that in this form.... Is it assuming that the amount of unemployment benefits were counted in the questions asked earlier?” (P4220)
 - “Where, where would that have been already reported? That statement doesn’t make sense to me.... This is the first time you’re even mentioning unemployment.” (P4766)
- Eight participants thought the instruction was confusing, with some participants not having any idea what this meant and some participants thinking that this referred to reporting income on taxes. One of these participants mentioned that as the interview occurred in July, they had already filed their taxes for the year, so this instruction was confusing to them.

Other findings:

- Four participants said that they did not know what Supplemental Unemployment Benefits (SUB) meant.
- One participant did not know what strike benefits meant.

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Workers Compensation (Source)

WC_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of worker’s compensation payments that (^you/anyone in this household) received as a result of a **job-related** injury or illness in 2024.

Do not include sick pay or disability retirement.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 State worker’s compensation
- 2 Employer (or employer’s insurance) worker’s compensation
- 3 Personal worker’s compensation
- 4 Other worker’s compensation payments
- 5 (^I/Someone in the household) got worker’s compensation, but I’m not sure what type (n=1)
- 6 None of the above (n=29)

What did “job-related” mean to respondents?

- No participants reported being confused by the phrase “job-related.” Most participants (n=23) interpreted “job-related” as an injury or accident that happened while at work or on the job. A few other participants (n=5) explained that “worker’s compensation” implies that the injury or illness is “job-related,” and they were not aware that there are other kinds of worker’s compensation.

Did they understand each of the response options and how they are different from one another? Was “personal workers’ compensation” (3) clear to them?

- Almost all participants had no difficulty with understanding the response options.
- One participant said, “These are very confusing” (P3311) during think-aloud but did not elaborate.
- One participant had never heard of “personal worker’s compensation” but guessed that it was referring to someone who owned their own business and purchased their own worker’s compensation.

If they selected “other” (4), ask the respondent to explain.

- No participants selected “other.”

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Social Security (Source)

SS_YN (n=30)

Did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any Social Security payments from the U.S. Government in 2024?

- 1 Yes (n=13)
- 2 No (n=17)

How confident were respondents in responding for themselves? For others?

- Although this was not specifically probed, two participants mentioned that they could not answer for others in their household, as they do not know their financial situation.

Other findings:

- One participant was unsure whether this question was asking about disability or old age. This participant initially answered “Yes” but then changed to “No” after reading the next question about SSI. They explained, “Maybe this should say ‘do not include any disability payments.’” (P4865)

Recommendations:

Consider adding an instruction to not include disability payments or otherwise provide more clarification of “SSI payments” and what should be excluded. Additionally, consider including more clarification around what should be considered/included as “Social Security payments”. This instruction should be reviewed by SMEs to ensure accuracy.

Did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any Social Security payments from the U.S. Government in 2024?

Do not include SSI payments (assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons).

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) (Source)

SSI_YN (n=30)

Did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any SSI payments (Supplemental Security Income) in 2024?

SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons, and come from state or local welfare offices, the Federal government, or both.

Do not include anything you have already reported.

- 1 Yes (n=5)
- 2 No (n=25)

Did respondents read the definition under the question? Was it helpful? Necessary?

- Five participants either said that they did not read the definition, or the interviewer observed that they did not read the definition.
- Some participants (n=8) mentioned that they already knew what SSI was or they knew that this question did not apply to them and that they either did not read the definition at all or glanced at it/skimmed it.
- Sixteen participants said that the definition was helpful/necessary.
- Two participants found the definition confusing:
 - “What is low-income aged? I know low-income... But ... I’m confused ... is this someone below retirement age?... That’s really confusing me.” (P3269)
 - “It feels like it is asking the same thing as the previous question and I said yes. It feels like it is asking me the same question but wording it differently. I still would answer yes either way.” (P4206)

Were respondents familiar with the differences between Social Security and SSI (Supplemental Security Income)?

- Most participants said that they knew the difference between Social Security and SSI (n=20).
- Two participants said that the difference is somewhat unclear to them, but they are familiar with some of the differences.
- Three participants did not know the difference between Social Security and SSI.

Other findings:

- One participant said that they were not sure whether to include receiving EBT and would probably say “Yes” to be on the safe side. They explained, “It does say SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income, aged blind or disabled, and that’s what I do get. I do get the EBT ... for low income ... so it seems like they probably would want to know about that.” (P3313)

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

As some participants found the definition confusing and one participant was unsure whether to include EBT, consider consulting SMEs to reword the definition of SSI and/or provide extra context.

Veterans Payments (Source)

VA_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of Veteran Affairs (VA) payments that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Include assistance received by children of veterans.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Service-connected disability compensation
- 2 VA survivor benefits
- 3 Veterans Pension (a specific program for lower income veterans; different from a military pension)
- 4 VA educational assistance (including assistance received by children of veterans)
- 5 Other Veterans’ payments
- 6 (^I/Someone in the household) got Veteran’s payments, but I’m not sure what type
- 7 None of the above (n=30)

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- No participants had any difficulty selecting a response, with a few saying they didn’t closely read the response options for a variety of reasons, including:
 - No one in their household was a veteran, so they knew their answer was none of the above
 - One participant knew they themselves were not a veteran but weren’t sure about anyone else in the household.
 - One participant is a veteran and is in the process of applying for VA payments but has not received any benefits yet, so they knew their answer was no.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Three participants were not sure if others in their household were veterans.

- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected “other” (5), ask the respondent to explain.

- No participants selected “Other.”

Other findings:

- One participant mentioned that they thought it was interesting that the response options mentioned children of veterans but not spouses of veterans, as they have friends who have received spousal VA benefits.

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Survivor Benefits (Source)

SUR_TYP (n=30)

Select all the types of survivor benefits that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Survivor benefits provide income as a result of being a widow or widower.

Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or VA survivor benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company or union survivor pension (include profit sharing)
- 2 Federal government survivor (Civil service) pension
- 3 U.S. Military retirement survivor pension
- 4 State or local government survivor pension
- 5 U.S. Railroad retirement survivor pension
- 6 Worker’s compensation survivor pension
- 7 Black Lung survivor pension
- 8 Regular payments from estates or trusts (n=2)
- 9 Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies
- 10 Other type of survivor benefits
- 11 (^I/Someone in the household) got survivor benefits, but I’m not sure what type
- 12 None of the above (n=28)

Did respondents read all of the options? Or just the first few?

- Nine participants did not read the response options and five additional participants scanned or skimmed the response options.

- Twelve participants read the response options, with some of them reading the response options out loud during the think-aloud.

Did respondents who did not have any survivor income find/use the “None” option?

- No participants had issues finding the “None” option, with many commenting that they went straight to the bottom of the list to find “None of the above.”

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- Three participants mentioned that they receive payments from annuities, insurance policies, and/or estates or trusts from deceased relatives, but since they were not the widow or widower, they said that this did not apply to them.
- One participant, who chose “None of the above,” mentioned that annuities and trusts sometimes pay out in a lump sum and thought that the phrasing of “regular payments” excluded payments in a lump sum.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Three participants said that they did not know the financial situation of others in their household.
- One participant, who lives in a sober living household, said that they knew one other person does get regular payments from estates or trusts, but they do not know the answer for any others in the household.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected “other” (10), ask the respondent to explain.

- No participants selected “Other.”

Recommendations:

We recommend keeping the instruction “Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or VA survivor benefits.”

SMEs should confirm that Social Security Survivor benefits should be reported under the question related to Social Security and that this would be clear to those who receive Social Security Survivor benefits.

Public Assistance (Source)

PA_TYP (n=30)

Select all the types of cash assistance that (^you/anyone in this household) received from a state or county welfare program in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Do not include Food Stamps (SNAP), SSI (Supplemental Security Income), energy assistance, WIC (Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children), free or reduced price school meals, childcare vouchers, or education assistance.

Select all that apply.

- 1 (^State Program Name)/Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)/welfare/Aid to Families
- 2 General Assistance (a state or local program for those with limited means who do not qualify for other types of cash aid) (n=1)
- 3 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance (n=1)
- 4 Diversion payments
- 5 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 6 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 7 Some other program (n=2)
- 8 (^I/Someone in the household) got cash assistance, but I'm not sure what type (n=2)
- 9 None of the above (n=26)

What came to mind when respondents read "cash assistance"? What types of income did respondents think about?

- Some participants (n=6) focused on "cash" and thought about the method of receiving the assistance, like in a direct deposit. Examples:
 - "If you're receiving any, like, cash, to live off of, from the government." (P3128)
 - "If you received a check that you can sign and receive the cash payment for ... or a deposit of some type." (P3311)
- Most participants (n=24) focused on "assistance" and thought about specific assistance programs, like SNAP, TANF, or welfare, that people receive temporarily or in an emergency. However, several participants noted that the instructions specify not to include some of these programs, which was confusing to them.

Was "state or county welfare program" noticed and considered in their response?

- Sixteen participants said that this phrase did not change their understanding of "cash assistance."
- Participants said that "state or county welfare program" clarified the definition or made it more specific.

Did the respondent read all of the options? Or just the first few?

- Most (n=24) participants either said that they read the response options, or the interviewer observed that they read the response options. One participant mentioned that they read the response options to get a better idea of what the question was asking about.
- Four participants did not read the response options.

Did respondents who did not have any assistance find/use the “None” option?

- Only one participant did not see the “None of the above” option at first because they said they were not reading close enough, but they were able to find the option once the interviewer clarified which option they would select.

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- In addition to the confusion about the instructions specifying to not include common programs such as SNAP (mentioned above), confusion with the response options included:
 - Three participants said that they did not know what diversion payments are.
 - One participant did not know if “Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance” was referring to two different things or one thing.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Five participants said that they did not know enough about the finances of others in their household to be able to answer for them or were not confident in their answer for others in their household.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected “other” (7), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant receives assistance from a state program that helps pay for her Medicare pension under Part D and said it is a special needs program or QMB.
- One participant received emergency assistance from FEMA due to a hurricane. They chose “Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance” but said that they also could have chosen “other.”
- One participant, who lives in a sober living household, said that he would have to ask his household members because he knows that there are state grants to get if you are in sober living. This participant chose “other” because he wasn’t sure which resources his housemates were using. When the interviewer pointed out the “Someone in the household got cash assistance, but I’m not sure what type” option, he said that either option would work.

Other findings:

- Many participants thought of programs like SNAP or food stamps when reading the question stem and were surprised when the instructions said not to include them. Some participants mentioned in the think-aloud that they do receive cash assistance but realized they should exclude this when they read this instruction. Some of these participants wondered if they would be asked about these programs on a future question.
- Three participants mentioned that the list of things not to include in the instructions was very long and might lead to some respondents skipping these instructions. For example: “I have to say, this is probably the densest question so far.... I read through the italicized text and through all the different answers.” (P4302). Despite this, it is clear from the above finding that participants who received SNAP excluded this from their answer.

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Pensions (Source)

PEN_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of pension income that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or Veterans Pensions.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company (n=2)
- 2 Union (n=2)
- 3 Federal government
- 4 State government (n=2)
- 5 Local government
- 6 U.S. Military
- 7 U.S. Railroad retirement
- 8 Other type of pension (n=1)
- 9 (^I/Someone in the household) got pension income, but I’m not sure what type (n=1)
- 10 None of the above (n=22)

Did respondents read all of the options? Or just the first few?

- Most (n=22) participants either said that they read the response options, or the interviewer observed that they read all of the response options.
- Six participants did not read all of the response options, with some saying that they skipped to the bottom of the list to find “None of the above.”

Was the “do not include” instruction helpful?

- Most participants (n=21) said that this instruction was helpful, with many noting it was helpful to know that they should not include withdrawals from IRAs and 401(k)s.
- Seven participants said that they did not need the instructions because they already knew what a pension was, or they already knew that their answer would be “None of the above.”
- One participant was not sure what pension income is and did not think that the instructions clarified this, explaining, “Yes and no. Yes, because it kind of gave me the area of what it meant, but not meant at the same time. But at the same time, it’s also a little confusing.” Is pension “more of like bonuses or extra pay?”

Extra accounts of what’s like in a company?” (P3114) This participant ultimately chose “None of the above” and said during probing that they did not have difficulty selecting this response.

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- No participants expressed difficulty or confusion with the response options.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Four participants said that they did not know enough about their other household members’ financial situation to be able to answer for them or that they would have to ask them.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected “Other” (8), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant was going to select “Other” to indicate an annuity until the interviewer explained that this would be asked on the next question.

Recommendations:

We recommend keeping the instruction “Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or Veterans Pensions.”

Annuities (Source)

ANN_YN (n=30)

Did (^you/anyone in this household) receive income from an annuity in 2024?

An annuity is a long-term arrangement where payments are made regularly (e.g., monthly) to you because of money you’ve already paid to an insurance company, bank, or broker.

Do not include anything you already reported.

- 1 Yes (n=4)
- 2 No (n=26)

Was the instruction information used? Was it helpful?

- Five participants said that they did use the information in the definition.
- Eight participants said that they did not use the information in the definition, with many of them noting that they already knew what an annuity is.
- Fifteen participants said that the definition was helpful, even if they already knew what an annuity was. For example: “Yeah I knew ... it was helpful to make it clear because different people have different ideas of what annuity is.” (P3291)
- One participant was still not sure what an annuity was, even after reading the definition. “This one might get a little iffy for me, because I did pay to an insurance company.... They overpaid me and now I’m having to pay them back. But I do not think it was an annuity. I think it was more of a disability

insurance.... I know my life insurance policy has a type of setup where I could like get a loan against it, and I think that's more of what this falls under. So, I would have to answer no on this." (P3309)

- Many (n=19) participants said that they are familiar with how annuities are different from other income sources.
- Nine participants said that they are not familiar with annuities or knew that they were different from other income sources but could not explain the details.
- One participant thought that it would be clearer to say "long-term contract" rather than "long-term arrangement."

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction "Do not include anything already reported" only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Retirement Accounts (Source)

RET_TYP (n=29)

Select the types of financial accounts that (^you/anyone in this household) had in 2024 that were specifically to save for retirement.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 401(k) (n=14)
- 2 403(b) (n=2)
- 3 Roth IRA (n=7)
- 4 Traditional IRA (n=5)
- 5 KEOGH plan
- 6 SEP plan (Simplified Employee Pension) (n=3)
- 7 Other type of retirement account (n=3)
- 8 (^I have/Someone in the household has) a retirement account, but I'm not sure what type (n=1)
- 9 None of the above (n=11)
- 10 Refused (n=1)

Was the end of the question, "specifically to save for retirement," clear? How did respondents know whether the account is specifically for retirement savings or not?

- Most participants understood the phrase "specifically to save for retirement."
 - Some (n=6) thought this was referring to an account that would only be accessed once someone stops working. For example: "This means like, when you stop working. And so, myself I liquidated mine when I was specifically not

working. Previously to that, I kept putting money in it and it wasn't until I stopped working that I was able to withdraw without getting penalized." (P3309)

- Some thought that this was referring to accounts that were set up specifically for retirement (n=4), while others thought this was referring to any accounts or investments that someone uses for retirement planning (n=12).

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- Six participants said that they did not know what a KEOGH or SEP plan was.
- One participant who knew that they had a 403(b) account was not sure whether or not to report it, but ultimately decided to report it, explaining, "So this one is a little bit confusing in that, you know, I have a 403(b), which I had used from the schools for many years putting money into that. So, are you counting what was in the past or now? Like what I'm putting in now or anything like that?" (P3418)
- One participant was not sure whether they had a Roth IRA, but decided to select it, explaining, "But I think because it's like.... I think the Roth is like a post-tax account. I had to make withdrawals from it, so I don't know if it has a balance or not." (P4220)

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Six participants said that they did not know enough about other household members' financial situation to be able to answer for them.
- Two participants said that they did not know or were not confident about what type of retirement account their spouse/significant other has.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected "Other" (7), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant has stocks and cryptocurrency, one participant has stocks with their company but could not remember the name of the account, and one participant has a pension from the city where they live and counted this on this question (rather than the pensions question) because it is not a private pension.

Other findings:

- One participant refused to answer, as they felt this information was too personal. This participant said they would choose "None of the above."

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction "Do not include anything already reported" only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

SMEs should be consulted to determine whether participants are interpreting "specifically to save for retirement" correctly. There are some participants who interpreted this question to ask about *any* means of saving for retirement, with some even including answers like stocks and cryptocurrency in the "Other" response. If these interpretations are incorrect, this question could be re-worded to include a definition or some examples.

Income-Earnings Accounts Outside of Retirement (Source)

INT_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of accounts that (^you/anyone in this household) had that may have paid interest in 2024.

Do not include retirement accounts or anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Interest-earning checking account (n=14)
- 2 Savings account (n=20)
- 3 Money market fund (n=7)
- 4 CD (certificate of deposit) (n=8)
- 5 Savings bond (n=2)
- 6 Other savings or investments that pay interest (n=3)
- 7 (^I have/Someone in the household has) an interest-earning account, but I'm not sure what type
- 8 None of the above (n=6)
- 9 Refused (n=1)

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- One participant thought that the response option "Other savings or investments that pay interest" was vague because "savings accounts are so specific" (P3311), but then thought it was self-explanatory after the interviewer probed.
- One participant was not sure what a "savings bond" is.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Ten participants either did not know enough about the other household members' financial situation to be able to answer for them, assumed they had a checking and savings account, or wanted to confirm with other household members if they had anything on this list.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected "Other" (6), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant considered selecting "Other" for stocks, but because they pay profit and not interest, they decided not to select it.
- One participant said that their spouse has a savings account that they use to purchase stocks, but they were not sure whether that applies to this question, so they decided not to select "Other."
- One participant was considering including dividends in this question, but they were not sure whether that would be asked on a separate question later. They explained, "I have some.... Like Fidelity, I have some in money markets and some in bonds, some in all this other stuff.... Interests and dividends is a little

confusing here.” (P3418) They noted that it would have been helpful to note in the instructions not to include dividends and they ultimately decided not to select “Other.”

- One participant selected “Other” to refer to a Prosper account: “It’s basically a peer-to-peer lending platform, where you can invest money, um, through the platform, and the platform, you, you can basically loan other people’s money but you don’t know who those people are and you’re only loaning them money through that investment platform, and you pick out what ... percentage of the loans you wanna, you want to fund. And then when the people, when they get that loan, and they make their payments every month, you get your principal and interest back in relation to the loan that you funded.” (P4958)

If they selected “None” (8), ask if they have any bank accounts. If yes, ask if any of them earn interest, even if it’s very low?

- Two participants who selected “None of the above” said that they have savings accounts that earn interest, but one of them said that they didn’t get any interest in 2024 and the other said the interest earned was only a few cents.
- One participant confirmed that they had accounts in the past, but they have closed.
- One participant confirmed that everyone in their household has a checking account but they do not earn interest.
- One participant has a bank account but was not sure if it earned interest: “Well, I may be wrong. I have a credit card account, would that be the same?” (P3114)

Other findings:

- One participant refused to answer, as they thought this was confidential information.
- Two participants thought it was difficult to indicate which accounts earn interest, with one of them saying, “Oh man, you guys are really getting into the weeds here, holy cow. [laughs] Good luck getting good answers.” (P4766)
- One participant thought that if the question said “have received interest” instead of “paid interest,” then it would have clarified the intent of the question. This participant reported CD and interest-earning checking account and said during probing that this question was easy to answer.

Recommendations:

Consider an instruction telling participants to not include dividends.

We recommend to keep the instruction “Do not include retirement accounts or anything you already reported.”

Consult SMEs to determine whether participants should include accounts that have the potential to earn interest. Participants seem to be interpreting this question as asking about accounts where they have earned a significant amount of interest (i.e., more than a few cents). If participants should be including accounts that have the potential to earn interest,

regardless of whether they have earned any interest in that account, then this question should be reworded.

Select the types of accounts that (^you/anyone in this household) had that may have paid interest in 2024.

Do not include retirement accounts or anything you already reported.

Do not include assets that paid dividends.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Interest-earning checking account
- 2 Savings account
- 3 Money market fund
- 4 CD (certificate of deposit)
- 5 Savings bond
- 6 Other savings or investments that pay interest
- 7 (^I have/Someone in the household has) an interest-earning account, but I'm not sure what type
- 8 None of the above

Dividends

DIV_TYP (n=30)

Select the types of assets that (^you/anyone in this household) had that paid dividends in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Shares of stock in corporations (n=7)
- 2 Mutual funds (n=5)
- 3 Other savings or investments that pay dividends (such as index funds or ETFs) (n=5)
- 4 (^I have/Someone in the household has) an asset that pays dividends, but I'm not sure what type
- 5 None of the above (n=20)
- 6 Not sure: 1
- 7 Refused: 1

How confident were respondents in their understanding of dividends versus interest?

- Many (n=19) participants said that they knew the difference between dividends and interest. For example: "Yeah, like interest, like a checking account. Or a

savings account, you get interest built up there, for keeping your money in the bank, you know.... And dividends is money that pays, like stocks, on a stock something, or bonds. It's the money they're gonna pay on stocks or bonds ... maybe a person could um, get a bond from company, a big company...." (P5339)

- Eleven participants said that they did not know the difference between dividends and interest. For example: "I know what interest is. I know dividends are a different category that is not the same as interest. That is what I know." (P4454)

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- One participant did not know what an ETF was.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Seven participants said that they did not know enough about the other household members' financial situation to be able to answer for them.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected "Other" (3), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant considered selecting "Other" but decided not to because of the examples given in the response option, explaining, "This one's a little iffy and I don't know how you would uh, if you had another option for me.... My significant other, none. Myself, I don't have any shares in stock or corporation or mutual funds. Do have investment that pays me a monthly amount. I don't know if you'd consider those Index Funds. Definitely not ETFs. I'm not even really sure what that is. Comes from the postal office because the postal office, where I live, my family has been there since 1600s and the postal office sits on our land, and they pay us monthly ... and my share is \$400." (P3309) Once this participant saw the next question, they realized that what they were describing was property income.
- One participant chose "Other" for their cryptocurrency and index funds.
- One participant chose "Other" because their and their partner's 401(k)s have index funds to ETFs.

Other findings:

- After reading this question, one participant wondered if they answered the previous question incorrectly because they were not sure if they paid dividends or interest for their money market fund.

Recommendations:

We recommend keeping the instruction "Do not include anything you already reported." on this item.

Property Income (Source)

PROP_TYP (n = 27)

Select the types of property income that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Income from a rental property (^you/they) do not reside in (n=1)
- 2 Income from roomers or boarders at a property (^you/they) reside in (exclude amounts paid by relatives) (n=2)
- 3 Income from estates or trusts
- 4 Royalties
- 5 None of the above (n=23)
- 6 No answer: n=1

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- One participant paid money to their roommates, as they live in their roommates' home. This participant was not sure if they should select "Income from roomers or boarders at a property they reside in," but ultimately decided to select "None of the above." It is unclear why this participant decided not to include this, but it is possible that testing limitations (i.e., "you or anyone in this household") contributed to this error. It is unclear how this participant would have responded if the question was asked separately for each household member.
- Two participants were confused by the response option "Income from estates or trusts," as this isn't always property income. One of these participants explained, "I think it's 'None of the above,' but I'm a little confused on the third answer, estates or trusts ... because my partner's mother passed away and her money was put into a trust and distributed to family members not including myself. I'm not sure if that kind of trust qualifies under this response.... It asks about property, but it was more like her holdings.... [Mother in-law's trust] wasn't based on her property,. It was based on her financial holdings." (P4302)

Did respondents read the instructions in italics? Were they helpful?

- About half of (n=14) participants either said that they read the instruction, or the interviewer observed that they read the instruction
- Three participants said that the instruction was helpful. One of these participants elaborated that it could be useful to those who receive money from renters as their income.
- Five participants said that the instruction was not helpful, with most being unsure why this instruction was necessary.

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Five participants did not know enough about the other household members' financial situation to answer for them
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

Other findings:

- One participant received income from a family rental property and initially included it on the previous question about dividends (see the previous section). However, when they got to this question, they realized that this income should be

reported here. They explained, “If I had gotten this question first, the other one would have totally registered that no [this income should not be reported with dividends].” (P3309). Further, if this question came before the dividends question, they would have known not to report it as dividends due to the instruction. However, this situation is likely very rare.

- One participant refused to answer.

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction “Do not include anything already reported” only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Clarify if “Income from estates and trusts” only refers to property-related “estates and trusts.”

Education Assistance (Source)

HIED_YN (n=27)

In 2024, did (^you/anyone in this household) attend school beyond the high school level including a college, university, vocational, business, or trade school?

- 1 Yes (n=7)
- 2 No (n=20)

What type of schooling were respondents thinking about?

- Seven participants said “Yes” to this question. It is unclear what schooling four participants were thinking about.
- For the other three participants: one participant attended a pre-apprentice program, which they considered vocational, and two participants had someone in their household who attended trade school.

Was the language “beyond the high school level” clear?

- This phrase was clear to almost all participants.
- One participant was unsure whether attending a course online for expanded learning would count, explaining, “The way I read this is did I do something to enhance my skills to get a job. There’s nothing in here about did I do anything just to be a life-long learner.” (P3418) This participant thought that it might be helpful to add something like “to further your career” or “work towards a promotion.”
- One participant was unsure whether to report a roommate who participated in a certificate course. This participant ultimately decided not to include this.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended

EDASST_TYP (n=8)

Select the types of educational assistance that (^you/anyone in this household) received for tuition, fees, books, or living expenses in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported, like VA educational benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Pell Grant (n=2)
- 2 Assistance from a welfare or social service office
- 3 Other government assistance (n=2)
- 4 Scholarships, grants, etc.
- 5 Other assistance (employers, family, friends, etc.)
- 6 (^I/Someone in the household) got educational assistance, but I'm not sure what type (n=1)
- 7 None of the above (n=4)

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- One participant who reported "None of the above" was unsure how to categorize assistance received by another member of their household: "I think the program that she was in was paid for by the state, but to me that's different than if she got ... if she was granted some kind of money to pay for the program. I think it was just something funded through the state." (P4302) It is unclear why this participant did not select "Someone in the household got educational assistance, but I'm not sure what type."
- Similarly, another participant said that they also received assistance from a state program and was unsure how to categorize this; they reported "Someone in the household got educational assistance, but I'm not sure what type."
- One participant was unsure what "Other government assistance" was referring to.
- One participant was unsure how to report student loans. This participant answered "Pell Grant" and "Other government assistance."

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- One participant was not confident in their answer for an unrelated housemate and said they would have to ask them to confirm.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

Did anybody talk about loans taken out for education?

- Yes—see findings above.

If respondent selected "Other" (3 or 5), ask the respondent to explain.

- See findings above.

Recommendations:

We recommend keeping the instruction “Do not include anything you already reported, like VA educational benefits.”

Child Support (Source)

CSUP_YN (n=27)

In 2024, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any child support payments? (n=27)

- 1 Yes (n=1)
- 2 No (n=26)

Findings:

- Participants did not report any difficulties with understanding or answering this question.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended

Regular Financial Assistance (Source)

RFA_YN (n=27)

In 2024, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive (^any other/any) regular financial assistance from friends or relatives not living in this household?

Do not include amounts that must be paid back.

Do not include anything you already reported.

- 1 Yes (n=3)
- 2 No (n=23)
- 3 Refused (n=1)

Did respondents read the instruction?

- Almost all of the participants read the instruction. Only one participant said that they did not read the instruction, as they saw “financial assistance from friends or relatives” and immediately knew the answer was “No.”
- Although most participants read the instruction, some thought that it was confusing:
 - “I think if it was a gift, it should specifically say it was a gift and not to be repaid.” (P3418)
 - “And when they say regular financial, I don’t know what that means.... Like the way you get a certain amount every month on a regular basis?” (P4152)

- "I guess it's like difficult to answer. Like, if someone gave you money, I guess most people want to pay them back.... That's a really weird question for me and difficult for me to answer. If anyone has ever given me money, which they have, my goal is to pay them back. I don't know a lot of people who would take money from someone and don't pay them back." (P4220)

Other findings:

- One participant refused to answer.
- One participant, who lives in a sober living household, said that he would not be able to answer for others in the household. Although he said that he could easily ask about income sources for all other questions, the participant noted that this question would not be as easy to ask: "I would assume 'Yes.' Um, yeah, some of the people here are not doing as well as I am, so, you know, friends or relatives, giving them money, is, I'm going to say, almost definitely.... I would also say ... in my living situation, it would be a very awkward question to ask someone." (P5273). The interviewer probed to ask if they would like another response option listed here, and they said something like the previous questions, which included "Someone received financial assistance, but I'm not sure what kind"; in other words, this participant wanted a way to indicate that they were not sure about the answer for others in their household.

Recommendations:

Consider including the instruction "Do not include anything already reported" only when relevant (i.e., when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question).

Consider asking whether they "regularly received financial assistance," as opposed to saying "regular financial assistance" to emphasize that this item is interested in repeated assistance.

Other Money Income (Source)

OTH_TYP (n=27)

Select the types of other income that (^you/anyone in this household) received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Income from Alaska Permanent Fund
- 2 Income from foster child care
- 3 Income from alimony (n=1)
- 4 Income from jury duty (n=4)
- 5 Income from armed forces reserves
- 6 Income from severance pay (n=3)
- 7 Income from hobbies (n=1)

- 8 Income from other sources (n=4)
- 9 None (n=16)

Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

- One participant was not sure what the “Alaska Permanent Fund” is.

What did “hobbies” mean to respondents?

- Participants thought that “hobbies” was referring to homemade or crafted items that someone sells on websites/apps like eBay or Etsy. Some participants said that more generally, this includes something that a person does because they are interested in it but don’t necessarily receive a full-time income from it.
- Examples of hobbies that participants provided included carpentry and woodworking, gardening or florists, crafts and artwork (e.g., T-shirts, frames, sewing, plastic model kits, painting), playing music, baked goods, farmer’s markets, and selling collectibles (e.g., stamps, cards like Magic: The Gathering).

How confident were respondents in answering for others in the household?

- Four participants said that they would have to ask others in their household the answer to this question.
- All other participants said that this question was easy to answer for others in their household, or the probe was skipped for time.

If they selected “other” (8), ask the respondent to explain.

- One participant considered selecting “other” for being paid to participate in focus groups but because they did not receive over \$600, which is the threshold to report on taxes, they would also not report it here. They ultimately chose “None.”
- One participant said they received minimal income from other sources but did not want to disclose from where; they ultimately chose “None.”
- Two participants chose “other” to report side gigs like cutting grass, cleaning houses, and washing cars.
- One participant chose “other” to report being a poll worker for the presidential election in November.

Other findings:

- One participant thought that it was difficult to follow the instruction to not include anything already reported: “It’s assuming you kept track of the other 25 types of income you’ve already talked about. So ... I’m not really sure at this point what means income from other sources?” (P4220)
- One participant said that they almost reported income from their job working for DoorDash, until they read the instruction to not include anything already reported.
- One participant noted that although they were receiving money for participating in this interview, they would not report that as income; they would also not report being a part of a mock jury, where they get paid \$100–\$200.

Recommendations:

We recommend keeping the instruction “Do not include anything you already reported.”

7.2.3 Income Amounts

SS_AMT. (n=11)

How much did you receive in Social Security payments in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

- Eleven participants received the question, but four participants refused to answer. If completing this on their own, they would leave this blank, noting that the IRS has this information and they did not feel that the Census needed this information.

Were respondents comfortable guessing the amount if they didn't know the exact value? If so, would they have provided a guess without the instructions that doing so was okay?

- Participants appeared comfortable providing an estimate. They felt the instruction was helpful in giving them permission to provide an estimate.
- One participant, however, would prefer for us to provide ranges rather than determining an actual amount.
- Another participant asked, "So when it says you received in Social Security payments, is it me, or my husband?" The participant did not know how much her husband receives, so she would probably just leave this blank if completing this on her own. (P3311)
- However, other participants would be able to answer this for others in their household.
- One participant did note that the question does not ask about others in the household, so he interpreted the question to be only asking about Social Security he receives.

Did anyone who knew the exact amount provide a rounded or approximate answer?

- Some participants (n=3) provided an exact amount, while the others provided an estimate.

Recommendations:

Consider clarifying whether respondents should only consider Social Security that they receive or whether to include what others in their household receive.

One participant recommended including an on-screen calculator for this question so they can make quick calculations, perhaps based on the amounts of each payment. May also consider providing the option to report monthly instead of annually.

SS_RNG. (n=3)

Select a range that indicates how much (^you/name) earned from Social Security before taxes in 2024.

- 1 \$0–\$999 (0)
- 2 \$1,000–\$4,999 (0)
- 3 \$5,000–\$9,999 (0)
- 4 \$10,000–\$19,999 (0)
- 5 \$20,000 or more (0)
- 6 Don't know (1)
- 7 Refused (2)

Findings:

- Of the three participants who received this question, one participant still refused to provide a response, while another participant who refused to provide a response to the previous question said she would make a selection here (but did not want to tell the interviewer what the selection would be). Another participant said he still would not know the response and just answered "Don't know," commenting that there was no way to know what the amount was before taxes.

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than specific information (periodicity, payment amount, and number of payments) about what they received?

- One participant noted that she did prefer ranges rather than providing specific financial information. However, she would still refuse to respond.

Did respondents feel these ranges are too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- A participant felt the categories were not evenly distributed.
 - The participant commented, "It's a pretty wide range." (P3373)
 - This participant said that the categories start going up by (increments of) 5 and then jump to 10 and 20. He felt we could include options for \$10,000–\$14,999, \$15,000–\$19,999 and then \$20,000 or more.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

PEN_AMT. (n=6)

How much did you receive from your pension in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

Findings:

Were respondents comfortable guessing the amount if they didn't know the exact value? If so, would they have provided a guess without the instructions that doing so was okay?

- Two participants would not provide an exact amount but said they would provide a range. Of the two, one participant was concerned about giving the Census specific financial information and the other felt that it would be too difficult to provide an accurate amount and that a range would be easier.

Did anyone who knew the exact amount provide a rounded or approximate answer?

- All six participants provided an estimated amount as they noticed the instruction to provide their "best estimate." It was not apparent whether they were aware of the exact amount.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

PEN_RNG. (n=1)

Select a range that indicates how much you earned from your pension before taxes in 2024.

- 1 \$0-\$999
- 2 \$1,000-\$4,999
- 3 \$5,000-9,999
- 4 \$10,000-\$19,999 (1)
- 5 \$20,000 or more

Findings:

- Only one participant received this question. No issues were found.

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than specific information (periodicity, payment amount, and number of payments) about what they received?

- The participant felt comfortable with the range and expected this based on the previous question.

Did respondents feel these ranges are too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- The participant said she doesn't know how large pensions can be but thought we should consider this in terms of the range sizes we offer.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

RET_DIST_AMT. (n=8)

How much did you receive from withdrawals and distributions from your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

Findings:

Were respondents comfortable guessing the amount if they didn't know the exact value?

- Participants generally felt this was difficult to answer without reviewing records. This was easier if the monthly distribution was equal as the participants could then multiply this by 12 to get a response that was fairly accurate.
- Two participants calculated the exact amount and others provided an estimate.
 - One participant refused, explaining, "Again, this one I ... I wouldn't even estimate. And I'm not even sure if I could do the range on this one. It just seems.... It just seems all like, like it was complaining about taxes." [P3418]
 - The participant explained that he has a financial planner who handles this for him.
- One participant said that he would be unable to provide the amount for others in the household.

If they did not provide an answer, was it because they have privacy concerns or because they couldn't guess an amount?

- Only one participant did not provide a response due to not knowing or being able to estimate the response.

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

RET_DIST_RNG. (n=2)

Select a range that indicates how much you earned from withdrawals and distributions for your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024.

- 1 \$0-\$999
- 2 \$1,000-\$4,999
- 3 \$5,000-9,999
- 4 \$10,000-\$19,999
- 5 \$20,000 or more (2)

Findings:

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than specific information (periodicity, payment amount, and number of payments) about what they received?

- Both participants explained that they would rather respond to a range than to determine a specific amount.

Did respondents feel these ranges are too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- Both participants felt the ranges were much too low.

Recommendations:

Consider reviewing the ranges to determine whether the upper limit should be increased so as to collect more detailed information.

RET_INT_AMT. (n=10)

How much did you receive from interest or dividends on your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____00

Were respondents comfortable guessing the amount if they didn't know the exact value? If so, would they have provided a guess without the instructions that doing so was okay?

- Several participants explained that they did not know the answer to this question or had difficulty responding, even with the instruction to provide an estimate. As one participant explained:
 - "That one I could not even begin to guess. Mainly because I have a financial planner and I don't. I trust him, so I don't really know what the interest was." (P3180)

Did anyone who knew the exact amount provide a rounded or approximate answer?

- Two of the 10 participants provided an exact number. All others provided an estimate or could not respond.

Recommendations:

Due to the difficulty in answering this question, some participants would prefer a range.

RET_INT_RNG. (n=5)

Select a range that indicates how much you received from interest and dividends from your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024.

- 1 \$0–\$99 (1)
- 2 \$100–\$499
- 3 \$500–\$999
- 4 \$1,000–\$2,999 (1)
- 5 \$3,000 or more (2)
- 6 Don't Know (1)

Findings:

Were respondents more comfortable providing a range than specific information (periodicity, payment amount, and number of payments) about what they received?

- Participants provided responses and they were confident that this was an accurate range.

Were ranges aligned with what they actually received?

- The participants were able to make a selection. The two who selected “\$3,000 or more” felt they could have selected a higher range if it were available.

Did respondents feel these ranges were too small to accurately or comfortably place themselves in a bin?

- One participant felt we could have had a category for \$5,000 or more as that would be his selection. Another participant also felt the top end of the ranges were too low.

Recommendations:

Consider reviewing the ranges to determine whether the upper limit should be increased.

7.3 Poverty Questions

7.3.1 Path 1-Low Income

INC_EST (n=19)

Which category represents your household income before taxes in 2024?

Household income includes money from jobs, net income from business, farm or rent, pensions, dividends, interest, social security payments, and any other money income received.

If you don't know the amount, please estimate.

- 1 \$0–\$34,999 (3)
- 2 \$35,000–\$49,999 (2)
- 3 \$50,000–\$69,999 (2)
- 4 \$70,000–\$89,999 (4)
- 5 \$90,000–\$119,999 (3)
- 6 \$120,000–\$150,000 (2)
- 7 \$150,000 or more (3)

Findings:

- Most participants (n=16) did not have issues with selecting a response.
- One participant (P3418) specifically noted that they prefer income range response options compared with recording exact amounts because it is easier and reduces respondent burden.
- Of the four participants who answered this question and endorsed living in a household with unrelated individuals (P3114, P3244, P5273, P4206), three expressed uncertainty when reporting on household income before selecting their final response.
 - Specifically, one participant (P3114) selected a response before they realized the item asked about household income and not personal income. This participant then updated their response to reflect their household income to their best estimate.
 - Two other participants (P3244, P5273) were uncertain about their household income due to not knowing income amounts from other household members. One participant (P5273) also selected a response, then after more thought about their household income, updated their response to reflect their household income to their best estimate.
 - These participants also reported living with at least two additional household members age 15 years or older, whereas the participant (P4206) living with an unrelated individual who did not express uncertainty when reporting on household income stated they live with one additional household member age 15 years or older.

Recommendations:

Participants living in a household with unrelated individuals had some difficulties with selecting a response due to uncertainty about the income amount of the other household members. Consider revising the question stem so that “household income” is emphasized. This format will emphasize the focus of this question and should reduce uncertainty among respondents. SMEs should also consider “Don’t Know” as a valid response for this item.

Consider as well whether household income is a useful construct for all household compositions. In households with unrelated individuals who are not in partnership, individual income may be a more informative signal of socioeconomic status.

7.3.2 Food Assistance

SNAP_YN (n=11)

The next questions are about food assistance programs.

At any time during 2024, EVEN FOR ONE MONTH, did anyone in this household receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program), the Food Stamp program, [state program fill/blank] or use a SNAP, food stamp, or [state card fill] benefit card?

Do not include WIC or TANF.

- 1 Yes (4)
- 2 No (7)

Findings:

Did respondents notice the “even for one month” instruction?

- All participants confirmed that they noticed the instruction, “even for one month.” Only one participant (P4958) provided an additional comment. This participant questioned why food stamps are called the more complicated “Supplemental Nutrition” program name.

Did they understand that all these programs refer to the same thing?

- Of the 10 participants who received this probe, more than half (n=6) did not understand that SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program referred to the same thing.
- Four participants reported that SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program are the same thing. Of these participants, one participant (P3128) endorsed receiving benefits from a food assistance program for at least 1 month in 2024.
- Four other participants reported that SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program are different programs. Of these participants, three (P5215, P4206, P4896) endorsed receiving benefits from a food assistance program for at least 1 month in 2024.
 - One participant (P5215) noted that these are different programs with different paperwork.
 - Another participant (P4896) shared that “state assistance program” is a vague statement considering there are a lot of state assistance programs, including SNAP, which is a specific state assistance program.
- Two participants, who both did not endorse receiving benefits from a food assistance program for at least 1 month in 2024, expressed uncertainty. One participant (P3373) explicitly stated they did not know. The other participant (P4958) stated “to me, it’s the same thing, but I don’t know if it is exactly the same thing or not.... I don’t know if the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program is different from the Food Stamp benefit card.”

Did they find the presence of the state card fill helpful or confusing?

- Of the three participants who received this probe, no one mentioned the presence of the state card fill to be confusing and two participants (P3128, P3373) thought the presence of the state card fill was helpful. Of these, one participant (P3128) reported the programs in the question stem are the same thing, whereas the other participant (P3373) reported not knowing if the programs are the same or different.
- The other participant (P3269) who stated the presence of the state card fill was not helpful also reported that they believe the question stem referred to different programs.

If they didn't know what WIC or TANF were, did they try to access the help text?

- Four participants (P3128, P3373, P4958, P5215) expressed uncertainty about TANF specifically. Three of these participants acknowledged the help link and understood this survey feature would display additional information about WIC and TANF. For example, one participant explained, "If you click it, it will tell you what WIC is and what the other one [TANF] is." (P3128)

Recommendations:

Although participants who received SNAP_YN did not express any difficulties with selecting a response, many participants—including those who endorsed receiving benefits from a food assistance program—did not understand that SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program or a SNAP, food stamp, or state benefit card all refer to the same thing. It is unclear if providing a list of everything a participant may identify as the food assistance program received is causing participants to doubt their understanding of these programs. This item is also positioned toward the latter half of the interview, directly following detailed employment and income items that required great cognitive effort from participants. It is unclear if participant fatigue, or something else, impacted participant understanding that all food assistance programs included in the question stem are referring to the same thing. SMEs should consider revising the question stem to reduce the level of cognitive effort required from participants to provide a response.

Consider the following revision:

The next questions are about food assistance programs. <NEW HELP LINK>

At any time during 2024, EVEN FOR ONE MONTH, did anyone in this household receive benefits from a food assistance program such as SNAP?

Do not include WIC or TANF. <EXISTING HELP LINK>

If the question stem is simplified, information about the specific food assistance programs should be added to a help link message that participants may access if needed. Specifically, the help message would be revised to include the information about SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program as well as the SNAP, food stamp, and state benefit card.

The participants who expressed uncertainty about TANF both acknowledged and understood the purpose of the help link survey feature. This observation suggests the help link is an effective survey feature for participants if needed.

7.3.3 WIC

WIC_YN (n=9)

At any time during 2024, [were you/was anyone in this household] on WIC, the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No (9)

Were respondents thrown off by WIC's full name?

- Most participants had no difficulties with this question and did not express confusion about the added text “the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children” in the question stem (n=8).
 - Although this participant (P3269) was not confused, one participant shared, “When I read it, I think I just read it without thinking much and I read it as two separate things, but I ... see that ... it’s listing out the full name.”
- One participant (P4896) expressed they were initially confused when reading this question because they were unsure if the full name of WIC was referring to SNAP. However, after rereading the question a second time, the participant confirmed their comprehension of this question.

Recommendations:

The question was easily understood by participants. Though a couple of participants initially thought the question may be referring to more than one program, no participant expressed any difficulties in providing a final response. However, findings are limited to participants who did not endorse receiving WIC. Additional testing may be warranted to assess comprehension of this question among WIC recipients specifically.

WIC_MNTH (n=0)

For how many months was WIC received in 2024?

_____ months

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Did respondents have issues with the second WIC question just saying “WIC” and not the full name?

- There are no data to support analysis.

Did they want to report different numbers of months for different people in the household?

- There are no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

No change recommended

7.3.4 Energy Assistance

ENG_ASST_YN (n=10)

The government has several energy assistance programs that help pay heating or cooling costs. This assistance can be received directly by the household, or it can be paid directly to the electric company, gas company, or fuel dealer. It may also show up as a reduction on your gas or electric bill, or as a separate one-time check.

In 2024, did your household receive energy assistance of this type from the federal, state, or local government?

- 1 Yes (2)
- 2 No (8)

Findings:

This question has a big block of text before the actual question. How did the respondent react to having to read that much?

- Most confirmed reading the informational text, or explicitly read the text aloud, before reading the question. One participant (P3373), who did not endorse receiving energy assistance, disclosed only skimming the paragraph of information about energy assistance programs. There were no observed negative reactions from participants about reading the informational text before the question stem.
- A majority of participants (n=9), including the two participants who endorsed receiving energy assistance in 2024 (P5215, P4896), stated the text about energy assistance programs was helpful.
 - For one participant, reading the block of text prompted them to update their response in ENG_ASST_YN from “No” to “Yes.” As this participant was thinking aloud, they stated “Oh, stop. Yeah, cause like, it comes included with my apartment, so I guess that’s what it’s saying.” (P5215) It is unclear how, and what part of, the informational text prompted this participant to change their response. This participant further disclosed they are subsidized so they don’t worry about the electricity at all, and that electric is included in the rent.

The interviewer did not probe further due to observations of the participant appearing impatient with the length of the interview. However, there is a possibility that reporting heating/electric that is included with one's subsidized apartment is not the intent of the question.

- Only one participant (P4865) explicitly noted that the text was not helpful nor needed for them to provide a response.

Would they have preferred to get this help information in a different way?

- A majority of participants (n=9) shared the way the help information is displayed is "fine" (P3269, P3373, P4865) and did not recommend any changes.
- One participant, however, shared they would rather see the question first and the help information directly below in parentheses. (P5215)

Did respondents think of energy, heating, and cooling assistance as one thing or separate things?

- More than half of participants (n= 6) understood energy, heating, and cooling assistance as one thing. Of these participants, one participant (P4896) endorsed receiving energy assistance in 2024.
- Four participants reported energy, heating, and cooling assistance as separate things (P3128, P3244, 4958, P5215). Of these participants, one (P5215) endorsed receiving energy assistance in 2024.
 - "I thought they were separate." (P5215)
 - "It depends on the house and how they have their, uh, heating and cooling systems set up." (P3244)
 - Another participant made a comment about different energy sources and that some people may use gas for heating and electric for lights. (P4958)

Recommendations:

Participants generally acknowledged the informational text before the question and did not express any difficulties with providing a response. However, some participants did not know that the various types of energy assistance government programs included in the informational text should be conceptualized as one thing and not separate government programs delineated by energy source. SMEs should consider revising the informational text to provide further clarity for participants to provide the most appropriate response for their household. Though only a couple of participants endorsed receiving energy assistance from a government program, it is unclear if one of these participants assumed their household received energy assistance from a government program because their energy costs are included in their rent payments. This could indicate that they were reporting that they do not pay separately for utilities but are not thinking about who does pay for these services. Additional testing may be warranted to assess comprehension of the informational text among energy assistance government program recipients specifically.

SMEs may also consider moving the informational text to a help link, similar to other items in the questionnaire (e.g., SNAP_YN), to reduce respondent burden. It is worth noting again that ENG_ASST_YN is positioned toward the end of the interview, where participant fatigue

may be high. Evidence from the cognitive interviewing efforts also suggest participants are comfortable with the help link survey feature and know how to access any additional information if needed.

7.3.5 Path 2 – Not Low Income

NCREC (n=12)

The next question is about assistance programs.

At any time during 2024, even for one month, did anyone in this household receive any of the following?

- SNAP/Food stamps (Yes=2, No=10)
- WIC (Yes=1, No=11)
- Energy/heating/cooling assistance (Yes=0, No=12)

Findings:

Did respondents have any issues understanding whether they received the programs?

- Participants seemed confident in their answers and did not struggle to understand the question.
- One participant provided an additional comment about “Energy/heating/cooling assistance” while thinking through a response. Specifically, this participant stated that the “only thing I had to think about was the energy/heating/cooling because we got rebates for installing heat pumps, but they were from our town. And as I read this [question], assistance to me would be like to pay your energy bill, not to install, like, clean energy equipment.” (P5273)

Did they have any problems with the question or format?

- None of the participants expressed having any problems with the question format.
- A few participants (n=3) explicitly stated that the format of these questions were “pretty straightforward” (P3100, P4302, P5353)
- Two participants provided a positive comment about the format.
 - Specifically, one participant (P3173) shared that they thought the grid format made it easier to document their responses.
 - The other participant (P3180) noted that they like the grid format better than if these questions were separated into three different pages.

If they didn’t know what a program was, did they try to access the help text?

- None of the participants attempted to interact with the help text “button.”

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants and no difficulties were observed.

7.3.6 WIC

WIC_MNTH2 (n=1)

For how many months was WIC received in 2024?

_____ months

Did respondents have issues with this just saying “WIC” and not the full name?

- The one participant (P3907) who received this probe did not have issues with the question wording.

Did they want to report different numbers of months for different people in the household?

- The one participant who received this probe stated no, they did not want to report different numbers of months for different people in the household.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

7.3.7 Housing

TENURE (n=20)

Are your living quarters...

- 1 Owned or being bought by you or someone in your household? (10)
- 2 Rented for cash? (9)
- 3 Occupied without payment of cash rent? (1)

Findings:

- Most participants understood the question and did not have an issue selecting a response.
- One participant (P5215) endorsed that their living quarters is “occupied without payment of cash rent.” However, this participant seemed to be confused by what this response option meant.
 - For example, after selecting the response option, the participant shared that “No, I live here by myself. Ain’t nobody.... No. I’m guessing the question’s asking me if somebody, if I’m renting out my apartment.” (P5215). The interviewer attempted to further understand the participant’s interpretation of

what the last response option means to them, but he expressed frustration about repeating himself.

Recommendations:

Although most participants expressed no difficulties with understanding this question and selecting a response, we recommend examining the current wording of all three response options in TENURE. The items appear to conflate the concept of ownership with the concept of payment.

For response option 1, "...being bought by" is an awkward sentence construction and it is unclear what scenario would qualify for this. Does someone who is paying a mortgage qualify? This sentence construction may be interpreted as applying to those who are in the process of purchasing a home, which is likely too narrow an interpretation.

For response option 2, "rented for cash" may be ambiguous for individuals who rent their current residence and have signed a lease agreement that requires renters to use a different payment method (e.g., direct deposit, use of a payment app, check payment).

For response option 3, the one participant who selected this response was not confident in their understanding of whether their residence is "occupied without payment of cash rent." While talking through their response, this participant shared they selected option 3 because they live alone and there is not an additional person living there who pays for rent. However, it is unclear if response option 3 is the most accurate description for this participant's household, or if they may have misinterpreted the response options provided. Further, if a home is owned and no mortgage is owed, would this response option apply? The concepts of "cash" and "rent" here may confuse the intent.

NUMROOMS (n=22)

Earlier, you reported that [you own or are buying your home/rent/live in quarters without paying cash rent]. The next questions are about that property.

How many separate bedrooms does your property contain?

Count as bedrooms those rooms you would list if this property were for sale or rent. If this is an efficiency/studio apartment, enter 0.

_____ bedrooms

Response range: 0 to 5

Response distribution:

- 1 0 rooms (1)
- 2 1 room (3)
- 3 2 rooms (4)

- 4 3 rooms (7)
- 5 4 rooms (6)
- 6 5 rooms (1)

Did people understand that “property” means the place where they live?

- Most participants (n=21) understood that “property” in this question refers to the place where they live.
 - One participant (P5353) provided additional thoughts about their understanding of the question by sharing, “[The word/question] made sense ... the house we live in used to be a two-story house but they just changed it into like a upstairs and downstairs unit, so I was thinking whether to add the two bedrooms upstairs, even though it’s a separate unit now.... [The two upstairs bedrooms were not included in their response] because it’s a separate unit.”
- Two participants who reside in an apartment noted that “property” may also be understood as the whole apartment complex.
 - One participant (P3291) stated that they understood the question but noted “at first I thought it was talking about not just my apartment, and it was talking about other people’s apartment too.”
 - The other participant (P4865) expressed, “The word property is extremely confusing.” This participant suggested the question should include the word “apartment” instead of the word “property” because property to them refers to the whole apartment complex.

Did they understand the instructions?

- When participants were specifically asked about their understanding of the word “property” in the question stem, one participant (P4865) again shared their confusion with the word “property” in this question. All other participants expressed that the instructions were clear.

Recommendations:

Participants generally understood this question and expressed no difficulties with providing a response. To reduce confusion among participants, particularly those who may live in a multiunit housing property similar to an apartment complex or townhouse community, revisions to the help text in italics should be considered. Specifically, the help text should clarify for participants living in a housing complex to only count bedrooms within their individual residential unit, and not the entire housing complex. Consider replacing “property” with “residence.”

MORT_YN (n=10)

Which of these loans does anyone in this household have on this property?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Mortgage or similar (6)

- 2 Second mortgage
- 3 Home equity loan
- 4 None—own home free and clear of any mortgages (4)

Findings:

Did respondents have any difficulty choosing between the response categories?

- All participants understood the question and expressed no difficulties with selecting a response.

Did they understand the difference between the response categories?

- A majority of participants (n=7) stated that they understood the difference between the response categories.
- A couple of participants (P4152, P4302) provided a nonconfident response and shared that they think they know the difference (n=2).
 - One participant (P4152) also shared there are also additional residential loans that may be missing from the response options: reverse mortgages and alternative mortgage instruments (ATIs).
- A couple of participants (n=2) expressed that they did not have a strong understanding of the differences between the response categories.
 - For example, one participant (P3114) responded “Kind of” when asked about this.
 - One participant (P3128) explicitly mentioned that they don’t really know the difference between a mortgage and a home equity loan, when spontaneously probed.

Recommendations:

There were no observed difficulties among participants while selecting a response option in MORT_YN. However, a few participants did express some uncertainty in their understanding of different types of mortgages and home loans. One participant also shared that the current list of response options may not be exhaustive (i.e., missing reverse mortgages and alternative mortgage instruments [ATIs]). SMEs could consider adding a help link at the end of each mortgage and home loan type response option for more information that would be accessible to participants if needed.

PUBHOUSE_YN (n=9)

Is this residence public housing?

Public housing is owned by a local housing authority or other public agency.

- 1 Yes (1)
- 2 No (8)

Findings:

- In general, participants understood the question and did not have any issues with selecting a response.
- One participant shared that their residence is not public housing, but they are not sure who owns it. This participant shared that it is owned by a property management company and not a public agency. (P4958)
- The participant who endorsed their residence as public housing answered quickly because they believed this question was self-explanatory. (P5215)

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

RENT_ASST_YN (n=8)

Are you paying lower rent because the Federal, State, or local government is paying part of the cost?

- 1 Yes (1)
- 2 No (7)

Findings:

- In general, participants understood the question and did not have any issues with selecting a response.
- One participant (P5273), who reported “No” and lives with three additional unrelated individuals age 15 years or older, stated that other people in their household may respond “Yes” to this item because there is a 1-year state grant that pays all rent for 3 months and a portion of rent for remainder of year. It is possible that this comprised a misreport.

Recommendations:

Participants respond to both household- and individual-level questions throughout the questionnaire. As such, while providing a response, one participant offered additional information about the other household members and how they may respond to this item. We recommend considering a transition sentence or revising the question stem so that “you” is displayed in bold text. This format will emphasize the focus of this question and may reduce respondent burden.

7.3.8 Child Care

CHCARE_PAID (n=6)

The next questions are about child care. Please answer these questions for your youngest child.

In 2024, which type(s) of paid care were routinely used for your youngest child while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

This does not include care arranged on short notice due to an emergency, sick child, etc.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Child care center/preschool/nursery school (2)
- 2 Home-based daycare (1)
- 3 Paid care by a nanny, babysitter, family, friends, or neighbors (1)
- 4 Before and/or after-school care (1)
- 5 Summer/day/school break camps (1)
- 6 Other
- 7 None - did not pay for child care (1)

Findings:

How did respondents interpret the word “work?”

- All participants expressed an understanding of the word “work” and did not struggle with selecting a response.
- Some participants (n=2) explicitly described work in terms of time.
 - One participant explained their interpretation of work as a “9-to-5 type of thing.” (P3114)
 - Another participant described work as “like during business hours, basically when you’re on the clock working wherever your place of work is.” (P3173)
- Other participants (n=3) explicitly described work as “making income” (P3907) or a “job” you go to for money. (P3291, P5353)

Would they respond differently if we asked about “work for pay/profit?”

- No participant stated their response would be different if the question were to ask about “work for pay/profit.”

Would they respond differently if we asked about “employment?”

- Participants understood the term “employment” and “work” to mean the same thing. One participant specifically noted that they used these two terms “interchangeably.” (P3907)

Were there other types of child care respondents wanted to report here?

- Most participants expressed no issues with selecting a response (n=5).
- One participant (P3173), who only endorsed “summer/day/school break camps,” also shared that there are some paid school activities/programs available that care for the child until pickup time. It’s unclear, however, if this participant believed the activity described was included in one of the response options provided.

Did they have any difficulty picking an appropriate category?

- Many participants expressed no difficulty in selecting a response.

- However, two participants made comments about specific response options that gave them pause.
 - One participant (P3114) stated the first response option (i.e., “Child care center/preschool/nursery school”) was a little confusing. The participant stated it was confusing “because my kid was in child care but I did not pay for the child care. It was through funding through the state.”
 - One participant (P3173) noted a challenge with the language of “paid care” in response option 3. This participant shared that they have family that takes care of their child, but it is unpaid.

If they responded “Other,” what type of care did they mean?

- There are no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

Though participants generally understood the question, we recommend revising the question stem to emphasize “paid” (e.g., all caps) to highlight the focus on this item. Consider as well that the question asks about care used “routinely” but also includes seasonal response options such as summer camp. Would someone who paid for summer camp consider its use to be routine, despite that it only occurs for a couple of months during the year? Consider whether to embed a different level of frequency of use into the question.

CHCARE_UNPAID (n=6)

In 2024, which type(s) of free or unpaid care were routinely used for your youngest child while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

This does not include care arranged on short notice due to an emergency, sick child, etc.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Care by you or another parent/guardian at home (1)
- 2 Head Start
- 3 Pre-Kindergarten (1)
- 4 Free care with family, friends, or neighbors (3)
- 5 Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher (1)
- 6 Other (1)
- 7 None - no free child care was used (1)

Findings:**Were there other types of child care respondents wanted to report here?**

- Only one participant selected “Other” and shared they would have typed in “After school programs/activities.” (P3173)

- While thinking about other types of child care, one participant reflected that they could have also selected “Free care with family.” This participant selected “Care by you or another parent/guardian” and stated that they wouldn’t add to their response (P5353). It’s unclear why this participant would not add to their final response after verbally endorsing response option 4 (i.e., “Free care with family, friends, or neighbors”).

Did they have any difficulty picking an appropriate category?

- No participant expressed difficulty in choosing a response.

Keep track of “Other” responses, even if the respondent doesn’t choose “Other.” We are particularly interested if they consider elementary school as free care.

- No participants mentioned elementary school as free care. One participant did endorse Pre-Kindergarten as a routine avenue for unpaid child care (P4896).

Recommendations:

Although participants understood the question and did not struggle with providing a response, we recommend revisions to the question stem and response options to reduce risks to misreporting and data quality. Similar to CHCARE_PAID, we recommend revising the question stem to emphasize “unpaid” to highlight the focus on this item. We also recommend that SMEs consider grouping response option 1 (i.e., “Care by you or another parent/guardian at home”) and 4 (i.e., “Free care with family, friends, or neighbors”) closer together to reduce cognitive burden on respondents.

CHCARE_MAIN (n=3)

In 2024, what was the main type of child care used for your youngest child while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

- 1 Child care center/preschool/nursery school (1)
- 2 Home-based daycare
- 3 Paid care by a nanny, babysitter, family, friends, or neighbors
- 4 Before and/or after-school care
- 5 Summer/day/school break camps (1)
- 6 Care by you or another parent/guardian at home
- 7 Head Start
- 8 Pre-Kindergarten (1)
- 9 Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- 10 Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- 11 Other

Findings:

- Out of the six participants who responded to CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID, two participants selected more than one response in CHCARE_UNPAID (P3173, P4896) and one participant selected more than one response in CHCARE_PAID (P3907).

- None of the participants in this universe expressed difficulty in choosing a response.

Recommendations:

If revisions to response options displayed in CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID are made, we would recommend updating the order of response options here to be consistent with previous child care items.

CHCARE_REP (n=1)

What is easiest way for you to report how much your household spent on childcare in 2024?

- 1 Cost for each child separately (1)
- 2 Cost for all children together

Findings:

Did respondents understand the question?

- Only one participant received this item. This participant (P3114) expressed confusion about this question because they only have one child, even though there are multiple children living in the household. While responding to the question, this participant was only thinking about themselves and their child, and not all children in the household. When spontaneously probed if their response would change if thinking about all children in the household, this participant stated their response would stay the same.

What kind of things made them choose one option over the other?

- The participant reflected that their child is the only child of age who needs regular child care, given that the other children go to school and therefore do not need child care. (P3114)

Recommendation:

In fielding, there will be a roster listing the names and number of children, which should help address confusion about who should be considered when responding. However, to further reduce confusion consider listing the children younger than age 13 from the roster under the question.

NEW CHCARE (n=1)

Please estimate how much your household spent on child care in 2024.

Findings:

- One participant (P3114) responded to this item. This participant did not have any issues with this question and was confident in their response, given that no adults in the household pay for child care.

Recommendation:

No recommendations based on the limited data available. However, it's unclear if the item was intentionally only targeted for participants with multiple children age 13 or younger in the household who used paid child care, or if this item was intended for any participant with at least one child age 13 or younger in the household who used child care. According to the protocol, NEW CHCARE displays after CHCARE_REP. Participants receive CHCARE_REP only if there are multiple children age 13 years or younger in the household who used child care, whereas participants with one child age 13 years or younger in the household route to CHCARE_SUB instead. We recommend reviewing the routing logic in this portion of the questionnaire to ensure the survey flows as intended. It is also worth noting that several participants did not respond to any of the child care items due to time constraints.

CHCARE_SUB (n=5)

In 2024, was any of your child's care fully or partially covered by a voucher or child care subsidy?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No (5)

Findings:

Did respondents know what a subsidy is?

- All five participants who received this item endorsed an understanding of subsidy.
 - One participant (P3907) stated that a subsidy is "like someone else paying on your behalf."
 - One participant (P3173) described a subsidy as a program paid by local or state government or charity organization that allows for a lower cost paid by the parent.
 - Two participants (P3291, P5353) acknowledged that a subsidy involves assistance from the "government" in some way.

Recommendations:

It's unclear if the item was intentionally only targeted for participants with one child age 13 years or younger in the household, or if this item was intended for any participant with at least one child age 13 years or younger in the household who used child care. According to the protocol, CHCARE_SUB displays after CHCARE_MAIN. Participants receive CHCARE_SUB only if there is one child age 13 years or younger in the household, whereas participants with multiple children age 13 years or younger in the household who used child care route to CHCARE_REP. We recommend reviewing the routing logic in this portion of the questionnaire to ensure the survey flows as intended.

CHCARE_PROB (n=6)

In 2024, did anyone in this household have to work less, or could not work more or at all, because they had trouble finding child care (paid or free)?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Yes, had to work less (2)
- 2 Yes, could not work more (1)
- 3 Yes, could not work at all (2)
- 4 No (1)

Findings:**How did respondents interpret this question, particularly “have to work less, or could not work more or at all”?**

- Most participants did not have trouble providing their interpretation of these statements (n=5).
 - For example, one participant (P3291) interpreted the statement “Yes, had to work less” as “the child took more time so you couldn’t work ... you had to work less or you couldn’t increase hours of work.”
 - Many participants (P3114, P3173, P5353, P4896) described these statements as not being able to find available child care.
- One participant (P3907), who responded “Yes, could not work at all,” stated that these statements were hard to understand. It is unclear, however, why this participant expressed difficulties with this item.

What did they consider when selecting their answer?

- Two participants provided responses to this probe.
- Participants shared that they thought about not finding friends or family for child care and the affordability of child care (P5353) as well as spending more time with their kids and not being able to work more (P3291).

Recommendations:

No change recommended.

CHCARE_ADAPT_YN (n=6)

At any time in 2024, was child care unavailable, closed, unaffordable, or not safe for [the child/any of the children] in your household?

- 1 Yes (2)
- 2 No (4)

Findings:

Were respondents only thinking about times when they were working/looking for work/in school?

- For the two participants who endorsed not having access to child care at least one time in 2024, they shared that they thought about situations when they had to work (P3114) as well as instances of school closures due to weather or an emergency (P3173).
 - One participant shared that they lost a job due to not receiving assistance for child care (P3114)
- Among the other participants who did not endorse at least one experience in 2024 when child care was not accessible:
 - One participant (P3291) thought about the COVID pandemic and the impact it had on child care, specifically that during COVID, child care was less available.
 - One participant (P3907) mentioned that there are also unique situations where a day care may change their policies, which could impact accessibility.
 - Another participant (P4896) mentioned situations where after-school care may be unaffordable.

Recommendations:

Participants expressed a clear understanding of the question and did not report any difficulties with providing a response. No changes recommended. Participant reports included school closures. Consider whether this item should include school under the umbrella of child care.

CHCARE_ADAPT_WAY (n=1)

When child care was unavailable, closed, unaffordable, or unsafe, what actions did the adults in the household take to provide care for the [child/children]?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Took unpaid leave
- 2 Used vacation, sick days, or other paid leave
- 3 Cut or changed work hours
- 4 Quit a job (1)
- 5 Missed work and was fired from a job
- 6 Did not look for a job
- 7 Supervised one or more children while working
- 8 Other
- 9 None of the above

Findings:

Regardless of whether they selected “Other,” what adaptations did they mention?

- One participant received this item. This participant understood the question and did not provide any adaptations of the response options while thinking aloud.

What situations were they considering when they answered?

- “Quit a job” matched closely with the participant’s situation.

Recommendations:

No recommendations based on the limited data available.

7.3.9 Child Support

CHSUP_YN (n=6)

In 2024, did [you/anyone in this household] pay child support for children living elsewhere?

Child support payments are made to the parent or legal guardian providing most of the child’s care. Do not include college expenses unless this is part of a legal agreement.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No (6)
- 3 Not applicable

Findings:

Did respondents react poorly to being asked this?

- None of the participants reactively negatively to this item, although none reported paying child support.

If they selected “Not applicable,” why did they pick it?

- No data to support analysis.

For children older than age 18 years, what expenses were being considered for inclusion?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

8. Conclusions and Overall Recommendations

The following section presents global findings and resulting recommendations for issues that impact multiple ASEC Income and Health Insurance questions. We provide several considerations to improve the questions prior to the conduct of any additional testing or fielding.

8.1 Health Insurance

8.1.1 Parenthetical Examples and Other Terminology

As a result of previous exploratory interviews and cognitive testing of the Health Insurance module, questions where participants had trouble interpreting items or response options as intended were modified to include clarifications in parentheses. Although these generally worked well, for some participants the parenthetical examples or qualifications proved somewhat confusing. In light of the findings outlined in this report, we recommend that this section be reviewed to see whether all the clarifications are needed, and if it is best to keep them in parentheses or make them part of the question stems. We also offer specific item-level recommendations for revising examples in *Section 5.1*.

The term “uninsured” was also not fully understood by some. Although no issues were found in Round 1 cognitive testing with the term “uninsured” and participants were split in their preference of “uninsured” or “without insurance,” and despite the small evidence that the term “uninsured” could possibly be problematic, we recommend rewording as “Were you without health insurance at any point in 2024?” This is important data and this change will ensure clarity for everyone.

8.1.2 Medical Out of Pocket Expenses

An important issue remains in this section with possible double reporting of certain expenses between MOOP_PREM and MOOP_NONPREM. The transition sentence into this topic is necessary, but in its current form it may be contributing to the double counting. We recommend the wording be simplified as an introduction only as follows:

The next questions are about what your household paid for health costs in 2024.

Then, prefacing the MOOP_PREM question with “First...” may make it clearer to the participant that this question is just about the amount spent on premiums. As further assurance that respondents will not double report expenses, MOOP_NONPREM could be reworded as:

Not counting any amount reported in the last question, in 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other nonprescription medical expenses?

8.2 Migration

8.2.1 Reference Periods

The lack of a clearly stated reference date appeared to be the primary source of confusion for respondents on 1-year and 5-year move items. Presenting the reference date below the question may reduce measurement error and aid the recall of respondents who may have moved at or around the time of the reference date, or who are transient.

We recommend filling the date (i.e., 1 year ago; 5 years ago) below the question (e.g., Date 1 year ago: February 3, 2025). Although this specific presentation was not tested in this round of cognitive interviews, similar formats that displayed fills below question text were tested in the Health Insurance module (e.g., Q15job or 15m as presented in slide 19 in Appendix D) and performed well.

We also recommend retesting this format in future rounds of cognitive testing to assess performance.

8.2.2 Reasons for Moving

The questions on reasons for move should be reviewed to identify any possible reductions and clarifications of response choices, as participants often found the list dauntingly long and some had difficulty deciding what option best fit their reason for moving. In addition, for those items that include the “No other reason” response choice, this should be more prominently displayed, through the use of highlighting or by separating the line to make it stand out more.

8.3 Income

8.3.1 Proxy Reporting

Similar to Round 1, several participants in Round 2 had trouble reporting for others in the household on income *source* items. The inclusion of the new instruction allowing estimates seemed to address some of the issues involved with reporting income *amounts* that were found in Round 1.

Following the findings from Round 1, to address issues with proxy reporting of income sources, the response option **“Someone in the household got [INCOME SOURCE], but I’m not sure what type”** was added to several questions in the “Income Sources” section. However, almost half of the participants in Round 2 indicated that they did not know the answer to a question at some point during the “Income Sources” section of the interview. The “Someone in the household got [INCOME SOURCE], but I’m not sure what type” response option was rarely used when participants were uncertain about income sources of others in their household (see distributions for each question below). Choosing this response option would indicate that the respondent confidently knows that someone else in

their household received income from this source, but that they just did not know the type received. However, for the participants described above, most were not confident or had no idea if others in their household received that income source at all. Therefore, this response option was not appropriate for them to indicate that they didn't know about income sources for others in their household. We recommend rewording this response option on all questions as follows:

I am not sure if someone else in the household received [INCOME SOURCE], or I am not sure what type they received.

8.3.2 Double Reporting Instruction

To address issues found in Round 1 with double reporting, most items in the "Income Sources" section included the instructions: **"Do not include anything you already reported."** Overall, participants found these instructions to be confusing and repetitive, especially when they were asked about an income source they had not been previously asked about in a prior question (e.g., unemployment). A few participants also interpreted this instruction to refer to reporting on taxes.

In general, we recommend including this instruction only when an income source is likely to have been reported on a previous question. We have listed this recommendation where applicable in each associated question in **Section 7.2.2**. We also note that for some questions, this instruction was helpful in reducing double reporting on items where respondents were more likely to do so (e.g., pensions), and thus it is important to keep this instruction on those questions.

Appendix A. Recruitment Screener

Web Survey Screener Specifications

Introduction and consent

Web intro/consent

RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, is conducting research on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau to improve questions in one of its national surveys.

To determine if you are eligible to participate in the research, we will ask you a few screening questions about your background and your household. Eligible participants can receive \$40 for a virtual interview, which will last 60 minutes.

If you are eligible for the study, we will call or email you to schedule a time for the interview.

Your participation in the eligibility screening is completely voluntary. You may stop at any time or skip questions that you do not want to answer.

This voluntary survey is being conducted under the authority of Title 13 U.S. Code, Sections 131 and 182. Federal law requires that your answers are kept confidential (Title 13, U.S. Code, Section 9), and protects your privacy under the Privacy Act (Title 5 U.S. Code, Section 552a). Routine uses of these data are limited to those identified in the Privacy Act System of Record Notice titled “COMMERCE/CENSUS-5, Decennial Census Programs.” The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you, your business, organization, or institution.

We estimate that completing these screening questions will take 15 minutes on average. This information collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). You can validate that this survey is a legitimate using the Office of Management and Budget's approval number 0607-0725, which expires 12/31/2025. We are required to tell you this number to conduct this survey. Send comments regarding this estimate or any other aspect of this survey, including suggestions for reducing the time it takes to complete this survey to adrm.pra@census.gov.

If you have questions about the research, you may contact RTI's project director, [D: NAME], at [D: PHONE NUMBER] or [D: EMAIL]

Consent to Participate

Do we have your permission to ask you a few questions to find out if you are eligible for this study?

If you agree to participate, please click “Yes, I agree” below and then the “NEXT” button to continue. If you choose not to participate, please click “Exit” and then the “NEXT” button to exit the survey.

☐₁ Yes, I agree [[Skip to Q1](#)]

☐₂ Exit [[Skip to REFUSAL](#)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 1: Key eligibility screener

Q1. Age

How old are you?

[] [If Q2<18, skip to INELIGIBLE]
[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (6-110)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q2. Federal employment status

Are you employed by the Federal Government? (if federal contractor, mark NO)

☐₁ Yes [skip to INELIGIBLE]
☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q3. Location

In what state or district do you currently live?

State: []

In what city and ZIP code do you currently live?

City: []

ZIP code []

[PROGRAMMER: CITY – TEXTBOX with 50 characters Max.; State – TEXTBOX; ZIP code – 5 digits NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q3.1 Location II

Which of the following best describes the place where you now live?

- ☐₁ A large city
- ☐₂ A suburb
- ☐₄ A small city or town
- ☐₅ A rural area

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 2: Demographic characteristics**Q4.1 SOGI-1**

What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

- ☐₁ Male
☐₂ Female
☐₄ I don't want to answer

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q6. Race

What is your race and/or ethnicity? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ American Indian or Alaska Native White
☐₂ Asian
☐₃ Black or African American
☐₄ Hispanic or Latino
☐₅ Middle Eastern or North African
☐₆ Native Hawaiian or other Pacific Islander
☐₇ White

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q7. Education

What is the highest grade of school you have completed, or the highest degree you have received?

- ☐₁ Less than high school diploma or equivalent
☐₂ High school diploma (including GED or ABE certificate)
☐₃ Some college, no degree
☐₄ Associate's degree (AA, AS, or equivalent)
☐₅ Bachelor's degree (BA, BS, or equivalent)
☐₆ Post Bachelor's degree (MA, MS, PhD, JD, MD, etc.)
☐₇ I have not completed any formal education

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q7.1. Internet use frequency

How frequently do you use the Internet? *This includes accessing the Internet through a cell phone, computer, or tablet.*

- ☐₁ Daily
☐₂ At least once a week

- ☐₃ At least once a month
- ☐₄ Less than once a month
- ☐₅ Rarely

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q7.2. Smartphone ownership

Do you own a smartphone (such as an iPhone or Android)?

- ☐₁ Yes
- ☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q8.1. Marital event in the past year

In 2023, did you become— *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Married?
- ☐₂ Widowed?
- ☐₃ Separated?
- ☐₄ Divorced?
- ☐₅ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Make 5 (“None of the above”) as an exclusive option.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 3: Household characteristics

Q9. Cohabitation status

Does anyone live or stay with you at your current address? Also include people who only sometimes live or stay with you.

- ☐₁ Yes [ask Q10]
- ☐₂ No [skip to Q14]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q10. Cohabitation status II

[Ask if Q9 = Yes] Who lives or stays with you? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Parent(s)
- ☐₂ Grandparent(s)
- ☐₃ Husband/wife/spouse
- ☐₄ Unmarried partner
- ☐₅ Children

- ☐ ₆ Grandchildren
☐ ₇ Other relatives(s)
☐ ₈ Roommates
☐ ₉ Friends
☐ ₁₀ Other – please specify

[PROGRAMMER: WHEN 10 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “please specify” TEXTBOX.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q11. Number of adults

[If Q9=1] How many people age 18 or older currently live or stay at your address, INCLUDING yourself?

[] adult/adults

[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (1-19)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q12. Number of children in household

[If Q9=1] How many people younger than 18 currently live or stay at your address?

[] child/children

[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (0-19)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q12.2. Young child (age between 5 and 13) in household

[Ask if Q12>=1] Is any child living or staying at your address 13 or younger?

- ☐ ₁ Yes
☐ ₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q13. Children event in the past year

In 2023, did you or a partner or spouse —

- ☐ ₁ give birth to any children?
☐ ₂ adopt any children?
☐ ₃ foster any children?
☐ ₄ None of the above

-----NEXT SCREEN-----
Module 4: Health Insurance and social programs

(For ASEC) Q14. Health insurance coverage

Do you currently have health insurance?

- ☐₁ Yes
- ☐₂ No, I don't have any health insurance
- ☐₃ Don't know

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q15. Type of health insurance

[Ask if Q14=1] What type of health insurance? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Insurance coverage through an employer, school, or other group-based program (through you or another family member)
- ☐₂ Medicare
- ☐₃ Medicaid or other type of government-assistance plan for people with low incomes or disabilities
- ☐₄ Coverage purchased through healthcare.gov or other state-led marketplace associated with the Affordable Care Act (also known as Obamacare)
- ☐₅ TRICARE, VA healthcare, or other military health care
- ☐₆ Other type of insurance – please specify

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q16. Health insurance policy holder

[Ask if Q15=1 or Q15=4 or Q15=5] Is this health insurance in your own name, or do you get it through someone else?

- ☐₁ It's in my name
- ☐₂ I get it through someone else
- ☐₃ Don't know

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q17. Lack of access to regular healthcare

If you are sick or need to see a medical professional, where do you go? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Doctor's office

- ☐₂ Hospital
- ☐₃ Walk-in health clinic (e.g., MinuteClinic, Patient First, Urgent Care)
- ☐₄ Pharmacy
- ☐₅ Other places, please specify:
- ☐₆ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Make 6 (“None of the above”) as an exclusive option.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q18. Social Assistance programs

In 2023, did you or someone in your household receive benefits from any of the following programs? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), sometimes referred to as food stamps
- ☐₂ Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC)
- ☐₃ School Lunch Program
- ☐₄ Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)
- ☐₅ Energy assistance (heating/cooling)
- ☐₆ Housing or rent assistance
- ☐₇ Broadband or internet assistance
- ☐₈ Other public assistance – please specify
- ☐₉ Did not receive any of the benefits above

[PROGRAMMER: IF 8 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “Please specify” TEXTBOX.]

[PROGRAMMER: Make 9 (“Did not receive any of the benefits above”) as an exclusive option.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 5: Employment and Income

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q22. Employment

Were you working at any time in 2023?

- ☐₁ Yes
- ☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q21. Work arrangement

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023, did you work for an employer, were you self-employed, or did you have some other work arrangement?

- ☐₁ I worked for an employer

☐₂ I was self-employed

☐₃ I had another work arrangement — Please specify

[PROGRAMMER: IF 3 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “Please specify” TEXTBOX.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q23.1. Unemployment

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023, did you have any periods where you were **not** working?

☐₁ Yes, I was retired for some time

☐₂ Yes, I was unemployed or out of work for some time

☐₃ Yes, I was unable to work due to disability for some time

☐₄ Yes, I was not working for some other reason (please specify)

☐₅ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q24. Number of jobs

[Ask if Q22 = 1] At any point in 2023, did you work two or more jobs at the same time?

Please include any side jobs you did for pay in addition to a primary job.

☐₁ Yes

☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q25. New job in the past year (life event)

[Ask if Q22=1] Did you start a job in 2023?

☐₁ Yes

☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q26 Seasonal/non-standard work (last year)

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023 did you do any of the following types of work?

Type of Work	Yes (1)	No (2)
Q26.1 Temporary or seasonal work (<i>for example, holiday sales associate, summer camp counselor, crop harvester, etc.</i>)		

Type of Work	Yes (1)	No (2)
Q26.2 In-person jobs or tasks through companies that connect you directly with customers using a website or mobile app (<i>for example, delivering food or groceries or driving for a rideshare service</i>)		
Q26.3 Freelancing or consulting work		
Q26.4 Other types of side jobs that provide additional income streams. <i>Do not include time spent answering online surveys</i> Please Specify:		

[PROGRAMMER: IF Q26.4 =1, DISPLAY “Please specify” TEXTBOX.]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q30. Other income

In 2023, did you receive income from any of the following sources? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Interest and dividends earned from savings or investments
- ☐₂ Retirement or pension income, including regular payments from estates, trusts, or annuities
- ☐₃ Rental income
- ☐₄ Commission
- ☐₅ Bonus
- ☐₆ Tips
- ☐₇ Unemployment benefits
- ☐₈ Worker compensation
- ☐₉ Social Security or supplemental security income
- ☐₁₀ TANF or other public assistance benefits
- ☐₁₁ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Option 11 to be programmed as exclusive]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 6: Contact info

Finally, we just have a few more questions about your contact information. If you are eligible and selected to participate in the study, we will use the information to contact you to schedule the interview.

Q31. Name

What is your name?

Name: [_____]

Q32. Email

What is your email address?

[_____]
[PROGRAMMER: email verification]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q33. Phone

What is the best telephone number to reach you? (Numbers only, please do not include special characters)

Phone ([____]) [____] – [_____]

Q34. Time to call

What is the best time to reach you by phone?

- ☐1 Mornings (8-10 AM)
- ☐2 Midday (11 AM-1 PM)
- ☐3 Afternoons (2-5 PM)
- ☐4 Evenings (after 5 PM)

Q35. Referral

Could you think of any family or friends who may be interested in participating in our interview? Please provide their name and email address for us to reach out to them in the next screen.

- ☐1 Yes
- ☐2 No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q35.1. Referral name

[Ask if Q35=1] What is the name of your family or friend?

Name: [_____]

Q35.2. Referral email

[Ask if Q35=1] What is the email address of your family or friend?

[_____]
[PROGRAMMER: email verification]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q36.1 Interview participation.

Would you be able to participate in a [90; 60] minute virtual interview at a day/time to be determined in [MONTH]? The interview will use a free software called Microsoft Teams.

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q36.2 Screen sharing.

Would you be willing to share your phone or computer screen during the interview?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q36.3 Recording.

We would like to audio and video record interviews. Would you be willing to have the interview video and audio recorded?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q37. Advertisement source

How did you hear about this study?

- ☐₁ Community publication (for example, local paper)
☐₂ Flyer
☐₃ Friends or family
☐₄ RTI or Census Bureau employee
☐₅ Craigslist
☐₆ Facebook
☐₇ Reddit
☐₈ Other – specify: _____

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Exit/Completion

Thank you for taking the time to answer our questions today. We will get back to you soon if you are eligible for an interview.

Refusal/Screened out

Based on your responses, you are not eligible to participate in this study. Thank you for taking the time to answer our questions today.

Appendix B. Participant Recruitment Materials

Subject line: Upcoming invitation to participate in a Census Bureau Interview

Good [Morning/afternoon], **FIRST NAME**,

My name is **RECRUITER NAME**. I am contacting you because you recently expressed interest in participating in an interview to discuss your thoughts and opinions on questions asking about you and your household. This interview is being conducted by RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS) for the United States Census Bureau.

The interview should take about 60 minutes, and you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card as a thank you for participating in the interview.

We plan to reach out to you again later this summer to schedule you for an interview. No action is needed from you at this time – we will be in touch in the coming weeks once we are scheduling interviews.

Thank you,

RECRUITER NAME

Subject line: Invitation to participate in a Census Bureau Interview

Good [Morning/afternoon], **FIRST NAME**,

My name is **RECRUITER NAME**. I am contacting you because you recently expressed interest in participating in an interview to discuss your thoughts and opinions on questions asking about you and your household. This interview is being conducted by RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS) for the United States Census Bureau.

Your responses indicate that you are in **[TIME ZONE]**. Below are some available appointments for an interview:

- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**

The interview should take about 60 minutes, and you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card as a thank you for participating in the interview.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview to help us accurately capture your answers. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview. Please let me know if you prefer not to be video recorded during the interview.

Please let me know what time works best for you. Once we confirm the appointment time, I will send an invitation email for the interview.

Thank you,

RECRUITER NAME

Recontact Email

This email template is designed to contact the recruits who completed the previous CPS cognitive interview screener but were not selected for interview scheduling. CPS recruitment has spent approximately 3-4 weeks to look for a couple of specific characteristics to fulfill the requirement, which leaves many recruits suitable for ASEC recruitment. However, since the screeners are evolved to separate surveys with some different questions, we need to get these people to fill out the ASEC screener in order to assess their eligibility.

SUBJECT:

Census Bureau research interview - \$40 incentive

Email text:

Hi [NAME],

You are receiving this email because you previously responded to a Craigslist/Reddit advertisement about a research study conducted on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. We have concluded the previous research study but have another opportunity available:

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 60 minutes. We will provide \$40 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

[LINK TO RECRUITMENT SCREENER]

You may also call 866-280-1520 to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

This questionnaire will close on Friday, June 27th but we will review responses and reach out to those who are eligible later this summer.

Thank you,

[SIGNATURE]

ASEC Interview Calendar Invitation Template

Event title: ASEC Census Bureau Interview

This calendar invite is for your Census Bureau interview. Thank you again for agreeing to participate!

As a reminder:

- Your interview is scheduled for **[DAY]**, **[DATE]**, from **[START TIME]** to **[END TIME]** **[PST/MST/CST/EST]**.
- The interview will be conducted virtually using the video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. The link and information for joining the meeting is below. Please click on the link to connect with your interviewer at your scheduled meeting time.
- You will receive a \$40 electronic gift card as a thank you for your participation in the interview.
- The interviewer's name is **[INTERVIEWER NAME]**.
- **Interviews will be conducted via a desktop or laptop computer. If you need to join via your phone, that is okay.**

Before the interview, please review the consent information attached to this email. Your interviewer will review it when you meet, and you can ask any questions you may have.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview to help us accurately capture your answers. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

If you need to reach us before the interview, please reply to this email.

If you need to reach us on the day of your interview, please call me at **866-280-1520**.

Thank you for your participation!

[Recruiter name]

Reminder Email Template—Schedule Send to Go Out the Day Before the Interview

EMAIL VERSION

Subject line: Census Bureau Interview Reminder – DATE at TIME

Good [Morning/afternoon], FIRST NAME,

This is a reminder about your interview on **DATE at TIME (time zone)**. Thank you again for agreeing to participate! Below are the details about the appointment. I have also sent you a calendar invite to help reserve the time on your schedule.

Some important notes:

- The interview will be conducted virtually using the video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. The link and information for joining the meeting is below.
- **Please join via a desktop or laptop computer. If you need to join via your phone, that is okay.**
- Before the interview, please review the consent information attached to your meeting invitation.
- We would also like to audio and video record the interview to help us accurately capture your answers. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

Please respond to this email or give me a call if you have any questions or need to reschedule your interview.

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

866-280-1520

Appendix C. Cognitive Interview Participant Consent Form

What is the purpose of this interview?

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting interviews to help with the design and content about a portion of the Current Population Survey (CPS). This module, called the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC) is an important source of information about our nation on topics such as employment, health insurance, and income. It's important that the questions make sense, are easy to answer, and that everyone understands the questions in the same way. You are one of about 60 people who are being asked to participate in these interviews. Findings from these interviews will be used to clarify survey questions and instructions on the survey.

What will happen if I take part in this interview?

If you agree to take part in this study, you will be asked to answer questions about your household, including yourself and other people that live with you. The interview will be conducted virtually by a staff member from RTI International or Research Support Services, who are doing this study for the U.S. Census Bureau.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. It will help us make sure we accurately capture your answers. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

How much time is required to participate?

The interview will last approximately 90 minutes.

Do I have to take part in this interview?

No, participation in this interview is voluntary. You can stop the interview at any time, and you don't have to answer a question if you don't want to. You will not lose any rights you would normally have if you choose not to join this interview.

What are the possible risks and benefits from participating in this interview?

There are no direct benefits to you from doing this interview. Your involvement in this study will help us improve the questions for the Current Population Survey. There is no more than minimal risk in participating.

How will my privacy be protected?

By law, we are required to keep your answers confidential. The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting this study under the authority of 13 U.S.C. Sections 131, 141, 182, 193, and 196. Your privacy is protected by the Privacy Act of 1974 (5 U.S.C. Section 552a). Only

research staff from the U.S. Census Bureau, RTI International, and Research Support Services will know your answers to interview questions. The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you or other members of your household.

This collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). This eight-digit OMB approval number, 0607-0725, confirms this approval and expires on 12/31/2025. Without this approval, we could not conduct this study.

How will I be compensated?

You will receive \$40.

What if I have questions about the interview?

If you have concerns or questions about the interview, you may contact RTI's project director, Patty LeBaron, at 312-777-5204 or plebaron@rti.org.

Participant's Agreement: I have read the information provided above. I voluntarily agree to participate in this interview.

() I agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.

() I do NOT agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.

Use your mouse or finger to sign your name in the box below.

SIGN HERE

Type today's date below.

Fill in the following information below:

First Name: _____

Last Name: _____

Appendix D. Health Insurance, Out of Pocket Expenses, and Migration Cognitive Protocol

Protocol for Insurance through a Job: ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP testing + Migration

July 2025

THERE ARE NOT MANY SPECIFIC PROBES. PLEASE MAKE SURE GENERAL OBSERVATIONS OF TROUBLE UNDERSTANDING THE QUESTION AND PROBE ON THOSE PROBLEMS AS NEEDED.

THERE ARE SOME POINTS WHERE THE INTERVIEWER IS ALLOWED (ENCOURAGED) TO ENGAGE WITH THE RESPONDENT TO HELP THEM NAVIGATE THE CLUNKINESS OF SOME QUESTIONS/PATHS. HOWEVER, ALL HEALTH INSURANCE PROBES WILL BE HELD UNTIL THE END OF THE HEALTH INSURANCE QUESTIONS (BUT BEFORE MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.

- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready, and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but it's not a separate room from the kitchen because there are no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

Number

NOTE IF 1 PERSON IN HH OR 2+ IN ORDER TO NAVIGATE THE SKIPS

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Slide 3: Q2. Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT INS THROUGH A JOB FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Did you have trouble deciding between Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected "No health insurance".

Slide 4: Q2a. How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE DON'T WANT TO LENGTHEN THE QUESTION BY STATING COLLEGE/UNIVERSITY. DOES THE UNIVERSITY (ALONE) WORK?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you selected the student insurance option.

Probe (if choose Student ins): This option specifically states that the insurance is through a university. Do you see college and university as the same thing? If not, would you change the wording?

Slide 5: Q4c. Whose name was this insurance in?

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

WE DROPPED THE WORD "POLICYMAKER". WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE QUESTION IS UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT IT.

ALSO, THIS IS THE FIRST OF SEVERAL QUESTIONS THAT SHOW THE TYPE OF INSURANCE UNDER THE QUESTION, RATHER THAN AS A FILL IN THE QUESTION. WE WANT TO KNOW HOW RESPONDENTS LIKE/UNDERSTAND THAT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE DON'T LET R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHOSE INS IS NOT IN THEIR NAME.

Slide 6: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE "IN 2024" AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 7: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS "YES" THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 8: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

DOES THE WORD "GET" WORK FOR PEOPLE?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 9: Q5. How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Probe (only if asked Q33-35): This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What did you think about that?

Slide 10: Q15job. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THE RESPONDENT SHOULD THINK BROADLY ABOUT ANY EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE POLICIES IN THE HOUSEHOLD.

Probe: Were you thinking about the specific insurance policy (through a job) that we've been asking about or more generally, about insurance through any job?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAVE OTHER HH MEMBERS WITH INS THROUGH A JOB.

Slide 11: Q16job. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE EXPLAIN THIS TO THE RESPONDENT AND DON'T LET THEM GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 12: Q17job. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-
Adult child (18 or older)	-	-
Child 1 (under 18)	-	-
Child 2 (under 18)	-	-
Child 3 (under 18)	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC", AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 13: Q18job. Whose name was [Person in Q17_job]'s insurance in?

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult Child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE CHILDREN OVERALL.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE “GENERIC”. HELP RESPONDENTS AS NECESSARY.

Slide 14: Q19job1. Did [^Person in Q18_job]’s employer or union help pay for [^Person in Q17_job]’s insurance?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

NOTE THAT THIS QUESTION POTENTIALLY REFERS TO 2 DIFFERENT PEOPLE. THIS MAKES IT HARD TO UNDERSTAND WITH THE GENERIC FILLS. CONSIDER READING THE QUESTION TO THE RESPONDENT, FILLING IN THE HH MEMBERS’ NAMES.

Slide 15: Q19job2. Did [^Person in Q18_job]’s employer or union pay all or part of the cost of [^Person in Q17_job]’s insurance?

- ☐ All
- ☐ Part

NOTE THAT THIS QUESTION POTENTIALLY REFERS TO 2 DIFFERENT PEOPLE. CONSIDER READING THE QUESTION TO THE RESPONDENT, FILLING IN THE HH MEMBERS’ NAMES.

Slide 16: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 17: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member’s)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED. WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

**** "SOMETHING ELSE" IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PATH TO TEST. CHOOSE THAT LINK OVER OTHER RESPONSES GIVEN.**

(IF SELECT PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 18: Q9. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY "MARKETPLACE" AND "PURCHASED DIRECTLY".

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you chose the last option, about Student insurance. Would you change the wording of this option?

(IF SELECT SOME OTHER TYPE OF INS)

Slide 19: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 BECAUSE NO ONE SELECTED "OTHER".

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 17)?

Slide 20: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care

- ☐ HealthShare
- ☐ Other

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 21: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 22: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Medical doctor's office
- ☐ Clinic or hospital clinic
- ☐ Hospital emergency room
- ☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- ☐ Some other place
- ☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6.

Slide 23: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 24: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 25: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE “GENERIC” AND THEY INCLUDE “EXTRA” PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON’T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 26: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member’s)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (if more than one person selected in Q19): For the household member(s) we didn’t ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them—what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 27: Q25. How long did [Person] have this insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

Slide 28: Q20Adult. Was [Person] uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, 25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP QUESTIONS

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

- ☐ \$0 - \$199
- ☐ \$200 - \$499
- ☐ \$500 - \$999
- ☐ \$1,000 - \$2,999
- ☐ \$3,000 or more

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

- 4 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?
- 5 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 6 In the question, explain what "health insurance coverage" means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 7 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 8 Did you read the information in italics?
- 9 Did this help you answer the question?
- 10 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)
- 11 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 12 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 13 (If have insurance through a job) Did your answer include employer contributions to the cost or not?
- 14 (If 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

\$_____.00 for the year

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 15 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
- 16 Did this help you answer the question?
- 17 Were there still things that you weren't sure if you should include or not?
- 18 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 19 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today.” Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If "Don't Know"
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety

- For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship

- For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “5 years ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship

- For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?

- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?

- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, Slide 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, Slide 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenersA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

Stop recording

Protocol for Medicaid: ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP Testing + Migration

July 2025

There are not many specific probes. Please make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

There are some points where the interviewer is allowed (encouraged) to engage with the respondent to help them navigate the clunkiness of some of the questions/paths. However, all probes will be held until the end of the health insurance questions (but before MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation[.]>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.

- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but its not a separate room from the kitchen because there is no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

NOTE IF 1 PERSON IN HH OR 2+ IN ORDER TO NAVIGATE THE SKIPS

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Slide 3: Q2. Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT MEDICAID FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Was the difference between the first 2 options, Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job, clear? [If YES] What is the difference?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected “No health insurance”.

Slide 4: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE “IN 2024” AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 5: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS “YES” THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 6: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

DOES THE WORD "GET" WORK FOR PEOPLE?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 7: Q5. How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

THIS IS THE FIRST OF SEVERAL QUESTIONS THAT SHOWS THE TYPE OF INSURANCE UNDER THE QUESTION, RATHER THAN AS A FILL IN THE QUESTION. WE WANT TO KNOW HOW RESPONDENTS LIKE/UNDERSTAND THAT.

Probe: This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

Slide 8: Q15m. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THE RESPONDENT SHOULD THINK BROADLY ABOUT ALL GOVERNMENT PROGRAMS.

Probe: Were you thinking about the specific Medicaid policy that we've been asking about or more generally, about any government sponsored insurance?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAVE OTHER HH MEMBERS WITH MEDICAID OR SIMILAR PROGRAM.

Slide 9: Q16m. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)

- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE EXPLAIN THIS TO THE RESPONDENT AND DON'T LET THEM GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 10: Q17m. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-
Adult child (18 or older)	-	-
Child 1 (under 18)	-	-
Child 2 (under 18)	-	-
Child 3 (under 18)	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 11: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 12: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)

- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED, AND ASK THEM TO HUMOR US.

WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

** "SOMETHING ELSE" IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PATH TO TEST. CHOOSE THAT LINK OVER OTHER RESPONSES GIVEN.

(IF SELECT INS THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 13: Q8. How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE DON'T WANT TO LENGTHEN THE QUESTION BY STATING COLLEGE/UNIVERSITY. DOES UNIVERSITY (ALONE) WORK?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you selected the student insurance option.

Probe (if choose Student ins): This option specifically states that the insurance is through a university. Do you see college and university as the same thing? If not, would you change the wording?

(IF SELECT PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 14: Q9. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY "MARKETPLACE" AND "PURCHASED DIRECTLY".

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you chose the last option, about Student insurance. Would you change the wording of this option?

(IF SELECT SOME OTHER TYPE OF INS)

Slide 15: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 BECAUSE NO ONE SELECTED "OTHER".

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 12)?

Slide 16: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care
- ☐ HealthShare
- ☐ Other

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 17: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 18: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Medical doctor's office
- ☐ Clinic or hospital clinic
- ☐ Hospital emergency room
- ☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- ☐ Some other place
- ☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE

DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6.

Slide 19: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 20: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 21: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON

THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 22: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (IF MORE THAN ONE PERSON SELECTED IN Q19): For the household member(s) we didn't ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them -- what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 23: Q25. How long did [Person] have this insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

Slide 24: Q20. Adult Was [Person] uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, 25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP QUESTIONS

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

- ☐ \$0 - \$199
- ☐ \$200 - \$499
- ☐ \$500 - \$999
- ☐ \$1,000 - \$2,999
- ☐ \$3,000 or more

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

- 20 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?
- 21 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 22 In the question, explain what "health insurance coverage" means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 23 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 24 Did you read the information in italics?
- 25 Did this help you answer the question?
- 26 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)
- 27 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 28 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 29 (if have insurance through a job) Did your answer include employer contributions to the cost or not?
- 30 (if 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

\$_____.00 for the year

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 31 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
- 32 Did this help you answer the question?
- 33 Were there still things that you weren't sure if you should include or not?
- 34 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 35 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about "1 year ago today". Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description "in the 50 United States or Washington, DC" clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness,
 - landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk

- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety

- For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about "5 years ago today". Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse’s new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship

- For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family

- For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "Other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenersA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

STOP RECORDING

Protocol for Medicare: ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP testing + Migration

July 2025

There are not many specific probes. Please make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

There are some points where the interviewer is allowed (encouraged) to engage with the respondent to help them navigate the clunkiness of some of the questions/paths. However, all health insurance probes will be held until the end of the health insurance questions (but before MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review

Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but its not a separate room from the kitchen because there is no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

Including yourself, how many people are living or staying in your house?

_____ People

Note if 1 person in HH or 2+ in order to navigate the skips

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 3: Q2. Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

Mark all that apply.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else
- ☐ Not sure
- ☐ No health insurance

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT MEDICARE FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Was the difference between the first 2 options, Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job, clear? [If YES] What is the difference?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected “No health insurance”.

Slide 4: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE “IN 2024” AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 5: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS “YES” THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 6: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

DOES THE WORD “GET” WORK FOR PEOPLE?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 7: Q5. How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)

- ☐ All year

☐ Part of the year

THIS IS THE FIRST OF SEVERAL QUESTIONS THAT SHOWS THE TYPE OF INSURANCE UNDER THE QUESTION, RATHER THAN AS A FILL IN THE QUESTION. WE WANT TO KNOW HOW RESPONDENTS LIKE/UNDERSTAND THAT.

Probe: This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

Slide 8: Q15m. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)

☐ Yes
☐ No

Probe: Were you thinking about the specific Medicare policy that we've been asking about or more generally, about any Medicare or Medicare Supplemental plan?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAVE OTHER HH MEMBERS WITH MEDICAID OR SIMILAR PROGRAM.

Slide 9: Q16m. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)

☐ Adult 2

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. ALSO, ONLY OLDER ADULTS CAN HAVE MEDICARE SO CHILDREN (EVEN ADULT CHILDREN) ARE NOT PROVIDED AS AN OPTION. ADULT 2 MAY BE MORE THAN ONE PERSON. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON "ADULT 2". ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 10: Q17m. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 11: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 12: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED, AND ASK THEM TO HUMOR US.

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else

WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

** "SOMETHING ELSE" IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PATH TO TEST. CHOOSE THAT LINK OVER OTHER RESPONSES GIVEN.

(IF SELECT INS THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 13: Q8. How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ Student insurance through university

(IF SELECT PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 14: Q9. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY "MARKETPLACE" AND "PURCHASED DIRECTLY".

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

(IF SELECT SOME OTHER TYPE OF INS)

Slide 15: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 BECAUSE NO ONE SELECTED "OTHER".

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 12)?

Slide 16: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care
- ☐ HealthShare
- ☐ Other

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 17: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 18: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Medical doctor's office
- ☐ Clinic or hospital clinic
- ☐ Hospital emergency room
- ☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- ☐ Some other place
- ☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6.

Slide 19: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 20: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 21: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

Select all that apply

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 22: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (if more than one person selected in Q19): For the household member(s) we didn't ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them -- what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 23: Q25. How long did Adult 2/Child have this insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

Slide 24: Q20 Was adult [Person] uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, Q25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP Questions

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

- ☐ \$0–\$199
- ☐ \$200–\$499
- ☐ \$500–\$999
- ☐ \$1,000–\$2,999
- ☐ \$3,000 or more

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

- 36 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?
- 37 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 38 In the question, explain what "health insurance coverage" means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 39 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 40 Did you read the information in italics?
- 41 Did this help you answer the question?
- 42 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

- 43 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 44 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 45 (if 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

\$_____.00 for the year

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 46 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
- 47 Did this help you answer the question?
- 48 Were there still things that you weren't sure if you should include or not?
- 49 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 50 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse’s new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)

- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired

- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “5 years ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?

- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn't fill the list with the names; think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenerA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

STOP RECORDING

Protocol for Military Insurance (VA/TRICARE): ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP Testing + Migration

July 2025

There are not many specific probes. Please make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

There are some points where the interviewer is allowed (encouraged) to engage with the respondent to help them navigate the clunkiness of some of the questions/paths. However, all health insurance probes will be held until the end of the health insurance questions (but before MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but its not a separate room from the kitchen because there is no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

Including yourself, how many people are living or staying in your house?

_____ People

NOTE IF 1 PERSON IN HH OR 2+ IN ORDER TO NAVIGATE THE SKIPS

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 3: Q2. Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else
- ☐ Not sure
- ☐ No health insurance

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT TRICARE/VA INS FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Did you have trouble deciding between Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected "No health insurance".

(ONLY ASKED IF HAS TRICARE)

Slide 4: Q4c. Whose name was this insurance in?

VA/TRICARE or other military health care

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

WE DROPPED THE WORD "POLICYMAKER". WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE QUESTION IS UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT IT.

ALSO, THIS IS THE FIRST OF SEVERAL QUESTIONS THAT SHOWS THE TYPE OF INSURANCE UNDER THE QUESTION, RATHER THAN AS A FILL IN THE QUESTION. WE WANT TO KNOW HOW RESPONDENTS LIKE/UNDERSTAND THAT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHOSE INS IS NOT IN THEIR NAME.

Slide 5: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE "IN 2024" AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 6: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS "YES" THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 7: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

DOES THE WORD "GET" WORK FOR PEOPLE?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 8: Q5. How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

VA/TRICARE or other military health care

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Probe (only if asked Q33-Q35): This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

Slide 9: Q15_tricare. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

VA/TRICARE or other military health care

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THE RESPONDENT SHOULD THINK BROADLY ABOUT ANY KIND OF MILITARY INSURANCE.

Probe: Were you thinking about the specific insurance policy (TRICARE or VA) that we've been asking about or more generally, about any military insurance?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAVE OTHER HH MEMBERS WITH INS THROUGH A JOB.

Slide 10: Q16_tricare. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

VA/TRICARE or other military health care

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE EXPLAIN THIS TO THE RESPONDENT AND DON'T LET THEM GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 11: Q17_tricare. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

VA/TRICARE or other military health care

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-
Adult child (18 or older)	-	-
Child 1 (under 18)	-	-
Child 2 (under 18)	-	-
Child 3 (under 18)	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 12: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 13: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED, AND ASK THEM TO HUMOR US.

WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

** "SOMETHING ELSE" IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PATH TO TEST. CHOOSE THAT LINK OVER OTHER RESPONSES GIVEN.

Slide 14: Q8. How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE DON'T WANT TO LENGTHEN THE QUESTION BY STATING COLLEGE/UNIVERSITY. DOES UNIVERSITY (ALONE) WORK?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you selected the student insurance option.

Probe (if choose Student ins): This option specifically states that the insurance is through a university. Do you see college and university as the same thing? If not, would you change the wording?

(IF SELECT PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 15: Q9. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY "MARKETPLACE" AND "PURCHASED DIRECTLY".

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you chose the last option, about Student insurance. Would you change the wording of this option?

(IF SELECT SOME OTHER TYPE OF INS)

Slide 16: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 BECAUSE NO ONE SELECTED "OTHER".

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 13)?

Slide 17: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care

- ☐ HealthShare
- ☐ Other:

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 18: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 19: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Medical doctor's office
- ☐ Clinic or hospital clinic
- ☐ Hospital emergency room
- ☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- ☐ Some other place
- ☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

(QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6.)

Slide 20: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 21: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 22: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 23: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other:

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (if more than one person selected in Q19): For the household member(s) we didn't ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them -- what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 24: Q25. How long did Adult 2/Child have this insurance in 2024?

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Slide 25: Q20Adult. Was Adult 2/Child uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, 25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP QUESTIONS

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

- 51 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?
- 52 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 53 In the question, explain what "health insurance coverage" means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 54 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 55 Did you read the information in italics?
- 56 Did this help you answer the question?
- 57 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)
- 58 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 59 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 60 (if have insurance through a job) Did your answer include employer contributions to the cost or not?
- 61 (if 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 62 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
- 63 Did this help you answer the question?
- 64 Were there still things that you weren't sure if you should include or not?
- 65 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 66 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health

- For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle

- For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about "5 years ago today". Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse’s new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship

- For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family

- For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, Slide 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenerA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

STOP RECORDING

Protocol for Insurance through a Job: ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP Testing + Migration

July 2025

There are not many specific probes. Please make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

There are some points where the interviewer is allowed (encouraged) to engage with the respondent to help them navigate the clunkiness of some of the questions/paths. However, all health insurance probes will be held until the end of the health insurance questions (but before MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but its not a separate room from the kitchen because there is no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

Including yourself, how many people are living or staying in your house?

_____ People

NOTE IF 1 PERSON IN HH OR 2+ IN ORDER TO NAVIGATE THE SKIPS

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 3: Q2. Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else
- ☐ Not sure
- ☐ No health insurance

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT "OTHER" INSURANCE FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Did you have trouble deciding between Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected "No health insurance".

Slide 4: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member's)

- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g. Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 BECAUSE NO ONE SELECTED "OTHER".

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 3)?

Slide 5: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care
- ☐ HealthShare
- ☐ Other:

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 6: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 7: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

- ☐ Medical doctor's office
- ☐ Clinic or hospital clinic
- ☐ Hospital emergency room
- ☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store
- ☐ Some other place
- ☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

Slide 8: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE "IN 2024" AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 9: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS "YES" THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 10: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

DOES THE WORD "GET" WORK FOR PEOPLE?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 11: Q4c. Whose name was this insurance in?

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2

- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

WE DROPPED THE WORD "POLICYMAKER". WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE QUESTION IS UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT IT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 12: Q4d. Did an employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 13: Q4e. Did an employer or union pay all or part of the cost of the insurance?

- ☐ All
- ☐ Part

Slide 14: Q4f. Did you receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to pay for the insurance?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 15: Q5_that. How long did you have that health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Slide 16: Q15_nontypical. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 17: Q16_nontypical. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE EXPLAIN THIS TO THE RESPONDENT AND DON'T LET THEM GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 18: Q17_nontypical. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-
Adult child (18 or older)	-	-
Child 1 (under 18)	-	-
Child 2 (under 18)	-	-
Child 3 (under 18)	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 19: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision.

- ☐ Yes
☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 20: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
☐ Private health insurance not through a job
☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
☐ TRICARE or other military health care
☐ Indian Health Service

- ☐ Something else

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED, AND ASK THEM TO HUMOR US.

WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

(IF SELECT INS THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 21: Q8. How did you get your Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)?

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE DON'T WANT TO LENGTHEN THE QUESTION BY STATING COLLEGE/UNIVERSITY. DOES UNIVERSITY (ALONE) WORK?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you selected the student insurance option.

Probe (if choose Student ins): This option specifically states that the insurance is through a university. Do you see college and university as the same thing? If not, would you change the wording?

(IF SELECT PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB)

Slide 22: Q9. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY "MARKETPLACE" AND "PURCHASED DIRECTLY".

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you chose the last option, about Student insurance. Would you change the wording of this option?

(QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6)

Slide 23: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 24: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 25: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 26: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other:

PICK ONE PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (if more than one person selected in Q19): For the household member(s) we didn't ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them -- what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 27: Q25. How long did Adult 2/Child have this insurance in 2024?

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

Slide 28: Q20Adult. Was Adult 2/Child uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, 25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP QUESTIONS

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

67 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?

- 68 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 69 In the question, explain what “health insurance coverage” means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 70 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 71 Did you read the information in italics?
- 72 Did this help you answer the question?
- 73 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)
- 74 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 75 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 76 (if have insurance through a job) Did your answer include employer contributions to the cost or not?
- 77 (if 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 78 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
 - a Did this help you answer the question?
 - b Were there still things that you weren’t sure if you should include or not?
- 79 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 80 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse’s new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired

- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “5 years ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health

- For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenersA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

STOP RECORDING

Protocol for Private Insurance, not through a job: ASEC Health Insurance + MOOP Testing + Migration

July 2025

There are not many specific probes. Please make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

There are some points where the interviewer is allowed (encouraged) to engage with the respondent to help them navigate the clunkiness of some of the questions/paths. However, all health insurance probes will be held until the end of the health insurance questions (but before MOOP).

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF OBSERVER OR NOTETAKER ARE PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be observing the interview to see how the questions are working/taking notes on our conversation].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review this form? I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.

- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 60 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE/IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that you consent to participate in the interview today and that I have your permission to record the interview? [WAIT FOR VERBAL CONSENT]

Now I am going to open a document to show you what the questions in the survey would look like if you were answering them online. Unfortunately, for this test, the materials are not yet ready and these screens cannot be filled out. We will need to pretend that some of your specific details are included in the questions when they are not. This may be a bit confusing, but don't worry, I will help you keep track of who in your household a question is asking about.

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. This means that I would like you to tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will ask you follow-up questions after you answer all of the questions in the section.

Since thinking aloud is not something you normally do I want to give you an example of what I am asking you to do. If you were asked how many rooms you have in your home, you may say something like, "Well, I have 2 bedrooms, so that's 2. And there is a bathroom upstairs and another downstairs, and I have a kitchen, so 5, and I have a living room, but it's not a separate room from the kitchen because there is no walls, so I am not sure if I should count it as another room. I am not going to count it, so 5."

Now, to begin, let's look at these questions. Please remember to tell me what you are thinking as you come up with your answer and to tell me how you would answer the question.

Slide 1: HH size

Including yourself, how many people are living or staying in your house?

_____ People

NOTE IF 1 PERSON IN HH OR 2+ IN ORDER TO NAVIGATE THE SKIPS

Slide 2: Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2024?

Health insurance may include insurance through a job, Medicaid, Medicare, or insurance purchased from healthcare.gov.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Slide 3: Q2 Between January and December 2024, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else
- ☐ Not sure
- ☐ No health insurance

RESPONDENT SHOULD VERBALLY LIST AS MANY INSURANCES AS THEY HAVE BUT INTERVIEWER WILL STATE THAT THEY SHOULD THINK ABOUT PRIVATE INS FOR NOW.

PRIVATE INSURANCE WAS DIVIDED INTO INSURANCE THROUGH A JOB AND NOT THROUGH A JOB. MEDICARE WAS ALSO CHANGED TO EXPLICITLY NOTE ADVANTAGE AND SUPPLEMENTAL PLANS. WE ARE TESTING THOSE OPTIONS.

Probe: Did you have trouble deciding between Insurance through a job and Private health insurance not through a job?

Probe: For the insurance through a job option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe: For the Medicare option, was the information in parentheses helpful to you? Why?/Why not?

Probe (if chose No health ins): Please explain why you selected “No health insurance”.

Slide 4: Q2b. How did you get your Private health insurance not through a job?

- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university

WE ARE INTERESTED IN HOW RESPONDENTS UNDERSTAND THE RESPONSE OPTIONS, ESPECIALLY “MARKETPLACE” AND “PURCHASED DIRECTLY”.

Probe: The first option, State or Federal Marketplace, goes by different names. Please explain what Marketplace means to you.

Probe: Is the second response option, Purchased directly from an insurance company, different from Marketplace?

Probe (if choose Student ins): Please explain why you chose the last option, about Student insurance. Would you change the wording of this option?

Slide 5: Q4c. Whose name was this insurance in?

Private health insurance not through a job.

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

WE DROPPED THE WORD “POLICYMAKER”. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE QUESTION IS UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT IT.

ALSO, THIS IS THE FIRST OF SEVERAL QUESTIONS THAT SHOWS THE TYPE OF INSURANCE UNDER THE QUESTION, RATHER THAN AS A FILL IN THE QUESTION. WE WANT TO KNOW HOW RESPONDENTS LIKE/UNDERSTAND THAT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHOSE INS IS NOT IN THEIR NAME.

Slide 6: Q33. Did you have a job that offered health insurance to any of its employees in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTION WAS NOT TESTED IN ROUND 1 AND WE WONDER IF THE "IN 2024" AT THE END SOUNDS CLUNKY.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Probe: Would you reword this question at all?

Slide 7: Q34. Was it possible for you to get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THIS QUESTION IS ABOUT ELIGIBILITY, ALTHOUGH WE DON'T USE THIS WORD. WE WANT TO MAKE SURE THE RESPONDENT UNDERSTANDS THAT AND ANSWERS "YES" THEY WERE ELIGIBLE EVEN IF THEY DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Probe: Please explain what this question was asking.

Slide 8: Q35. Why didn't you get health insurance through a job in 2024?

- ☐ On someone else's plan
- ☐ Covered by another plan, not through a job
- ☐ Traded health insurance for higher pay
- ☐ Too expensive
- ☐ Don't need health insurance
- ☐ Have a pre-existing condition
- ☐ Haven't yet worked for this employer long enough to be covered
- ☐ Don't work enough hours per week or weeks per year
- ☐ Contract or temporary employees not allowed in plan
- ☐ Other/specify _____

Does the word “get” work for people?

Probe: Was this question clear to you?

Slide 9: Q5. How long did you have this type of health insurance in 2024?

Private health insurance not through a job.

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Probe (only if asked Q33-Q35): This question lists the specific type of insurance after the question. Did you see that? What do you think about that?

Slide 10: Q15_job. Did anyone else in your household also have this type of insurance in 2024?

Private health insurance not through a job.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

THE RESPONDENT SHOULD THINK BROADLY ABOUT ANY KIND OF PRIVATE INS NOT THROUGH A JOB.

Probe: Were you thinking about the specific insurance policy that we’ve been asking about or more generally, about any private insurance not through a job?

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAVE OTHER HH MEMBERS WITH INS THROUGH A JOB.

Slide 11: Q16_job. Which people in your household were also covered by this type of insurance in 2024?

Private health insurance not through a job.

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE “GENERIC” SINCE WE CANNOT DO A ROSTER. PLEASE DON’T LET THEM GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 12: Q17_job. How long did each person below have this type of insurance in 2024?

Private health insurance not through a job.

Household Member	All of 2024	Part of 2024
Adult 2	-	-
Adult child (18 or older)	-	-
Child 1 (under 18)	-	-
Child 2 (under 18)	-	-
Child 3 (under 18)	-	-

THIS IS A GRID. WE CAN'T TEST HOW THEY WOULD MANIPULATE IT BUT NOTE ANY DIFFICULTY UNDERSTANDING HOW TO RECORD THEIR ANSWERS, AND IF THEY WALK THROUGH EACH PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION OR NOT.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. IF NECESSARY, HELP THE RESPONDENT BY NAMING THE PEOPLE THEY MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION.

Probe: Was the question clear as written, or did you need to read the headings "All of 2024" and "Part of 2024" to understand it?

Slide 13: Q18_job. Whose name was [Person in Q17_job]'s insurance in?

Private health insurance not through a job.

- ☐ My name
- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Someone outside the household

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE CHILDREN OVERALL.

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC". HELP RESPONDENTS AS NECESSARY.

Slide 14: Q6. Did you have another type of health insurance in 2024?

Do not include plans that cover only dental, drugs, or vision.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

QUESTIONS ONLY FOR PEOPLE WHO HAD ANOTHER TYPE OF HEALTH INSURANCE.

Slide 15: Q7. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2024?

THE RESPONDENT MAY HAVE ALREADY LISTED ALL OF THEIR INSURANCE TYPES IN Q2. YOU CAN ACKNOWLEDGE THIS, IF THEY ARE CONFUSED, AND ASK THEM TO HUMOR US.

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Something else

WE PROBED THESE OPTIONS IN Q2. HOWEVER, IF THE RESPONDENT HAS TROUBLE WITH ANY OF THE FIRST 3 RESPONSE OPTIONS, PLEASE ASK WHY THEY HAD PROBLEMS.

** "SOMETHING ELSE" IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PATH TO TEST. CHOOSE THAT LINK OVER OTHER RESPONSES GIVEN.

(IF SELECT "SOMETHING ELSE")

Slide 16: Q2c. How did you get your health insurance in 2024?

Not tested in round 1 because no one selected it.

- ☐ Current job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Former job (yours or another family member)
- ☐ Union or professional association
- ☐ State or Federal Marketplace (e.g., Healthcare.gov)
- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- ☐ Broker
- ☐ Student insurance through university
- ☐ Some other way
- ☐ Not sure

Probe (if choose anything but Other/not sure): Why did these response options make more sense to you than the options in the previous question (slide 15)?

Slide 17: Q2d. What kind of health insurance did you have?

- ☐ Church
- ☐ Charity care
- ☐ HealthShare

☐ Other:

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. THESE ARE RESPONSE OPTIONS THAT HAVE SHOWN UP IN WRITE-INS. PLEASE RECORD ANYTHING ELSE MENTIONED.

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

Slide 18: Q2e. Is there a place where you usually go if you are sick and need health care?

THIS QUESTION IS NEW.

☐ Yes

☐ No

Probe: Did this question make sense to you?

Probe: Can you think of a situation where someone would answer No?

Slide 19: Q2f. What kind of place do you usually go to if you are sick and need health care?

☐ Medical doctor's office

☐ Clinic or hospital clinic

☐ Hospital emergency room

☐ Urgent care center or a clinic in a drug store or grocery store

☐ Some other place

☐ No one place

THIS QUESTION IS NEW. WE HOPE TO USE THIS INFO TO CORRECTLY CODE THEIR RESPONSE DURING DATA CLEANING.

Probe: Did you want to select more than one response? Please explain.

Probe (if Some other/no one place): Please explain your answer.

(QUESTION ONLY IF INSURED FOR PART OF THE YEAR IN Q6.)

Slide 20: Q11. Were you uninsured for part of 2024?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Slide 21: Q18. Was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2024?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Slide 22: Q19. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

- ☐ Adult 2
- ☐ Adult child (18 or older)
- ☐ Child 1 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 2 (under 18)
- ☐ Child 3 (under 18)

THE RESPONSE OPTIONS ARE "GENERIC" AND THEY INCLUDE "EXTRA" PEOPLE WHO WERE PROBABLY NOT NAMED. PLEASE DON'T LET THE R GET TOO HUNG UP ON THIS. ALLOW THEM TO TALK ABOUT THEIR HOUSEHOLD AS THEY WISH (E.G., BY NAME).

Slide 23: Q22. What other type of health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2024?

- ☐ Insurance through a job (yours or another family member's)
- ☐ Private health insurance not through a job
- ☐ Medicare (including Part B, or any Advantage or Supplemental plans)
- ☐ Medicaid or other government program (CHIP, State Medicaid)
- ☐ Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- ☐ TRICARE or other military health care
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Other

PICK **ONE** PERSON MENTIONED IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION. ADULT OR CHILD – MIX IT UP ACROSS RESPONDENTS BUT CHOOSE MORE ADULTS OVERALL.

Probe (if more than one person selected in Q19): For the household member(s) we didn't ask additional questions about, could you answer this question for them -- what type of insurance did they have?

Slide 24: Q25. How long did Adult 2/Child have this insurance in 2024?

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION (Q22).

- ☐ All year
- ☐ Part of the year

Slide 25: Q20Adult. Was adult 2/Child uninsured at any point in 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

SAME PERSON REFERENCED IN PREVIOUS QUESTIONS (Q22, 25).

WE WANT TO CHECK THAT THEY ANSWERED CORRECTLY SINCE THEY RESPONDED THAT THE PERSON DID NOT HAVE THIS INSURANCE ALL YEAR (BUT WE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT EVERY KIND OF INS THEY HAD).

Probe: Please explain your answer to this question.

MOOP QUESTIONS

Slide 1: MOOP prem. The next questions are about what your household paid for health insurance coverage and other healthcare costs in 2024. In 2024, how much did your household pay for health insurance coverage?

- ☐ \$0–\$199
- ☐ \$200–\$499
- ☐ \$500–\$999
- ☐ \$1,000–\$2,999
- ☐ \$3,000 or more

DID THE INTRODUCTORY STATEMENT HELP THE RESPONDENT (DID THEY READ IT)? DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION IN ITALICS. HOW DO THEY INTERPRET "PAY FOR HEALTH INSURANCE COVERAGE"? ARE THEY ANSWERING FOR THE WHOLE HOUSEHOLD? WOULD IT HAVE BEEN EASIER TO REPORT FOR EACH PERSON? IS ANSWERING FOR THE YEAR THE EASIEST? IF EMPLOYER-BASED INSURANCE, DOES THEIR ANSWER INCLUDE OR EXCLUDE CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE EMPLOYER? HOW DID THEY CALCULATE THE TOTAL COST?

Probes:

- 81 There is a sentence before the question that starts with "The next questions are about...". Did you read this?
- 82 Was this helpful for you when answering the question?
- 83 In the question, explain what "health insurance coverage" means to you. What costs did you think about?
- 84 Did you think about everyone in the household when answering this question?
- 85 Did you read the information in italics?
- 86 Did this help you answer the question?
- 87 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)
- 88 Did you answer for the whole year?
- 89 Would it be easier to answer for a different period of time, other than a year? Please explain.
- 90 (if have insurance through a job) Did your answer include employer contributions to the cost or not?
- 91 (if 2+ people in HH) Would it be easier to answer for each person in your household separately?

Slide 2: Moop nonprem. In 2024, how much did your household pay out-of-pocket for medical care and other non-prescription medical expenses?

\$_____.00 for the year

DID THE RESPONDENT READ THE EXTRA INFORMATION? WAS IT HELPFUL? DID THEY ANSWER FOR THE HOUSEHOLD? DID RESPONDENTS HAVE ANY TROUBLE WITH THIS QUESTION?

Probes:

- 92 Did you read the information in italics, about what to include and not include?
- 93 Did this help you answer the question?
- 94 Were there still things that you weren't sure if you should include or not?
- 95 Did your answer include everyone in the household?
- 96 How did you come up with your answer? (e.g., explain the calculation)

Protocol for Migration

Switch to Migration slide deck and **administer** the probes at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

MIGSTAT1 – Slide 1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

MIGUS1 – Slide 3, Slide 18

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., one year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST1 – Slide 4, Slide 19

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY1 – Slide 5, Slide 20

What county in MIGST_1 did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC1 – Slide 6, Slide 21

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

- If 'Don't Know'
 - Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM1 – Slide 7, Slide 22

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety

- For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM1 – Slide 8, Slide 23

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship

- For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 2, Slide 9, Slide 17

Did anyone else living at your current residence move in within the last year /5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

5-Year Migration

MIGSTAT5 – Slide 10

Were you living at your Current Address five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- This question asks you to think about “5 years ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

MIGUS5 – Slide 11, Slide 24

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, five years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

MIGST5 – Slide 12, Slide 25

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- None

MIGCTY5 – Slide 13, Slide 26

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

MIGPLC5 – Slide 14, Slide 27

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

- If ‘Don’t Know’
 - Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

MIG1RFM5 – Slide 15, Slide 28

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship

- For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?
- Did you read all of the options?
- Were any of the options unclear to you?
- Did you read the help information in italics?
- Were the examples helpful to you?
- Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?
- Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?

- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

MIG2RFM5 – Slide 16, Slide 29

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

- Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes] How did you decide?

- [If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.
- [If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

MIGTOGETH1 – Slide 31, Slide 32

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

MIGTOGETH5 – Slide 33, Slide 34

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[TELL THE RESPONDENT THAT WE COULDN'T FILL THE LIST WITH THE NAMES;
THINK OF THE PEOPLE WHO LIVE IN THE HH NOW]

Probes:

- This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn't list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, "Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today", did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

ScreenersA5 – Slide 35

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last five years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

- None

That's all the questions I have for you. Thank you so much for your help today! I will go ahead and turn off the recorder, and then I'll confirm with you where I am sending the gift card to thank you for your time.

STOP RECORDING

Appendix E. I&O, Income, Poverty, and Migration: Cognitive Protocol

Participant ID	-
Date	-
Time	-
Interviewer	--
Device used: Computer or Phone	-
Recruitment characteristics	-

DOCUMENT INFORMATION FROM RECRUITMENT TRACKER:

Lives with at least 1 person someone	YES/NO
Lives with children under 13 years	YES/NO

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for [RTI], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau. They are observing the interview because they were a part of the team that designed these questions and want to see how they are working.]

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how you come up with your answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO: Can you please open this form in your email?] I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. I will be using a program that records the screen and our voices. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.

- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- Interviews have taken about 60 minutes, on average.
- The form also has the contact's name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.

Any questions?

[SNAG-IT RECORD] AFTER THE RECORDING STARTS, ASK THE PARTICIPANT TO CONFIRM THAT THEY CONSENT TO COMPLETING THE INTERVIEW AND HAVING IT RECORDED.

The purpose of our today's interview is to evaluate how easy or difficult it is to fill out this survey just as you would if you accessed it online. We want to know what works well and what doesn't. This gives us an opportunity to fix any problems. The best way to do this is to Think Aloud as you review the questions and consider your response. This might seem a little unnatural but let me give you an example.

Let's say the question asks, "How many bedrooms are there in your home?" As I think aloud, I would say:

"Well, there are currently two rooms where people are sleeping that would be considered a bedroom. However, we do have a den that might be considered a bedroom as it does have a closet and windows, but I am not sure whether to count this as a bedroom or not. I think I will just go with the two bedrooms that we are sleeping in."

As you can see, the think aloud was helpful as we would find out about the den that could have been considered a bedroom.

OK let's get started.

[IF P LIVES WITH SOMEONE, ASK FOR DETAILS OF HOUSEHOLD ROSTER. THIS INFORMATION IS NEEDED FOR ROUTING PURPOSES IN THE POVERTY PROTOCOL]

Roster information needed for routing purposes in poverty protocol:

- Household size: How many people live in your household?

- Number of children under age 13: How many children under the age of 13 live in your household?
- Number of people age 15 and older: How many people age 15 or older live in your household?
- State of residence: What state do you live in?

I am now going to show my screen and display the questionnaire that we are testing. You should read through the question and tell me your response. I will then guide us to the next question.

Feel free to mention anything confusing or unclear as you think aloud.

Any questions?

[SHARE SCREEN AND DISPLAY FIRST QUESTION OF INCOME INSTRUMENT]

Employment (I&O)

The Employment section is at the start of the interview. The Employment Probes are administered at the end of this section (after slide 28).

In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

Slide 1

Q29a. Did you do any work for pay or profit at any time during 2024, even for one day?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

(NONE. Do not need to test this question – only needed for pathing)

Research Question: Removed help text about military reserves and national guard work. Retest because no respondents in round 1 had military reserves or national guard work.

Universe: Q29a = 2 (If Q29a is No)

Slide 2

Q29b. Did you do any temporary, part-time, or seasonal work, even for one day during 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

[If answered yes] On the previous question, you answered that No, you had not worked at all. But here, you said you did do some temporary or part-time work. Why didn't you answer Yes to the previous question? [Interviewer can show slide 1]

[If answered yes] Would your response to the previous question [slide 1] change if the question asked about work for as little as one hour? For example: "Did you do any work for pay or profit at any time during 2024, even for one hour?"

Are you in the Military Reserves or National Guard? [If yes] Did you include this as work in your response?

Research Question: Changed “on layoff” to “on temporary layoff”. Do respondents mistake “on layoff” for being laid off/fired?

Universe: Q29b = 2 (If Q29b is No, did no work in 2024)

Slide 3

Q30. Did you spend any time trying to find a job or on a temporary layoff during 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

How did you interpret “on temporary layoff”?

This wasn’t in the question but what does the term “on layoff” mean to you?

Research Question: Retest due to no one receiving this question in round 1.

Universe: Q30 = 1 (If Q30 is Yes, trying to find a job or on layoff)

Slide 4

Q31. How many weeks in total were you looking for work or on temporary layoff in 2024?

_____weeks

[] all 52 weeks in 2024

PROBES:

How did you count the number of weeks that you were looking for work?

Research Question: Any additional reasons to consider?

Universe: Q29b = 2 (If Q29b is no, did not work in 2024)

Slide 5

Q32. What was the **main reason** you did not work in 2024?

- ☐ Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern
- ☐ Chronic health condition or disability
- ☐ Retired
- ☐ Pregnancy or childbirth
- ☐ Taking care of children or others
- ☐ Going to school

- ☐ Unable to find work
- ☐ On temporary layoff
- ☐ Not interested in working
- ☐ Some other reason

PROBES:

[If “Some other reason”]: What was the reason?

Did you find any of the response options confusing or have difficulty deciding on a response?

Research Question: Changed response method. Does adding the help text to the response box label affect people’s understanding of the question?

Universe: Q29a = 1 OR Q29b=1 (If Q29a is Yes or Q29b is Yes. They worked.)

Slide 6

Q33. During 2024, how many weeks did you do any work, even for a few hours?

Include paid vacation and sick leave as work.

_____weeks of work, including paid leave

[] all 52 weeks in 2024

PROBES:

Did you read the instruction to count paid vacation/sick leave as work? [If no] did the additional text next to the response box remind you to include this?

Not including vacation or sick leave, did you have a week in 2024 where you did not work the full week? [IF YES: Did you count this week in your answer, or did you exclude this week in your answer?]

Research Question: Testing alternate wording for “on layoff”

Universe: Q33 = 50, 51 (If Q33 equal to 50 or 51 weeks. Worked almost all weeks.)

Slide 7

Q35. Did you lose any full weeks of work in 2024 because you lost a job or were on temporary layoff from a job?

- ☐ Yes

☐ No

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Deleting the total number of hours in a week as an instruction. Same as cog test 1 version.

Universe: Q33 < 50 (If Q33 Less than 50 weeks. Worked less than 50 weeks)

Slide 8

Q36. Of the weeks you were not working, how many full weeks were you looking for a job or on temporary layoff?

_____ weeks

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Same as cog test 1 version. Implemented suggestion to bold “main reason” for emphasis.

Universe: If Q36 is equal to 0 or 1 week. (This is for people who were mostly not looking for work.)

Slide 9

Q38. During the weeks you were not working, what was the **main reason**?

- ☐ Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern
- ☐ Chronic health condition or disability
- ☐ Retired
- ☐ Pregnancy or childbirth
- ☐ Taking care of children or other persons
- ☐ Going to school
- ☐ Not interested in working
- ☐ Some other reason

PROBES:

[If “Some other reason”] what was the reason for not working?

Research Question (Q39a-c): We would like to test splitting out Q39 into multiple questions to better collect data on multiple job holders.

Universe: Q33 >= 1

Slide 10

Q39a. In 2024, did you have more than one job or business?

If you do similar work across multiple clients or apps, count those as one job or business.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

Was the second sentence in italics clear to you?

Did you read this instruction and follow it when answering?

Universe: Q39a = "Yes"

Slide 11

Q39b. How many jobs or businesses did you have in 2024? If you do similar work across multiple clients or apps, count those as one job or business.

- ☐ Two
- ☐ Three or more

PROBES:

Did you have any trouble remembering the number of employers?

[If the respondent mentions participating in gig/platform based work (i.e. Uber, Lyft, Grubhub, etc.)] Since you do gig work, did that make it hard to answer this question? Explain how you counted your jobs.

[If the respondent is self-employed] Since you are self-employed, did that make it hard to answer this question? Explain how you counted your jobs or businesses.

Universe: Q39b = "Two"

Slide 12

Q39c. Did you work at those jobs or businesses at the same time at any point during 2024?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

Did you understand the question?

[If yes] Did you work multiple jobs at the same time for only part of the year? [If yes] please explain how you came up with your answer.

Universe: Q39b = "Three or more"

Slide 13

Q39d. Did you work at any of those jobs or businesses at the same time at any point during 2024?

- ☐ No
- ☐ Yes, at most two at the same time
- ☐ Yes, three or more at the same time

PROBES:

Did you understand the question?

[If yes] Did you have trouble deciding which "yes" option to choose?

Universe: Q33 ge 1

Slide 14

Q41. In the weeks that you worked, how many hours did you usually work per week?

_____ hours

PROBES:

None

Universe: Q41 $\geq$ 35 (Q41 greater or equal to 35 hours.)

Slide 15

Q43. Were there one or more weeks where you worked less than 35 hours?

Do not count time off with pay like holidays, vacation, or sick leave.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Adding “all weeks” check box

Universe: Q41 < 35 OR Q43 = 1 (Q41 if less than 35 hours or Q43 is Yes)

Slide 16

Q44. How many weeks in 2024 did you work less than 35 hours?

_____ weeks

[] all the weeks worked

PROBES:

Was it difficult to remember the number of weeks you worked less than 35 hours?

Did you count weeks where they worked less than 35 hours because you were on paid vacation/sick leave?

Research Question: Changed response options. Added “Going to school” per round 1 suggestion.

Universe: Q41 < 35 OR Q43 = 1 (Q41 if less than 35 hours or Q43 is Yes)

Slide 17

Q45. What was the **main reason** you worked less than 35 hours per week?

- ☐ Could not find a full-time job
- ☐ Job was part-time
- ☐ Seasonal work
- ☐ Business was slow
- ☐ Weather conditions
- ☐ Physically unable to work full time
- ☐ Going to school
- ☐ Caring for family or personal obligation
- ☐ Some other reason

PROBES:

Are any of the response options unclear or confusing?

Did you have trouble selecting a response?

Did multiple options apply for you? [If yes] How did you decide which to choose?

[If "Some other reason"] What was the reason?

Research Question: New question (same as Cog 1). Q45 had 2 responses about reasons for "unable to do full time work" which were combined to one. Here we get the reasons.

Universe: If Q45 = (unable to work full time)

Slide 18Q45a. Why were you physically unable to work full time?

- Injury
- Short-term illness
- Chronic health condition or disability
- Some other reason

PROBES:

Are any of the response options unclear or confusing?

Which option would you use to indicate problems with mental or emotional health?

[If "Some other reason"] What was the reason?

Research Question: Question and answer categories remained the same as cognitive round 1.

Universe: Q33>0

Slide 19

Q47a. What employer did you work for the longest in 2024?

Employer name: _____

PROBES:

[If they work in more than one employer in 2024] how did you determine which employer you worked for the longest?

Research Question: Question and answer categories remained the same as cognitive round 1

Universe: Q33>0

Slide 20

Q47e1. Which best describes this employer or business?

- ☐ Private for-profit company
- ☐ Non-profit organization including tax exempt and charitable organizations
- ☐ Government
- ☐ Self-employed
- ☐ Unpaid family business or farm

PROBES:

Did you know which employer this question was asking about?

Did you think your employer was more than one of these? [If yes] How did you decide which one?

Research Question: Question and answer categories remained the same as cognitive round 1

Universe: Q47e1 = 1 (Q47e1 is Government)

Slide 21

Q47e1a. Which one of the following best describes this government job?

- ☐ Federal - (Federal government civilian employee)
- ☐ Active Duty (U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps)
- ☐ State (including state colleges/universities)
- ☐ Local (county, city, township) (city or county school district)

PROBES:

Did you need the extra information in the parentheses to find the right response?

Research Question: Question and answer categories remained the same as cognitive round 1.

Universe: Q47e1 = 4 or 5 (Q47e1 is self-employed or working in family business)

Slide 22

Q47e1b. Was this business incorporated?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

None

Research Question:

Universe: Q47e1 = 5 (Q47e1 equal working in family business)

Slide 23

Q47e1c. Were you the owner of this business?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Question and answer categories remained the same.

Universe: Q47e1a=4 in local government, or Q47e1 <> 1 (so we are excluding state, fed, and military employers)

Slide 24

Q4788. Counting all locations where this business operated, what was the total number of employees in 2024?

- ☐ 1- 9
- ☐ 10-49
- ☐ 50-99
- ☐ 100-499
- ☐ 500-999
- ☐ 1,000+ or more

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Revising question wording and examples for ISR.

Universe: (simple universe for testing) Q33>0

Slide 25

Q47b. What kind of business or industry was this?

Include the main activity, product, or service provided at the location where employed.
(For example: elementary school, residential construction)

Kind of Business: _____

PROBES:

None

Universe: Q33>0

Slide 26

Q47b1. What was the primary industry of this business?

- ☐ Manufacturing
- ☐ Retail trade
- ☐ Wholesale trade
- ☐ Something else

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Revising question wording and examples for ISR.

Universe: Q33>0

Slide 27

Q47c. What kind of work were you doing at this job or business in 2024?

- ☐ For example: 4th grade teacher, entry-level plumber

Main Occupation: _____

PROBES:

None

Research Question: Revising question wording and examples for ISR.

Universe: Q33>0

Slide 28

Q47d1. What were your most important activities or duties in 2024?

- ☐ For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe sections and review building plans for work details.

Job Duties: _____

PROBES:

None

Income Protocol

The Income section follows the Employment questions, at slide 30, and continues to slide 66.

The Probes are administered concurrently after each question.

In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed. **If a participant is reluctant or unwilling to provide income information anywhere in this section, probe to determine if they would provide the information if they were completing on their own on the web (i.e., not in the interview).**

- *If you were completing this on your own on the web, would you provide this information?*

To begin on the correct path, after issuing probes for Employment, you must know whether someone is (from Q29a/b; Q47e1):

- self-employed from (starts on slide 33),
- employed (employer-based income, starts on slide 30),
- or not employed (no employment income, starts on slide 39).

Earned Income

Main Job – employer-based

Slide 30

EMP_INC_TYP: Select the types of income that you received while working at your employer in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- 97 Salary or wages
- 98 Tips
- 99 Bonuses
- 100 Overtime pay
- 101 Commissions
- 102 Piece rate or pay per item of work

PROBES:

Were any of the answers listed confusing to you?

[If Tips selected] Since you receive tips, did the wording of this question make sense to you?

Slide 31

EMP_INC_AMT: How much did you earn from this employer before taxes and other deductions in 2024?

Include:

- Salary or wages
- Tips
- Bonuses
- Overtime pay
- Commissions
- Piece rate or pay per item of work

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

[If reporting multiple sources] Please describe how you combined the different sources of income to come up with your answer.

Was this difficult for you?

Would you have liked it better if you could have reported each source separately?

Was it difficult for you to report the amount for the whole year?

Are your earnings the same each paycheck? [If not] Would you have liked it better if you could report for a different time period?

There is a sentence about providing your best estimate. Was this helpful? Would you have skipped the question or had more difficulty answering the question if this sentence wasn't there?

Universe: If skipped or didn't know EMP_INC_AMT

Slide 32

EMP_INC_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you earned from this employer before taxes and other deductions in 2024.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 103 | \$0–14,999 |
| 104 | \$15,000–\$29,999 |
| 105 | \$30,000–\$44,999 |
| 106 | \$45,000–\$59,999 |
| 107 | \$60,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Main Job – business or farm

Slide 33

BUS_INC_TYP: Select the types of income that you received from self-employment in 2024.

Select all that apply.

- | | |
|-----|------------------------------------|
| 108 | Salary or wages |
| 109 | Tips |
| 110 | Bonuses |
| 111 | Overtime pay |
| 112 | Commissions |
| 113 | Piece rate or pay per item of work |

PROBES:

Were any of the answers listed confusing to you?

[If Tips selected] Since you receive tips, did the wording of this question make sense to you?

Slide 34

BUS_INC_DESC: What best describes your earnings from self-employment in 2024?

Include:

- Salary or wages
- Tips
- Bonuses
- Overtime pay
- Commissions
- Piece rate or pay per item of work

114 Positive (earnings were greater than expenses)

115 Broke even (earnings and expenses were equal)

116 Loss (earnings were less than expenses)

PROBES:

Did the answer options “positive” and “loss” make sense to you? [If not] Are there other words you might use instead?

Was it easy to answer this for the entire year?

Would you have preferred to answer for a different time frame, like quarterly? Please explain.

Universe: Answered Positive (1) to BUS_INC_DESC

Slide 35

BUS_POS_AMT: How much were your net earnings, before taxes, in 2024?

Net earnings are total earnings minus expenses for the year. If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

Please explain how you came up with your answer.

What income sources did you include in your answer? Do you think you missed any?

Would you have liked to have reported this for some other time period?

There is a sentence about providing your best estimate. Was this helpful? Would you have skipped the question or had more difficulty answering the question if this sentence wasn't there?

Universe: if skip or don't know BUS_POS_AMT

Slide 36

BUS_POS_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you earned from self-employment before taxes in 2024.

Net earnings are total earnings minus expenses for the year.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 117 | \$0–14,999 |
| 118 | \$15,000–\$29,999 |
| 119 | \$30,000–\$44,999 |
| 120 | \$45,000–\$59,999 |
| 121 | \$60,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Slide 37

BUS_NEG_AMT: How much was your net loss before taxes in 2024?

Net loss is total earnings minus expenses for the year. If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

Please explain how you came up with your answer.

Would you have liked to have reported this for some other time period?

There is a sentence about providing your best estimate. Was this helpful? Would you have skipped the question or had more difficulty answering the question if this sentence wasn't there?

Universe: Skipped or didn't know BUS_NEG_AMT

Slide 38

BUS_NEG_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you lost from self-employment before taxes in 2024.

Net loss is total earnings minus expenses for the year.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 122 | \$0–14,999 |
| 123 | \$15,000–\$29,999 |
| 124 | \$30,000–\$44,999 |
| 125 | \$45,000–\$59,999 |
| 126 | \$60,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Income Sources

Unemployment Compensation (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 39

UI_TYP: Select the types of unemployment benefits that you/anyone in the household received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 127 State or Federal unemployment compensation
- 128 Supplemental Unemployment Benefits (SUB)
- 129 Union Unemployment or Strike Benefits
- 130 Someone in the household got unemployment, but I'm not sure what type
- 131 None of the above

PROBES:

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

Did the instruction to not include anything already reported make sense to you?

[If the respondent says "don't know" or indicates uncertainty in think aloud] Does the fourth option, about someone in the household being on some type of unemployment, apply to your household? Why/why not?

Workers Compensation (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 40

WC_TYP: Select the types of worker's compensation payments that you/anyone in this household received as a result of a JOB-RELATED injury or illness in 2024.

Do not include sick pay or disability retirement.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 132 State worker's compensation
- 133 Employer (or employer's insurance) worker's compensation
- 134 Personal worker's compensation
- 135 Other worker's compensation payments
- 136 Someone in the household got worker's compensation, but I'm not sure what type
- 137 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you notice the word "job-related"? What does this mean to you?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (4)] Please explain the "other" type of compensation.

Social Security (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 41

SS_YN: Did you/anyone in this household receive any Social Security payments from the U.S. Government in 2024?

138 Yes

139 No

PROBES:

[if yes and more than 1 person in household] Who received Social Security payments?

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 42

SSI_YN: Did you/anyone in this household receive any SSI payments (Supplemental Security Income) in 2024?

SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons, and come from state or local welfare offices, the Federal government, or both.

Do not include anything you have already reported.

140 Yes

141 No

PROBES:

Did you read the information under the question? [if yes] Was it helpful when answering the question?

Do you know the differences between Social Security and SSI (Supplemental Security Income)?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

Veterans Payments (Source)

Universe: All

Side 43

VA_TYP: Select the types of Veteran Affairs (VA) payments that you/anyone in this household received in 2024.

Include assistance received by children of veterans.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 142 Service-connected disability compensation
- 143 VA survivor benefits
- 144 Veterans Pension (a specific program for lower income veterans; different from a military pension)
- 145 VA educational assistance (including assistance received by children of veterans)
- 146 Other Veterans' payments
- 147 Someone in the household got Veteran's payments, but I'm not sure what type
- 148 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (5)] Please explain your "other" type of payment.

Survivor Benefits (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 44

SUR_TYP: Select all the types of survivor benefits that you/anyone in this household received in 2024.

Survivor benefits provide income as a result of being a widow or widower.

Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or VA survivor benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 149 Company or union survivor pension (include profit sharing)
- 150 Federal government survivor (Civil service) pension
- 151 U.S. Military retirement survivor pension
- 152 State or local government survivor pension
- 153 U.S. Railroad retirement survivor pension
- 154 Worker's compensation survivor pension
- 155 Black Lung survivor pension
- 156 Regular payments from estates or trusts
- 157 Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies
- 158 Other type of survivor benefits
- 159 Someone in the household got survivor benefits, but I'm not sure what type
- 160 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you read all of the response options before deciding on your answer?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If they selected "other" (10)] Please explain your "other" type of survivor benefit.

Public Assistance (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 45

PA_TYP: Select all the types of cash assistance that you/anyone in this household received from a state or county welfare program in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Do not include Food Stamps (SNAP), SSI (Supplemental Security Income), energy assistance, WIC (Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children), free or reduced price school meals, childcare vouchers, or education assistance.

Select all that apply.

- 161 (^State Program Name)/Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)/welfare/Aid to Families
- 162 General Assistance (a state or local program for those with limited means who do not qualify for other types of cash aid)
- 163 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- 164 Diversion payments
- 165 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 166 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 167 Some other program
- 168 Someone in the household got cash assistance, but I'm not sure what type
- 169 None of the above

PROBES:

What came to mind when you read the words "cash assistance"?

Did reading the words "state or county welfare program" change your understanding?

Did you read all of the response options before deciding on your answer?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (7)] Please explain your "other" type of cash assistance.

Pensions (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 46

PEN_TYP: Select the types of pension income that you/anyone in this household received in 2024.

Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

Do not include anything you already reported, like Social Security or Veterans Pensions.

Select all that apply.

- 170 Company
- 171 Union
- 172 Federal government
- 173 State government
- 174 Local government
- 175 U.S. Military
- 176 U.S. Railroad retirement
- 177 Other type of pension
- 178 Someone in the household got pension income, but I'm not sure what type
- 179 None of the above

PROBES:

[if yes and more than 1 person in household] Who received this type(/these types) of pension income?

Did you read all of the response options before deciding on your answer?

There were instructions about what not to include. Were helpful to you?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (8)] Please explain your "other" type of pension income.

Annuities (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 47

ANN_YN: Did you/anyone in this household receive income from an annuity in 2024?

An annuity is a long-term arrangement where payments are made regularly (e.g., monthly) to you because of money you've already paid.

Do not include anything you already reported.

180 Yes

181 No

PROBES:

[if yes] Where is your annuity from?

(e.g., what company or broker?)

Did you read the information in italics? [if yes] Was this helpful to you?

Are you familiar with annuities and how they are different from other types of income such as pensions, Social Security, or retirement accounts?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

Retirement Accounts (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 48

RET_TYP: Select the types of financial accounts that you/anyone in this household had in 2024 that were specifically to save for retirement.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 182 401(k)
- 183 403(b)
- 184 Roth IRA
- 185 Traditional IRA
- 186 KEOGH plan
- 187 SEP plan (Simplified Employee Pension)
- 188 Other type of retirement account
- 189 Someone in the household has) a retirement account, but I'm not sure what type
- 190 None of the above

PROBES:

[if yes and more than 1 person in household] Who had this(/these) retirement account(s)?

Did you notice the words: "specifically to save for retirement"? [if yes] How did you interpret this?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (7)] Please explain your "other" type of account.

Income-Earnings Accounts Outside of Retirement (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 49

INT_TYP: Select the types of accounts that you/anyone in this household had that may have paid interest in 2024.

Do not include retirement accounts or anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 191 Interest-earning checking account
- 192 Savings account
- 193 Money market fund
- 194 CD (certificate of deposit)
- 195 Savings bond
- 196 Other savings or investments that pay interest
- 197 Someone in the household has an interest-earning account, but I'm not sure what type
- 198 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If the respondent says "don't know" or indicates uncertainty in think aloud] Does the 7th option, about someone in the household having some type of interest-earning account, apply to your household? Why/why not?

[If selected "other" (6)] Please explain your "other" type of account.

[If they selected "none" (8)] You answered None. Do you have any bank accounts? [If yes] Does these accounts earn any interest at all, even if it's a small amount?

Dividends

Universe: All

Slide 50

DIV_TYP: Select the types of assets that you/anyone in this household had that paid dividends in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 199 Shares of stock in corporations
- 200 Mutual funds
- 201 Other savings or investments that pay dividends (such as index funds or ETFs)
- 202 Someone in the household has an asset that pays dividends, but I'm not sure what type
- 203 None of the above

PROBES:

Do you understand the difference between dividends and interest?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (3)] Please explain your "other" type of dividend.

[If the respondent says "don't know" or indicates uncertainty in think aloud] Does the fourth option, about someone in the household having something that pays dividends, apply to your household? Why/why not?

Property Income (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 51

PROP_TYP: Select the types of property income that you/anyone in this household received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 204 Income from a rental property (^you/they) do not reside in
- 205 Income from roomers or boarders at a property (^you/they) reside in
(exclude amounts paid by relatives)
- 206 Income from estates or trusts
- 207 Royalties
- 208 None of the above

PROBES:

Did the instruction to not include anything already reported make sense to you?

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

Education Assistance (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 52

HIED_YN: In 2024, did you/anyone in this household attend school beyond the high school level including a college, university, vocational, business, or trade school?

- 209 Yes
- 210 No

PROBES:

Was the phrase "beyond the high school level" clear to you?

Universe: If answered Yes to HIED_YN

Slide 53

EDASST_TYP: Select the types of educational assistance that you/anyone in this household received for tuition, fees, books, or living expenses in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported, like VA educational benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 211 Pell Grant
- 212 Assistance from a welfare or social service office
- 213 Other government assistance
- 214 Scholarships, grants, etc.
- 215 Other assistance (employers, family, friends, etc.)
- 216 Someone in the household got educational assistance, but I'm not sure what type
- 217 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (3 or 5)] Please explain the "other" type of assistance you received.

[If the respondent says "don't know" or indicates uncertainty in think aloud] Does the sixth option, about someone in the household having some type of education assistance, apply to your household ? Why/why not?

Child Support (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 54

CSUP_YN: In 2024, did you/anyone in this household receive any child support payments?

- 218 Yes
- 219 No

Regular Financial Assistance (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 55

RFA_YN: In 2024, did you/anyone in this household receive any other regular financial assistance from friends or relatives not living in this household?

Do not include amounts that must be paid back.

Do not include anything you already reported.

220 Yes

221 No

PROBES:

Did you read the instructions about what not to include?

Other Money Income (Source)

Universe: All

Slide 56

OTH_TYP: Select the types of other income that you/anyone in this household received in 2024.

Do not include anything you already reported.

Select all that apply.

- 222 Income from Alaska Permanent Fund
- 223 Income from foster child care
- 224 Income from alimony
- 225 Income from jury duty
- 226 Income from armed forces reserves
- 227 Income from severance pay
- 228 Income from hobbies
- 229 Income from other sources
- 230 None of the above

PROBES:

Did you have trouble deciding on a response? [if yes] Were there response options that you didn't understand?

In option 7, what does "hobbies" mean to you?

How easily could you answer this question for yourself?

(If there are others in the HH): If we were to ask you this question separately for each household member, how easy or difficult would it be to answer this for other people living in your household?

[If selected "other" (8)] Please explain your "other" source of income

Income Amounts

Slide 57

Use this slide to jump to the first relevant section, depending on what the R answered above.

We only want to ask the following amount questions if the respondent indicated they were the one that received a specific type of income or held retirement accounts themselves. This means you need to record responses to the questions on the slides listed below AND the response to the follow-up probe on these items that asks the participant to report who in the HH received this income/had these accounts to correctly path once in this section.

- Social Security payments, asked on slide 41
- Pension income, asked on slide 46
- Retirement accounts, asked on slide 48

Note that if the respondent selected anything on slide 48, they get both Retirement withdrawals and interest/dividends questions. Slide 48 only asks if the participant (or anyone in the HH) have these retirement accounts but **does not** confirm if the participant withdrew or received interest/dividends from these accounts. This is intentional, and RET_DIST_AMT and RET_INT_AMT should still be asked even if participants may report '0'.

The "Next" links for the questions below will bring you back to this slide repeatedly to select another income amount for testing.

If there is no more income to ask about, click "Done with income amounts" on slide 57.

Social Security (Amounts)

Universe: SS_YN = Yes

Slide 58

SS_AMT: How much did you receive in Social Security payments in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

[if answered] Did you know the exact amount or did you estimate?

[if estimated] Would you have provided an estimate without the instructions that doing so was okay?

[if exact] Did you round or fudge your answer a little?

[Do other people in household have this type of income?] Would you be able to provide this amount for the other people/person in the household? Would that be a fairly accurate amount or a rough estimate?

Universe: if the respondent didn't know or skipped SS_AMT

Slide 59

SS_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much (^you/name) earned from Social Security before taxes in 2024.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 231 | \$0-\$999 |
| 232 | \$1,000-\$4,999 |
| 233 | \$5,000-\$9,999 |
| 234 | \$10,000-\$19,999 |
| 235 | \$20,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Pensions (Amounts)

Universe: If any selected in PEN_TYP

Slide 60

PEN_AMT: How much did you receive from your pension in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

[if answered] Did you know the exact amount or did you estimate?

[if estimated] Would you have provided an estimate without the instructions that doing so was okay?

[if exact] Did you round or fudge your answer a little?

[Do other people in household have this type of income?] Would you be able to provide this amount for the other people/person in the household? Would that be a fairly accurate amount or a rough estimate?

Universe: if the respondent didn't know or skipped PEN_AMT

Slide 61

PEN_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you earned from your pension before taxes in 2024.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 236 | \$0-\$999 |
| 237 | \$1,000-\$4,999 |
| 238 | \$5,000-9,999 |
| 239 | \$10,000-\$19,999 |
| 240 | \$20,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Withdrawals/Distributions from Retirement Accounts (Amounts)

Universe: Any selected in RET_TYP

Slide 62

RET_DIST_AMT: How much did you receive from withdrawals and distributions from your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

[if answered] Did you know the exact amount or did you estimate?

[if estimated] Would you have provided an estimate without the instructions that doing so was okay?

[if exact] Did you round or fudge your answer a little?

[Do other people in household have this type of income?] Would you be able to provide this amount for the other people/person in the household? Would that be a fairly accurate amount or a rough estimate?

Universe: if the respondent didn't know or skipped RET_DIST_AMT

Slide 63

RET_DIST_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you earned from withdrawals and distributions for your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024.

- | | |
|-----|-------------------|
| 241 | \$0-\$999 |
| 242 | \$1,000-\$4,999 |
| 243 | \$5,000-\$9,999 |
| 244 | \$10,000-\$19,999 |
| 245 | \$20,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Interest/Dividends on Retirement Accounts (Amounts)

Universe: Any selected in RET_TYP

Slide 64

RET_INT_AMT: How much did you receive from interest or dividends on your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024?

If you are not sure, please provide your best estimate.

\$ _____.00

PROBES:

[if answered] Did you know the exact amount or did you estimate?

[if estimated] Would you have provided an estimate without the instructions that doing so was okay?

[if exact] Did you round or fudge your answer a little?

[Do other people in household have this type of income?] Would you be able to provide this amount for the other people/person in the household? Would that be a fairly accurate amount or a rough estimate?

Universe: if the respondent didn't know or skipped RET_INT_AMT

Slide 65

RET_INT_RNG: Select a range that indicates how much you received from interest and dividends from your retirement accounts before taxes in 2024.

- | | |
|-----|-----------------|
| 246 | \$0–\$99 |
| 247 | \$100–\$499 |
| 248 | \$500–\$999 |
| 249 | \$1,000–\$2,999 |
| 250 | \$3,000 or more |

PROBES:

[If provided an answer] Why did you provide a range rather than answer the previous question asking for a specific amount?

[If did not provide answer] Please explain why you did not answer this question.

Were these ranges too small or large? Please explain.

Poverty Protocol

The Poverty section follows income, on slide 67.

We are using a split-path approach for this test—one for low-income households, and one for everyone else. The paths come back together for the housing, school lunch, child care, and child support questions.

The Probes are administered at the end of this section. In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

Note any questions where the help (?) was requested.

To navigate the skips, you must know the following. This is asked at the start of the interview.:

- Household size
- number of children 13 years old and under
- number of people 15 or older
- State of residence.

Note that there are 8 states that lead to different versions of the question. These align with the cities where recruitment will take place. If the person is not from any of these states, there is a generic version of the question that does not reference a state assistance program.

Universe: All

Slide 67

INC_EST

Which category represents your household income before taxes in 2024?

Household income includes money from jobs, net income from business, farm or rent, pensions, dividends, interest, social security payments, and any other money income received.

If you don't know the amount, please estimate.

- | | |
|-----|-----------------------|
| 251 | \$0-\$34,999 |
| 252 | \$35,000 - \$49,999 |
| 253 | \$50,000 - \$69,999 |
| 254 | \$70,000 - \$89,999 |
| 255 | \$90,000 - \$119,999 |
| 256 | \$120,000 - \$150,000 |
| 257 | \$150,000 or more |

Pathing:

If 1 person in household and they pick 1 here, go to SNAP_YN (Path 1 – Low income)

If more than one person in household and they pick 1, 2, or 3, go to SNAP_YN (Path 1 – Low income)

Else, go to NCREC

PROBES:

(None. Do not need to test this question – only needed for pathing)

Path 1- Low Income

Universe for Path 1:

If INC_EST = 1 and the number of people in the household equals 1, or

If INC_EST in (1, 2, 3) and the number of people in the household is greater than 1

Food assistance

Slides 68–76

SNAP_YN

The next questions are about food assistance programs.

At any time during 2024, EVEN FOR ONE MONTH, did anyone in this household receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program), the Food Stamp program, [state program fill,/blank] or use a SNAP, food stamp, or [state card fill] benefit card?

Do not include WIC or TANF.

258 Yes

259 No

Pathing:

Go To: WIC_YN

PROBES:

Did you notice the instruction “even for one month”?

Are SNAP, the Food Stamp program, and the state assistance program the same thing to you, or different programs?

The name of the state’s benefit card was provided. Was this helpful to you?

Did you know what WIC or TANF were?

(If No and did not ask for (?) help text) Did you see that the question mark symbol was offering help information?

(if yes) Why didn't (ask me to) click the help information?

WIC

Slide 78

WIC_YN

At any time during 2024, was anyone in this household on WIC, the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children?

260 Yes

261 No

Pathing:

If yes, go to WIC_MNTH

Else, go to: ENG_ASST_YN

PROBES:

This question provides the full name of WIC. Was this confusing to you?

Did you have trouble deciding if this question applied to you or not?

Slide 79

WIC_MNTH

For how many months was WIC received in 2024?

___ months

Pathing:

Go to: ENG_ASST_YN

PROBES:

This question just said "WIC" and not the full name. Was this confusing to you?

Did you want to report a different number of months for different people in the household?

Energy Assistance

Slide 80

ENG_ASST_YN:

The government has several energy assistance programs that help pay heating or cooling costs. This assistance can be received directly by the household, or it can be paid directly to the electric company, gas company, or fuel dealer. It may also show up as a reduction on your gas or electric bill, or as a separate one-time check.

In 2024, did your household receive energy assistance of this type from the federal, state, or local government?

262 Yes

263 No

Pathing:

Go to: TENURE

PROBES:

This question has a big block of text before the actual question. Did you read this information?

Was it helpful to you?

Would you have preferred to get this information a different way?

Do you think of energy, heating, and cooling assistance as one thing or separate things?

Would you have answered this question differently if we had included "heating and cooling" in the question, as well as "energy"?

Path 2- Not Low Income

Universe for Path 2:

Not in universe for path 1. Specifically:

If number of people in the household = 1 and INC_EST gt 1, or

If number of people in the household is more than 1 and INC_EST ge 4

Slides 81, 83, 85, 87, 89, 91, 93, 95, 97 (depending on state)

NCREC

The next question is about assistance programs.

At any time during 2024, even for one month, did anyone in this household receive any of the following?

SNAP/Food stamps

WIC

Energy/heating/cooling assistance

Pathing:

If yes on WIC:

Go to WIC_MNTH2

Else:

Go to TENURE

PROBES:

Did you have any trouble answering whether your household receives these benefits or not?

Did you have any trouble with the question's format, with the Yes/No options for each?

(note if they tried to access the help text)

WIC

Slide 101

WIC_MNTH2

For how many months was WIC received in 2024?

___ months

Pathing:

If said yes to energy assistance on NCREC, go to ENG_ASST_AMT2

Else, go to NUMROOMS

PROBES:

This question just said "WIC" and not the full name. Was this confusing to you?

Did you want to report different numbers of months for different people in the household?

Housing

Universe:

Slide 102

TENURE

Are your living quarters...

264 Owned or being bought by you or someone in your household?

265 Rented for cash?

266 Occupied without payment of cash rent?

Pathing:

Go to NUMROOMS

PROBES:

(No need to probe this question. It's a CPS question used for pathing.)

Universe:

Slides 103–105

NUMROOMS

You reported that [you own or are buying your home/rent/live in quarters without paying cash rent]. The next questions are about that property.

How many separate bedrooms does your property contain?

Count as bedrooms those rooms you would list if this property were for sale or rent. If this is an efficiency/studio apartment, enter 0.

___ bedrooms

Pathing:

If owns home, go to MORT_YN

Else: go to PUBHOUSE_YN

PROBES:

Did you understand that “property” means the place where you live or were you thinking of something else?

Did you read the instructions in italics? (if yes) Were they clear to you?

Slide 106

MORT_YN

Which of these loans does anyone in this household have on this property?

Select all that apply.

- 267 Mortgage or similar
- 268 Second mortgage
- 269 Home equity loan
- 270 None—own home free and clear of any mortgages

Pathing:

If household has children 5-18 years old, go to SMEAL_YN

Else if there are children 13-years old or younger in the household, go to CHCARE_YN

Else, go to CHSUP_YN

PROBES:

Did you have any trouble choosing between the different answer choices?

Do you feel that you know the difference between the different mortgages and home loans?

Slide 107

PUBHOUSE_YN

Is this residence public housing?

Public housing is owned by a local housing authority or other public agency.

271 Yes

272 No

Pathing:

If no: Go to RENT_ASST_YN

If yes:

If there are children 13 and under in the household, go to CHCARE_PAID

Else go to CHSUP_YN

Slide 108

RENT_ASST_YN

Are you paying lower rent because the Federal, State, or local government is paying part of the cost?

273 Yes

274 No

Pathing:

If there are children 13 or under in the household, go to CHCARE_PAID

Else go to CHSUP_YN

Child Care

Programming Note:

This section should only go to households with any children age 13 and under.

Slide 109, Slide 116

CHCARE_PAID

The next questions are about child care for children 13 and under. [Blank/Please answer these questions for your youngest child].

In 2024, which type(s) of paid care were routinely used [blank/for your youngest child] while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

This does not include care arranged on short notice due to an emergency, sick child, etc.

Select all that apply.

- 275 Child care center/preschool/nursery school
- 276 Home-based daycare
- 277 Paid care by a nanny, babysitter, family, friends, or neighbors
- 278 Before and/or after-school care
- 279 Summer/day/school break camps
- 280 Other
- 281 None - did not pay for child care

Pathing:

Go to CHCARE_UNPAID

PROBES:

This question asks about time when parents or guardians are working. How did you interpret the word “working” in this question?

Would your answer change if the question asked about “working for pay or profit?”

Does employment mean the same thing as work to you?

Did you have trouble picking an answer?

(If responded “other”) What type of other child care were you thinking of?

Were there other types of childcare you wanted to report?

Slide 110, Slide 117

CHCARE_UNPAID

In 2024, which type(s) of free or unpaid care were routinely used for your youngest child while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

This does not include care arranged on short notice due to an emergency, sick child, etc.

Select all that apply.

- 282 Care by you or another parent/guardian at home
- 283 Head Start
- 284 Pre-Kindergarten
- 285 Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- 286 Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- 287 Other
- 288 None - no free child care was used

Pathing:

Go to CHCARE_MAIN

PROBES:

Did you have trouble picking an answer?

(If responded "other") What type of other child care were you thinking of?

Were there other types of childcare you wanted to report?

Slide 111, Slide 118

CHCARE_MAIN

In 2024, what was the main type of child care used for your youngest child while one or both of their parents or guardians were working, at school or training, or looking for work?

- 289 Child care center/preschool/nursery school
- 290 Home-based daycare
- 291 Paid care by a nanny, babysitter, family, friends, or neighbors
- 292 Before and/or after-school care
- 293 Summer/day/school break camps
- 294 Care by you or another parent/guardian at home
- 295 Head Start
- 296 Pre-Kindergarten
- 297 Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- 298 Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- 299 Other
- 300 No child care

Pathing:

If no child care, go to CH_SUP

If there is one child 13 and under in the household, go to CHCARE_SUB

If there are multiple children 13 and under in the household who used childcare, go to CHCARE_REP

Slide 112

CHCARE_SUB

In 2024, was any of your child's care fully or partially covered by a voucher or child care subsidy?

301 Yes

302 No

Pathing:

Go to CHCARE_PROB

PROBES:

Do you know what a subsidy is?

Slide 113, Slide 121

CHCARE_PROB

In 2024, did anyone in this household have to work less, or could not work more or at all, because they had trouble finding child care (paid or free)?

Select all that apply.

303 Yes, had to work less

304 Yes, could not work more

305 Yes, could not work at all

306 No

Pathing:

Go to CHCARE_ADAPT_YN

PROBES:

How did you interpret the phrase “have to work less, or could not work more or at all”?

What did you think about when you read this phrase?

Slide 114, Slide 122

CHCARE_ADAPT_YN

At any time in 2024, was child care unavailable, closed, unaffordable, or not safe for [the child/any of the children] in your household?

307 Yes

308 No

Pathing:

If yes go to CHCARE_ADAPT_WAY

Else go to CHSUP_YN

PROBES:

What situations did you think about when you answered this question?

Were these situations times when you planned to be working, looking for work, or in school?

Slide 115, Slide 123

CHCARE_ADAPT_WAY

When child care was unavailable, closed, unaffordable, or unsafe, what actions did the adults in the household take to provide care for the [child/children]?

Select all that apply.

309 Took unpaid leave

310 Used vacation, sick days, or other paid leave

311 Cut or changed work hours

312 Quit a job

313 Missed work and was fired from a job

314 Did not look for a job

315 Supervised one or more children while working

316 Other

317 None of the above

Pathing:

Go to CHSUP_YN

PROBES:

Were you looking for a response that wasn't listed?

Slide 119

CHCARE_REP

What is easiest way for you to report how much your household spent on childcare in 2024?

318 Cost for each child separately

319 Cost for all children together

Pathing:

Go to NEW CHCARE

PROBES:

Did this question make sense to you?

How did you decide on your answer?

Slide 120

NEW CHCARE

Please estimate how much your household spent on childcare in 2024.

You may estimate for each child separately or all children together.

Pathing:

Go to CHCARE_PROB

PROBES:

What problems did you have coming up with your answer?

If you had to answer this question the other way (for all children, or for each child), how difficult would that have been?

(Note if they reported wanting to answer per child or for all children together and then did the opposite for this question).

Child Support

Slides 124–125

CHSUP_YN

In 2024, did [you/anyone in this household] pay child support for children living elsewhere?

Child support payments are made to the parent or legal guardian providing most of the child's care. Do not include college expenses unless this is part of a legal agreement.

320 Yes

321 No

322 Not applicable

Pathing:

End of survey

PROBES:

Did you read the extra information in italics?

(if yes) was it helpful?

(if no) looking at it now, would it have changed your answer?

(If they selected not applicable) Please explain why this wasn't applicable to you.

(do you have any children over 18? If yes) Did you consider any expenses for these children when you answered this question?

Migration Protocol

The Migration protocol is administered after the Poverty protocol, and picks up on slide 127.

The Probes are administered at the end of this section.

In addition to scripted probes, make general observations of trouble understanding the question and probe on those problems as needed.

1 Year Mover

Universe:

Slide 127

MIGSTAT1

Were you living at your current residence 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

This question asks you to think about “1 year ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 1 year ago? For example, Were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2024?

Slide 129, Slide 144

MIGUS1

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, D.C., 1 year ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

Slide 130, Slide 145

MIGST1

What state did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

None

Slide 131, Slide 146

MIGCTY1

What county did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

[If 'Don't Know'] Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

Slide 132, Slide 147

MIGPLC1

What city did you/they live in 1 year ago today?

Probes:

[If 'Don't Know'] Please explain why you are having trouble answering this question

Slide 133, Slide 148

MIG1RFM1

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates

- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 1 year ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?

Did you read all of the options?

Were any of the options unclear to you?

Did you read the help information in italics?

Were the examples helpful to you?

Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?

Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?

[If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

Slide 134, Slide 149

MIG2RFM1

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship

- For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for the move? [If yes]
How did you decide?

[If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

[If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your "main" and "other" reasons.

Slide 128, Slide 135, Slide 143

MIGTOGETH1_NOMOVE (128)/MIGTOGETH1_MOVER (135)/MIGTOGETH5 (143)

Did anyone (else) living at this residence move in within the (last year/5 years)?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

None

5-Year Migration

Universe:

Slide 136

MIGSTAT5

Were you living at your current Address 5 years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

This question asks you to think about “5 years ago today”. Would it have been easier for you to answer if the question included the date for 5 years ago? For example, were you living at your current residence on [July/Aug] [Day] 2020?

Slide 137, Slide 150

MIGUS5

Were you/they living in the 50 United States or Washington, DC, 5 years ago today?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

Was the description “in the 50 United States or Washington, DC” clear? [If not] What would make more sense to you?

Slide 138, Slide 151

MIGST5

What state did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

None

Slide 139, Slide 152

MIGCTY5

What county did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

Probes:

[If 'Don't Know'] Did you forget the county name, or is it that you never knew it?

Slide 140, Slide 153

MIGPLC5

What city did you/they live in 5 years ago today?

[If 'Don't Know'] Please explain why you had trouble answering this question

Slide 141, Slide 154

MIG1RFM5

What was your/their main reason for moving to your current residence?

- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing

- *For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)*
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
 - For example: feeling unsafe in your community, high crime rates
- Legal or institutional
 - For example: re-entry from prison, foster care, court-mandated relocation, change in visa or residency requirements
- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

This question asks about your current residence, which may be different from where you lived 5 years ago. Were you thinking about your current residence when you answered this question?

Did you read all of the options?

Were any of the options unclear to you?

Did you read the help information in italics?

Were the examples helpful to you?

Did you have difficulty deciding on one main reason for move? [If yes] How did you decide?

Was your reason for moving, sensitive in nature? [If yes] Were you uncomfortable reporting your reason, using these categories?

[If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

What was another reason for moving to your current residence?

- No other reason
- Family
 - For example: birth of child, help parent, divorce, death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - For example: unmarried partner, live with friend, conflict with roommate
- Work
 - For example: commute, spouse's new job, unemployed, armed forces, retired
- Education or training
 - For example: college, trade school, internship
- Housing hardship
 - For example: high housing cost, foreclosure, eviction, homelessness, landlord problems, building issues
- Better-suited housing
 - For example: found less expensive housing, wanted to own home, down-sizing, upgrade (such as garage, pool, or yard)
- Better-suited neighborhood, cultural amenities, or lifestyle
 - For example: desirable school district, wanted bigger/smaller city, nightlife, change of scenery
- Crime or safety
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- Health
 - For example: injury, no stairs, assisted living, exited rehabilitation, pollution
- Natural disasters or risk of natural disaster
 - For example: hurricane or tornado damage, flooding, wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or natural environment
 - For example: warmer temperatures, distinct seasons, close to ocean
- Other, specify

Probes:

Did you have difficulty deciding on only one additional reason for your move? [If yes]
How did you decide?

[If R selected 'Other'] Please explain your "other" reason for move and why it didn't fit into the listed categories.

[If R selected same answer as Main reason] Please explain why chose the same reason as your “main” and “other” reasons.

Slide 157, 158

MIGTOGETH1you (157,158)

Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn’t fill the list with the names;

think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn’t list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, “Who from the list below lived with you 1 year ago today”, did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

Slide 159, Slide 160

MIGTOGETH5

Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today?

[tell the respondent that we couldn’t fill the list with the names;

think of the people who live in the HH now]

Probes:

This question was a little hard to answer because we couldn’t list the other people in your household. However, looking at the question itself, “Who from the list below lived with you 5 years ago today”, did you have any trouble understanding what this question was asking?

Slide 161

ScreenenerA5/MIGTOGETH5

Did anyone living at your current residence move in within the last 5 years?

- Yes
- No

Probes:

None

Thank you, those are all the questions that I have. Do you have any other thoughts or comments that I did not cover, that you would like to share now?

[TURN OFF THE RECORDER]

[PROVIDE P INFORMATION ON RECEIVING \$40 INCENTIVE – SEND OUT INCENTIVE EMAIL AND UPDATE CASE IN TRACKER TO “COMPLETE”]